Aam Zindagi!

Adarsh Anand

For, my parents,
Mr. Shambhu Prasad and Mrs. Shobha Devi, Who gave me the sky to fly and the soil to stay grounded. This book is but a small reflection of the capability you carved within me.

© Adarsh Anand, 2026. All Rights Reserved.

No part of this book electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or by any other means,
may be republished, stored, or transmitted without the prior written permission of the author.

This book is an original work of the author. All works, poems, lines, ghazals, etc., used herein are entirely the author's own writing. Any resemblance to any actual event, place, or person is purely coincidental.

Complete Volume, 2026

Unauthorized distribution, uploading, or sharing is prohibited.



1. Thy midst conflict!

Atheist Navalkishor sat drowned in worry for dowry, beside his beloved, theist wife, both consumed by thoughts of their daughter Lajwanti's impending marriage. Dowry gnawed at him like a rat at grain. He lay stretched upon a woven cot, calculating losses, when suddenly a celestial voice cracked from the sky!

"Behold! Siyaram Babu hath fallen! Daya Singh hath spilled the sacred blood!"

The news struck before sense could brace itself. The cot, startled as its master, flung Navalkishor down as though offended by such tidings. He tumbled, or rather was pushed by cot itself, clutching his dhoti in panic, head toward the voice that had spoken shit like thunder.

Kishor shouted upward in wrath: "What foul nonsense do you utter, you cursed mouth?"
"I speak truth, Kaka!" Akash Kumar was the walking radio of that runaway. Flesh, fact and frequency in one body.

Navalkishor had no choice but to believe. A voice from the person like walking clouds, could not lie. And who else would dare spit such blasphemy about Siyaram Babu? Actually, Navalkishor's father had four brothers. As the son of the middle brother, Navalkishor now stood as the sole elder after Siyaram Da. Interestingly, Siyaram Babu was both the eldest and the shortest son. Yet. No instrument had yet been invented capable of measuring his stature within the lineage. And to speak of Siyaram Babu's death was no small audacity. No one dares to raise eyes upon him.

Low caste by birth, yet he kept *Brahmins* and *kshatriya* under water. A walking contradiction. A living insult to social superior supremacy.

thundering like thunderbolt, Navalkishor vanished into the air, with younger brothers Lochan and Sulochan rushing behind him, bound by blood and reflex.

The scene resembled a decorated cinema hall. Spectators strained their eyes to imprint that dreadful spectacle. Fear and pleasure fought for space in their chests. Now you may ask, where lies pleasure in this? and which is why, you must know, this land is called as *Marghat*, the cremation ground, and it lies within *Brahmin* territory. Naturally, no *Chamar* dares to hover here. How could they? If a Chamar dared wash his face here, he would be forced to wash his hands with his feet.

Yet there lay Siyaram Babu. Even in death, pride perched upon his curled moustaches. His face was a mask of gore, yet it carried a strange, kingly aura. His wide, ruptured eyes declared that he had been the *tandava* of his own end and did not blink. He had been struck by a double-barrel gun; a weapon whose roar makes even the soul of the breath, tremble. The wounds whispered a dark tally; every high-caste rival he had humbled in life had now come to collect their debt, bullet-by-bullet. Into the river of the *Marghat*, a small tributary of blood was slowly merging, staining the water a deep, vengeful rust.

Navalkishor stood over the body, his atheist heart screaming for a god he didn't believe in just so he could curse Him. His veins were swelling like serpents. The upper caste had waited for this very day for so longer. Navalkishor knew it would come. But what stood heavier now, your midst conflict! vengeance for his brother or the burden of his daughter's wedding?

Yet men is men. being eldest of the kin and left without a challenge,. In case Siyaram Babu's spirit falls over on ground, will first settle accounts with him. The elder brother may have departed, but fear of him always thrives immortal.

Kishor swelled his veins upon his necks and roared. "Come forth, you runaway Daya, born of a half mother! Where hast you fled, you lecher? Hadst you been a man, you wouldst have stayed and faced me. Hear me well, you eunuch. By staining my brother's blood upon this soil, you hast sealed your doom. I swear upon this holy soul, until your lineage is erased, I shall yet draw breath."

But words alone do not carve marks. When aim is loosed, a sign must follow! Kishor scanned left and right. the fruit of a second wife, Dani Singh, stood staring. Had he been older, he might have fought back with the strength of a hero. But in this moment, the script was already written... the bow rested in Kishor's hands. He seized Dani and offered him to the river of *Marghat* as donation.

This entire incident was born of casteism. Yet those of Dani's own caste stood frozen like hollow pictures hanging on a wall, They watched in a paralyzed trance drifting him away. And so I said the cinema hall was prepared, and the audience was....

Even though Dani's blood, before Siyaram Babu's, felt raw and unripe. Yet pride swelled within Navalkishor. He had lost a brother equal to a father, and the one who is responsible for so would also find no cause to celebrate. Anyways, with broad shoulders, he carried his brother's corpse home. And gave him a divine cot for ultimate sleep with his rounded moustache.

There, Nunuram, Siyaram Da's younger son, found his father lying on the cot, he assumed, he was sleeping. He began demanding money.

Since Nunu's day begins by eating shop goods, so Sulochan took him to the shop. Now why would then the child had any interest to know what calamity had just arrived? But, the elder son, was quite sensible to understand underscores, still elder then him, elder pupils were already performing elder acts and making elderly noise. His role was singular, to light the funeral fire. Also either to learn or burn his elder's teachings.
After them all, Agarbati, Siyaram Babu's beloved with the women were performing their chorus of grief.

Alas! Where wedding shehnais were meant to echo, the house now sat in mourning. It is true that except the white skinned caste, the entire village offered Siyaram Babu's thirteenth day rites. your were society's ideal, they said. The whole village came to bid farewell.
Why would they not? When one lives in water and dares enmity with a crocodile, even fish feel waves of masculinity. And he himself was a crocodile. Now that he has perished, I believe more than affection or respect, their fear ruled their hearts seemingly more.

And why don't they fear, after all who shall now begin the second chapter of Siyaram Rai and breathe courage into the lungs of these petty fishes?

Elsewhere, Dani Singh's bloated corpse drained the moisture from Daya Singh's eyes and replaced it with boiling blood. Bloodshed was his ancestral trade. Upon performing Dani's cremation, Daya felt a cold fire ignite within.

And thus, he begins the second chapter of the murderous game. Where one death births another. Where every drop of blood rewrites the same ancient history. Where the final clash between Navalkishor and Daya Singh shall drown the village in such a chaos that its ashes shall not cool for decades!

***

2. Great Grand Ally!

The groom's side was restless for marriage, led by the matchmaker Bhulo Mahto, a man perfectly suited to his name. No teeth in his mouth, nor any strength in his belly, yet at a feast he ate like a seasoned conqueror. The way he gulped and gobbled, empty gums clapping lap lap, left no equal and no rival.

Along with other relatives, Narayan Babu had arrived, bringing his son, our groom-king Ramprasad. Wheat toned skin, fair enough height, a well-knit frame, a straight nose, and on his plump cheek a lone mole that pulls attention anonymously. All eyes lingered on Ramprasad, staring without blinking. Yet his gaze was suspended, fixed on a single hour.

Here, The hour arrived.

Lajwanti entered. Lotus eyes, a round fair face, cheeks forever brushed with a natural blush, a full and blooming form. Eyes were stolen away from the groom-king and chained to her instead. Beautiful, said the inner voice. The romantic poet within him began to recite silently within.

In my eyes a heady wine has flowed,
In every face I see but your shadow bestowed.
From your modest grace drips a fragrance of rose,
As if within your being my very soul repose.

Love turned competitive and poetry joined the fray.

Is it the *sari* that is fair or do you appear so?
What fortune the cloth bears, clinging unto you so close.
Each limb adorned with tender care and grace,
These *baalis*, that *kazal*, and this little *bindi* placed.
Hast you resolved to strike me dead outright?
Pink *sari*, dark tresses, lips curved in light.
Tell me yourself, beloved divine,
How shall I live, if you be not mine?

Ramprasad decided at first sight. If marriage happened, then with her or else shell thrive barren. He bridled the stallion of youth within, striving to appear composed. Only his eyes strayed again and again, losing their path in the veil's edge, where sunlight filtered and painted her cheeks with a sacred glow. Whose fortune shall it be, he wondered, in whose home she shall arrive as Lakshmi herself. Not Ramprasad, but his sophisticated eyes saw and thoughtfully think.

Meanwhile Bhulo Mahto tested Lajwanti's civility with his old tactics. Write your name in Hindi, now in English. The moment was usual until when, Ramprasad caught the words which Lajwanti never spoke. He signaled Narayan Babu. Narayan Babu understood in a blink. Crushing the *rasgulla* in his mouth, forcing it down to his guts, he burst out, hush! Mahto ji, enough of these tired tactics. Why suffocate the poor girl. This is their future married life. They must speak to each other or shell we?

Bhulo Mahto nodded at least ten times. If you all are busy stuffing sweets, I must play the role of matchmaker, or after words you will blame me for as I cheated on you, otherwise. Oh! go on daughter. And you Ramprasad. follow her, shuttle down, have some sip of love, Decide right and wrong. Come back and just tell us what your heart says. Descent Rama stood first yet, waving the banner of patience and propriety over his haste, let Lajwanti walk ahead.

The room adjoined the kitchen. Even so, Ramprasad's spy-nose reported *aaloo-gobhi* simmering nearby.

'After a long ceremonial silence!'

Ramprasad uttered,

:Your house is beautiful!

:Yes!

:but not more than you!

(A soft smile guarded her flushed cheeks for a moment, then fled.)

:You seem sad. Is something wrong, if it is fit for me to know?

:Why should I hide it from you? (she leapt into a struggle of words.)

:No, I mean, I am a stranger. You do not know me. Why share your pain with one, a stranger?

:Who said you are a stranger? God has given you an enchanting power. Wherever you walks, you pull people like a magnet, making them yours forever, just as you've made me. And see I've decided. If marriage happened, then only with you.

(The words melted into his ears, sweeter then sugar. For such a woman he had long troubled *bajrangbali* himself. His boyhood nearly leapt out, but he steadied his voice, as for manhood.)

:We have hardly spoken to each other. We do not know each other, so closely. Still Such trust to me, think twice.

:I've made up my mind. You know, Babuji keeps chanting only your poem & praises to me. The boy has a private job for now and earns little, but as they say, Talent reveals itself in the cradle. He will surely take a government post. Calm, cultured, radiant, restrained, and so of your virtues, he has sung over nights to me. Needlessly, even if I've not seen your sculpted face, your qualities were fair enough for me to marry you.

(Ramprasad felt tickled within, brushed with praises. Yet acting normal,)

:I earn fifteen hundred for now. Seeds and shelter come from my

employer. It suffices. After marriage, It will be seen. I feel this year I will make it in a government job. Still, all lies in God's willing.
:Hold on.. who asked you about money? I am capable myself. And can manage out our home. But.
:But? (Rama rested, he was drifted away from the pivot, yet, blaming Lajo)
:You are drifting from the point, Madam.
:No, it is just that I .. ah! ...I.
:Now, speak it up!
:Swear on me. You will not tell my Babuji. And after hearing, you will not step back from marriage.
:I swear. I will not step back. Now please go on..
:A few days ago, my elder uncle was shot dead in broad daylight. His thirteenth day rites ended only day before yesterday. Daya Singh will not stay silent. The longer he waits, the deadlier he strikes. I fear our love story may become another sacrifice to bloodshed custom. Slaughter in a wedding crowd is nothing to him. His silence carries that intent. Babuji says he will handle it, yet fear grips him too, You see. What if this becomes the last wedding of our family. That is why this marriage cannot happen. Daya Singh is not dying now, neither my age waits for no one. Men may delay marriage even to deathbeds, but perhaps for women, her *shringaar* fades away.

:Shot dead? What did your uncle do?
:He was a landlord, and a broker. Fighting for the rights of the oppressed, he turned violent without knowing when. I was little then. (she was still something sixteen, perhaps because of her dressing sense and mature appearance; she looks like a complete women)
:such a noble and renowned family, you have, haven't you?
:That is the grief of all, we swallow daily.

After a pause, with some salt of hesitation, Ramprasad served a proposal.
:Then come with me to my village. There is no Daya Singh there. Not even a creature called *Babhans* or *Brahmins*. There we shall merry! What you say?

:Her dim brown hope lit green again. Her dreams started dripping shape.
:Is that possible? Say? Is it can be?
:Yes. It can be. I will speak to my Babuji. What do you say? Shall I?
:You are so kinder. My *sola somvara* fasts have borne fruit. If God has written my fate with you, I will worship your sole like Sati.
:Oh! Don't make me feel shameful, you Lajwanti Devi Ji!
(Lajwanti Kumari has just become Lajwanti Devi. The beginning came from her future husband Ramprasad's sacred mouth.)

In a shy, excited rush, Lajo whole-heartedly,
:You, you have solved everything. You know, I had abandoned all hope. But you have made my.....
Before finishing, she out of shyness and bliss, she clung to him. Their bodies trembled with the first touch and meet of ripe youth like pair of serpents. Neither of 'em wished to apart.

From a crack in the window, Jaano and Maano devi continuously kept hazing there privacy. Their union sealed the match.
When the couple emerged, the alliance between families was already underway. Sweets had been shared very earlier.

Even after the meeting, curiosity lingered. The heroine Lajwanti watched the hero Ramprasad from behind her father's threshold, watching without end. Ramprasad returned formal glances, sometimes offering a coin sized smile. Yet behind his temples an invisible fear kept pricking like a needle, as if a strange sensation was breathing close to his ear, anonymously.

***

3. A Debt Aged in Doom!

The strategy had already been forged, yet its blueprint had remained unseen by all. In the marriage pavilion, in spite of flowers and sacred rice, drops of blood would be spilled and perhaps this was no figment of imagination, rather was a fate, written with a steady hand. That was why Daya had been lying in wait for so many days. Still, there was little that resembled the discipline of war in this plan. Daya Singh wished to send Naval Kishor, along with his entire household, across the final threshold. After all, fear too is a currency, and he knew its value well. A wedding turned into mourning was hardly new to him. It was, in fact, habitual for him to keep igniting his fearful flame among the blacks and browns.

The moment the news arrived that Lajwanti would be married into her in laws house, his blood rose like a tidal surge. Strategy be damned. To hell with plans. I'll Kill the scoundrel with my revolver, six bullets straight into his chest. Barked Daya. Pulling his gun from behind his back, fired two rounds into the air, parting the clouds like a barber taming unruly hair, and set out to place the final full stop of that filyour chapter. A lone jackal can feast only a carcass. thus, entire pack of wolves marched with him.

Naval Kishor lacked physical might, but his mind was no weakling. Hearing of Daya's exploits alone had turned the hair of his ears white. These days the government was showering favors upon the so called lower castes, *ghee* upon *ghewar*, and to crown it all, the new station officer too belonged to that very community. Named, Pyarelal Paltu.

The philosopher in Naval Kishor paid a formal visit to the fiery officer. Draping his helplessness in words, he reminded Paltu of his duty toward their people. A seed was planted firmly in the officer's mind.

As, if he could not protect his own people, what face would he show to his brethren. For what day, for what purpose, was he drawing a service? Before Kishor could add anything more and further provoke him, the officer turned the tables.

Assuring Kishor, and advising him to gather his people and stand united. Before a tall tree is felled, its branches are cut first. And when the moment comes, he shall strike as hammer on iron while it's temper is hot.

Kishor understood little of iron and less of its temper. Yet he felt reassured. After all, the officer was of his own caste. Still, doubt crept in like a snake in the granary. What if he lived up to his name? What if he switched his side? What if Daya Singh greased his palm?

Questions were many, but when it came to action, his mind froze as if bitten by a phantom scorpion. He had done little in life beyond studying. A job had come in his way once, only to be swallowed by senior officers. His spirit grew weary. He chose farming, a life of dignity, thinking that was living enough. He had grown up witnessing bloodshed, yet emerged a worshipper of non-violence, the one without a god. Who would come to save such an alienated man!

Anyways but one thing gnawed at him always was that, The own family of Siyaram Babu. His own people had done nothing beyond shedding crocodile tears. Had even one of them spoken plainly to him, for just once. though they were of the same clan, Kishor alone drowned day and night in worry for Siyaram Da, but was always concerned with a single sphere,

"*yaar!* they didn't even turned up to say a word!"

Lost in thought, he reached home; And there he got caught with another trouble. As Lochan and Sulochan were sharpening themselves for battle. It seems though every face was set on bloodletting.

Kishor with tired face and fired mind, did not know what to tell them. If he say, thanedaar Paltu 'll protect them. And in case if he turned, then the village would drown in a festival of blood. Who would bear the blame? The thanedaar or Kishor himself! Far better, the subtle mind of Naval, suggested to be Silent. He almost buried thanedaar's words deep within, just revealed it to only one soul, his beloved wife. And that was it all. Ahilya, in turn, told only Lochan and Sulochan and locked the matter in her private coffer.

Lochan was a strange creature. Half aged, half juvenile, at least in his own eyes. Perhaps that was why he always held his head high! "Why didn't our big brother opened to us? Are we not his family? Or does he fear we would leak his words across four peoples?" yelling he marched straight to Kishor, mean time Sulochan was Lochan's mirror, perfectly symmetrical, better a replica. Followed him as his shadow.

Lochan confronted Kishor. Kishor ducked his head in despair. Woe to woman and her tangy tongue. He pleaded with both brothers to keep the matter sealed ear to ear. Thanedaar would help them. Or if not, at least this shame would not unfold in the open-air, that their own caste kicked him to the place, where he belong. The heat here was still venomous.

Furthermore, The village square stood where four roads collided, naming Chauraaha. Behind it ran a narrow alley leading to Kishor's house. At the center stood an ancient banyan tree, its roots sunk deep, its shade swallowing everything zenith it. Nearby, a crumbling mud wall gave birth to a tree whose name even I don't know. Nor had I any business with it. The matter of fact is that behind that wall someone is spying out! constantly.

Three jeeps halted. Daya Singh and his red eyed hounds. Revolver in hand. A ghost of wind passed and every door shut with their windows tightly. Only one rattling window remained open in that falling mud wall, from whose lattice two eyes kept on peeping out.

Before entering the alley, Daya Singh soaked his manhood in liquor. The wind's echo bumped every hair on Naval's body conveying the moment had arrived, and it was monstrous. He was burning inwardly. Restlessness clawed at his soul. Yet Lochan and Sulochan boiled with eagerness, ready to leap into the funeral pyre.

Kishor cried,
"O wisdom that runs backward in the hour of destruction. One brother a remover of crises, the other a walking crisis. Has madness seized you? Was Siyaram Da only your brother? Did he mean nothing to me? Do you think I cannot burn with rage. If harm comes to you, on whose support shall I thrive my rest life?"

Lochan cut through his words, critiquing with venom,
"You just keep singing your songs of helplessness... You already challenged him, didn't you? Was this not the day you desired? Why does death frighten you now? know that saying goes, 'the father never killed a frog, yet the son comes to becomes an archer!' If this was so, why did you roar at first? for what sake of hell you tore your chest open? Are there only words as weapons in your quiver. You have done nothing so far, and when we act, you sit be coming our *baap*!"

The words stunned Kishor and sharpened him a bit.
"What are you even spiting, Lochan? Do you think I could have stayed silent before my brother's corpse? You mustn't know, those words were for his honor, not mine. And you think I became your *Baap*! So this is what brewed in your shitty mind? Bravo Brothers!

Alright then, from today, I am no father to you. Go, be free. I have stirred the storm, have I not! Now I shall see who shows mercy to this spawn of Daya. I shall strike him until his lungs forget the taste of air; He will lie in the dust, and not even the lowliest street dog will howl for his soul."

As Kishor stormed out,
Lochan leaped Kishor's hairy legs, breaking his voice,
"Forgive me, Bhaiya! In blind fury I spoke nonsense. You only stand our mother and father. Where would we stand after turning against you. You know me, a Nasty Howl! Forgive me, yet I assure you, Today as we unites, we shall send this wretch and his filyour wolves to the cremation ground. Either our soil shall drink his blood, or our blood shall settle the ledger of justice!"

Naval returned to the adolescence of his youth. Beside his brothers, his neck bore ornaments of a fiercer kind. "I Shall strike first!" As he took out Siyaram Babu's double barrel gun, for the first time to breathe that rusty smell of gunpowder, and here he mounted the horse.

Between Kishor's house and the alley lay a well. As he turned into a storm, neighbor Pancham arrived with five men, crashing down like lightning splitting wind. Uttered,
"Halt! Kishor Da."
"Behold, Pancham! the destiny of Daya's cruelty is a debt aging his fate. Today the verdict will be paid sin-by-sin. I have endured enough, bowed enough.... None should dare to halt me! From now either his pride survives or my mustache does! But hear me well. So long as breath dares to remain within this body, I shall not permit the world to feel Siyaram Da's absence. His void shall bleed louder than his presence ever spoke."

***

4. A Clumsy Family!

Golden sunlight blooms in full flourish. A house of mud and tile rests under it. A wide courtyard stretches out, unashamed of its poverty. In one corner stand three or four banana trunks, in the other a cattle shed, where two oxen, a cow, and a devoted pair of goat Chewing the cud, all together.

The cow and goats go unnamed, but the oxen do not. Narayan Babu named them with affection, after his departed father. One is Babu, the other is Lal. His father's name was 'Babulal'. Ironically, Lal, the ox, is black as midnight, also his tail is broken. How did it break? Is a interesting story to share. One day, while Narayan Babu was ploughing his field, no one knows when or why or how, Lal bolted! Narayan Babu was dragged along. Babu the ox slipped free of the yoke and fled, leaving Narayan Babu trapped in his fate's grip. Lal ran like death itself was chasing him. In blind panic, Narayan Babu grabbed at whatever came to hand and in that way he caught Babu's tail. In that tug of terror, Lal's tail tore away. Narayan Babu felled upon his head, he was struck so hard upon his forehead, that stamped this incident upon his brow for whole life, as a Hematoma, as a Bump.

Narayan Babu lies sprawled on his cot. A special stool has been set for Bhulo Mahto. Bhikhari Rai, Narayan Babu's elder son, sits nearby. His face is pockmarked from smallpox, his lips thick and hanging so low that his mouth never truly closes. His ragged appearance justifies his name, Bhikhari, the beggar! Married in childhood, he and his wife grew fighting like siblings, bred five children. His wife, named Kiyari Devi, but for to be easily or lazily called, makes everyone call her Kari.

By always twisting her mouth, Kari's mouth has pulled to one side, seems as if she dislikes everything on the planet. Sharp, greedy, quarrelsome, yet the apple of Narayan Babu's eye.

Bhikhari crouches at the edge of the stool beside Bhulo. Kari boils tea in the kitchen. Chintamani Ramprasad sits on a low plank, and with him sits everyone's worry. The worry has a name, "Lajwanti's murderous lineage."

Bhikhari said, " Hear me Kari, are you deaf, han? Have you poured bitter oil in your ears! Is the tea not ready yet?"
Kari snapped back, "The tea is on the boil. Shall I sit in it myself. Will you drink me instead! God knows which *santrees* have come and sat here. No grain to graze, but sips tea every hour."
"There you! Your trumpet begun to blare. You just need but a chance, You quarrelsome woman."
"Leave her, Bhikhari," Narayan Babu intervened, siding with his darling. "Tea takes time to boil. What fault has the poor soul."

Bhulo, remembering his purpose, said, "Aurh Ramprasad! what have you thought. What shall I tell Kishor. Is there to be a marriage or not."
Ramprasad had barely opened his mouth, and here arrives Kari with tea, "What is there to think, Kaka. She comes from a fighting clan. She will spread nothing but strife here."

Bhikhari to himself, "as if you have kept the peace of heavens here."

"This is not so, Bhabhi," Ramprasad said. "I have met Lajwanti. She is sweet spoken, modest, knowing well the ways of honor. Speak to her once. If she proves quarrelsome, then say so."
"All is moonlight for four nights," Kari retorted. "After marriage, see how sweet and shy she remains, still Dever ji! If you ask me, I would say no. But what do I know. It is your wedding."

"Who asked you," Bhikhari barked. "Go mind your kitchen. Women should not speak in men's matters."
"Yes, I go, I go.." Kari said, twisting her mouth. "I've no concerns in your councils. You hear that, but my ears love you so much that they die to hear your wisdom."
"And you are shameless and tangy tongued, aren't you?" Bhikhari sneered. "You'll speak regardless."

Narayan Babu's forehead bump flushed red with anger. "Enough, both of you. Bhikhu, utter not another word. Kari go mind your vessels. And you, Rama! Will you be sitting mute as a tethered bull, or will speak something?"

"What should I say." Ramprasad replied calmly. "Do what seems right to you. If I insist and later trouble arises, all blame will cling to my neck. So do whatever you wish too."

Narayan Babu understood the inverted wisdom of Kabirdas in his words.
"There is no room for insistence," Narayan Babu urged. "We have seen the girl. We all have seen the girl. She has looked upon the boy with full eyes, and Rama also have no complaints against her. And so true to say refusal wounds honor too. Afterall the marriage is with the girl, not her people. What you say, Bhulo?"

Bhulo slurped his tea noisily. "What can I say, *Maharaj*. When husband and wife agree, what can the priest do. But you know the atmosphere there. The greatest trouble is how the marriage shall be arranged?"

Ramprasad smiled within, his heart got blossomed like *Gulmohar*. His biggest worry already eased. He went ahead, "The wedding will be here. I gave my words to Lajwanti Ji. Which is why she agreed. Otherwise she had almost refused for the marriage."

Kari returned to collect dirty glasses. Her hands where were busy, but not her tongue, hence it refused to be restraint, "Who is she, who refuse, to whom she marry? Since when are girls asked about marriage? You are very innocent, Devar Ji." Good question. But went unanswered. Instead Narayan Babu jumped in,

"But Rama, there is again a trouble!" Narayan Babu folding his legs, "how can we manage to see both marriage alone?"

"With those two eyeballs!" Bhikhari laughed. "and how else!"
"Fool," Narayan snapped. "I speak of money. You idiot! Go feed fodder to the oxen. Move away."
"I go, I go. Cannot even joke."
"You'll joke with your father, you jackass!"
Bhulo chuckled. "Let it be Dada. If boys do not, then shall we old men will joke."
"This is a boy." Narayan Babu scoffed. "A man with five children. Nothing to work, nothing to earn, lies like a log. Spineless."
Narayan Babu himself had eight children. Perhaps in those days, such things were nothing but God's will. Humans had no control over it.

Bhulo re-calling the subject, "Rama, you fell silent again. What about the money?"
"All will be arranged, Kaka." Rama calmly.
"To be arranged is easy, my son. But how?" Bhulo bolted.
"I am telling you, if you will let me speak." Rama anxiously.
"Speak, speak my lord! I shall be silent better." Bhulo gasped.

While Bhulo died in silence, Rama, now gets comfortable and started his Ramayana: "So yes! when we were leaving their house, I went to seek Kishor Babu's blessing. He took me into his room, embraced me, grew very emotional, and said…"

"I shall remain forever grateful, son. Who trusts a bloody lineage like ours. I had lost hope my daughter would ever marry. Her aging hands killed me every single day, you know. I feared that when you'll hear of our house, you will not even ask for water... from my side, Thank you is too a small word. And worry not for money. I have saved every penny. I shall give double of it. offerings, dowry, gifts, all. There shall be no lack."
"I said to console him, Why worry, Kaka. Are relationships smaller than money. All shall be well."

But truth knows no consolation. Money stands taller than relationships. Ramprasad knew this better than any. There was a time Ramprasad wished to study, but Narayan Babu said plainly, If you live in my house, you must earn. Bhikhari was a big fat goose egg in studies. Obeying his father, he dealt his life to a *Bidi Godam*. but, Ramprasad alone chose exile. He left home, vanished among strangers, taught and studied. Yet fate like *Rahu* eclipsed his moonlike government dreams again and again. Still, he grew capable enough to be called back home. To sit for accounting his struggles would turn this book into his biography, and you into his devotee.

Bhulo breathed deeply. and coughed, "So Narayan Da, the matchmaker's work is done right here. Money too is arranged. It will come, and in excess. Your burden lightens, *Yajman!* Now give me excuse! Ram-Ram."

"What burden lightens?" Kari said, rolling *bidis*. "Both weddings will happen in this house. As if we run a rest house. Master Sahab has said Lajwanti's wedding will be here. Why should he worry of, How?"

At that moment entered a new *namuna*, lover of betel, a living taboo, Narayan Babu's younger brother, Baiju Babu.
"Why shout, Kari? Always her neck is creeped with veins. What went wrong now?"

"What can I say, Kaka," Kari replied. "In Mens' talk, what place has a woman. Think well for someone and they chase you with a spear. My singular concern is, Two weddings under one roof... Money alone is not enough. Goods are needed. Space is needed. Will this small hut hold people or possessions?"

"You speak right Kari!" Baiju Babu said. "If goods stay, where will kin live? And also when will my house serve its purpose? It is a government quarter, but still mine. The bride's side will stay there. The procession will start from there and comes here with song and dance. The wedding will be grand. If you all say? "

Baiju was a railway driver, a post inherited from Babulal; Narayan Babu gave it to his younger brother, thinking himself content with warehouse wages. This single act of brotherhood turned the pupil outshone the mentor. Since the both kin never seemed to be born of the same mother. For this generosity, Narayan Babu was cursed daily by his household.

Kari said eagerly, "If so, then all problems are sorted, kaka. No debt, no dangle. The girl's side pays. And income will exceed expense. There will be no quarrelsome for pennies, we shall drive half of them equally, And ...."

Baiju, with his itching palms for wealth in his eyes, said,
"Breathe, my mother, breathe. We shall see profit and loss later. For now bring your top class strong tea."
"Sure! just a second." Kari ran to Hariya's general store, returned with packet milk and tea powder, and sat on boiling.

Baiju mused, "Sometimes I think, Dada! if Hariya's shop were not here, what you would have done?"
"What do you mean?" said Narayan Da, mixing his tobacco.

"Look even now! Kari runs like a nomad at every demand. As if the shop is her storehouse and kin is her customers. It looks ill. What will society think?"
"Who thinks what? Let them say it to my face. I will pull their tongue and pierce it to their nose."
"That is why no one speaks. why would anybody say, what they think! Why don't you buy ration monthly? For so your honor stays intact and also Kari will not have to run to Hariya by jingling coins."
Narayan Babu saying with a big yawn,
"yaahhahaa!! After harvest, *Malik!*, I shall... think."

Beside them, Ramprasad knew well the house's threadbare state. After much pleading, Narayan Babu had dug a well long ago. For even garlic, onion, salt, spice, one still ran to the shop. Honor bled daily here. But, today Ramprasad worried as never before. How would Lajwanti Ji survive in this thicket? Kishor Babu would sell his soul and property to place his delicate daughter in my hands. "My family is full of peoples who would pinch pennies from a dead man's eyes." They knows what relationships mean. Spitting manner to them, is to give them forgery advice.

Ramprasad's earnings lay entirely under Kari's rule. Four earners, Narayan Babu, Ramprasad, Bhikhu and Rajeshri with one mistress, Shrimati Kari Devi. Imagine then when a new woman arrives and Kari must share her throne. What will then coal-colored Kari cat do, when her dominion will cracks.

***

5. The Scarlet Hail!

"Tis this very calamity I have come to halt, Kaka," Pancham said, drawing a heavy breath.

"What calamity?" Kishor thundered. "I go to annihilate the sinner who has sown calamity for years. You should be walking beside me with willing feet, Pancham. Or have you forgotten what befell your sister? How those beasts…"
"I remember that rage; Kaka! need not to remind me."
"Then by what mouth do you bid me stop? Your wounds may have healed, but I have nursed each bruise of him, black and blistered, as fresh as the day they were carved. If even your timid soul found no solace in his death, say it outright there, you timid."

Pancham flared, his voice sharp, almost scolding Kishor Da:
"But Kaka, Daya Singh did not kill Siyaram Babu."

"What drivel you speak? Lies, all lies. That trader has bought you as well. I see it now. Siyaram Da's own kin avert their faces. Kaleshwar shows no rage at his brother's death. Here three brothers stood shoulder to shoulder, then you, Turam Khan, strut before us! Speak true, Pancham! Do coin matter more to you than clan and blood? Do your wounds not scorch your flesh? Since when have you grown so stone-hearted? Had your father lived today, He must be shameful to see you like this…"

"You wander from sense to spectacle, kaka! composing melodies of all nine emotions at once. Will you hear me, or only the echo of your own voice will narrate all foolish stories?"

"What more have you to say, now? My throat is parched, no words shall pass through." saying, he sank onto the ledge of the well.

Pancham started his delivery of clarification over suspicion:
"I was coming to aid you, Kaka. Way on the road I met Kaleshwar Kaka. He was drenched in sweat, tying his suitcase in great agitation, like a man fleeing life itself. I asked lightly, "Where are you planning to run, Kaka?" His sweat broke into a flood. He stammered, "Who is it? What nonsense do you prattle? Shall I flee my own house? Are you a fool, or do I look mad to you?"

"I laughed it off. 'Easy, Kaka. I jest. You stiffened like tobacco mixed with lime. Well tell me kaka, where are you going?'"
"He snapped, 'It's none of your business? Your brother Akash already thrives on gossip. You too have taken up his trade? Splendid. Now be gone, stop dancing on my head, despite measure your own roadmap .'"
"You seem altered today, Kaka. There is matter here, and I shall know it."
"Know what? Have you ever killed even a mouse? I could crush the likes of you with a fart, and the wind would not feel heavy even."

"I meant only that I would learn what you hide. And tell me, have you hired bouncers on pay? The heat pours off from you, for so."
"Yes, I have. And if you chew on my brain further, I shall have you killed as well."
"'As well' you say? someone else too has been slain or what?"

"At that, Kishor Da. He panicked. Went inside and slammed the door shut, hastily.." Curiosity chained my feet. I peered through the cracks on the door. Soon he spoke to someone inside. My ears stood alert. then what I heard was ground-breaking, I heard: "Do something, quickly. My ticket to Patna is not even booked. People are growing suspicious here. Where have you vanished? And where is Daya Singh? (he continued)

At his bidding I sent my elder brother Siyaram Da to *Marghat*. In return he was to sign all property in my name. He spoke not to the registrar, nor arranged my safety. Where is he? Is it must for another corpse to rise from this house? Act, my brother. Act something, I did my debt, now its your duty! I beg you to Act."

Pancham, giving his words a verdict:
"Kaka, upon hearing this, my mind turned numb. I have never had dreamed a man would murder his own brother. The moment I heard, Daya Singh was slipping his capital into *Dhanuk Punji*, I rushed to aid you, dawn had risen since. But what I heard, I have stumbled here to tell. I am no coward. I have summoned my own men. These five fellows you see have families crushed by Daya's tyranny too. We shall drag his entrails from his throat by chasing him to the hell. Tell me, brothers shall we?
"With whole heart! Let him fall into our hand once. I shall mount his chest and skin him alive," one of them roared.

"No. We shall not be doing such things."
Kishor spoke with lowered head, his voice weighted with tears.
"With what face shall we face them? His own brother orchestrated this murder. A man battles enemies for his kin. But when kin join hands with enemies, for whom does one fight? Haven't you come a little later, Pancham… haah! let it be. Fate wills it so. If our lot is to drink blood like bitter water, so be it. Come, let us return."

"Wait, Kishor Da."
"Now what is it?"
"Recall, you had cast his son Dani into the *Marghat* river. Whether you fight or not, he has crossed the boundary. He writhes, throat raw with vengeance. His bow will not loosen without blood. He will fight. Either you slay that viper, or be slain. Speak. We shall do as you command."

Naval Kishor pondered a while.
then spoke, despair wrestling with forced resolve:
"Siyaram Babu was as much our brother as Kaleshwar's. His favors upon us outweigh blood relations. Today he lives in every memory. Awaken his flame. In each heart, a Siyaram lights. To abandon the field after death, claiming Kaleshwar bore more of his blood, would be bartering that divine blood. We shall fight until sense leaves us. Even if Kaleshwar comes now, we shall trample him too. The wretch repaid mother's milk with his brother's blood.

Kishor continued to ignite the spark of Manism among them:
Behold! You merciless. Rise, O ye brethren of the mountain pass! To shield the tender fruit of future loins, This day demands a tithe of vital red. Grip fast whatever steel the hand may find; The woodman's axe, the mattock, the scythe, and the spade, The heavy plough that breaks the stubborn earth! This hour shall pen the finish to our grief; One tale must perish that the truth may breathe. Either we stand as giants 'neath the moon, Or yonder tyrant's sun shall sink in gloom!

If blood must flow, let it be for the last! To-morrow greets a sun of different fire, A golden eye to watch a world reborn. We'll rive the oppressor's breast and pluck the heart, Where every heart'll tastes vengeance, salt and sweet. Foul treachery, deceit, and cankered souls, The filth of ages, rot of ancient pride; Strike back! As Goddess *Chandi* rides the storm-tossed sky, Let thunder be the rhythm of your stride! No more the morrow; now the hour is come, When we, the People, strike the tyrant dumb!

The field is set: 'tis death or victory's crown! Mark well this moment in your marrow's bone: Be you as flint, as cold Carpathian stone, Recall your manhood, let your soul take wing! Are you prepared? Speak! Does your courage sing?

Are you prepared to meet the iron gale? Then raise the cry that makes the heavens pale."
"The Scarlet Hail! The Scarlet Hail! The Scarlet Hail!"

All voices roared in unison. In the hour of sorrow, few stood. But Kishor's wrath echoed and drew the entire mass together. Each hand bore a tool turned weapon. The cry of Scarlet Hail heated the town into a blazing furnace. Its echo surely reached Daya Singh's ears. He hurled aside his liquor bottle, loaded his revolver, and stormed into the lane, his courage roaring from his throat. The counter-force charged like starving wolves.

Here, I bind the battle into verse, painting war with poetry.

Restless chests, trees, skies, and eyes; endless roars of steel and blood all arise. Poor and king, pure and outcaste; fighting for a breath up to last. Cunning rogues in false disguise; unleash bullets from the skies. The innocent body falls and fades; unavenged in the dark shades. Yet strong remains the ploughman's arm; blind to the flying bullet's harm. With heavy cleavers sharp as rain; they rip the wolves of their domain. Why does the wolf-pack never shrink? Do they of the demon's bloodline drink? Truth and virtues rot away; where does Goddess Kali's trident stay?

Some clash, some flee in dread; the mind's reason hangs by a thread. Limbs are severed, remnants fall; the axe's hunger claims them all. Hacking at heads already slain; orphaned corpses within the rain. In toxic loops of vengeance blind; they lost the path of mankind. Red-stained brow and massive dread; fierce Kishor steps out with iron tread. The piercing shots splits the air; shivering ears caught in despair. Strikes must not go to waste; Daya burns in furious haste. In the hail of bullets' flight; the farmers soak in bloody night.

Loading guns as chance permits; if manhood holds, the body splits.

A fierce battle wildly blows; dust as tornados as it grows, Blood is swallowed like dark wine; earth rises to the cloudy line, raining blood on the divine. Endless wrath and cursed abuse; instantly let hellfire loose. "Suddenly, the bullets bite"; Kishor falls wounded in the fight. Uproar halts in sudden shock; morale shatters like a rock. Then piercing through the cosmic soul; from the void of karma's toll. There mighty stood in frozen bone; "the mighty Daya turned to stone." Swift as a horse the axe was thrown; the wicked fell was overthrown. Yet the angry Kishor stubborn remained; discarding mercy, staying stained. In already dead he is apart in burst; since unquenched remains his lifetimes' thirst.[2]

Inspector Paltu, who was the one, stalking over the Warfield since the entry of Daya Singh, from behind the mud wall. He steps in to restrain Kishor. Kishor, enraged, raises his hand against him, but halts. Stops. He cannot strike his own caste. With cold equity, he orders him to wear bangles in his hand. Kishor continued,
"He will protect us? Eunuch. Why come now, to arrest me? Where were you till now?"
"I was here before the slaughter, behind a broken wall. Was waiting for if your side be weakened, I would have encircled Daya Singh at once. But…"

After a pause. Naval Kishor to thanedaar Paltu,
"Come forward. Take me to jail, or else another Siyaram shall rise here!"
The crowd protested, "Show us if you dare take people's hero Kishor Babu to jail."
Kishor Babu opposed them, urging:
"Hear me, you shall cremate the martyrs. Heal the wounded. Daya Singh is no more. Hence peoples of Upper caste who left alive, will take martyrs to the cremation ground. The tale ends here.

Before birthing another Daya Singh, remember his fate. Whenever Daya Singh rises, Naval Kishor shall rise too."

Heads bowed. Death conqueror Kishor's face glows red like a newborn sun, going first to the Trauma Center, then to prison.
The night has bled. Morning is inevitable.

***

6. He who never felt a wound.. jests at scars!

In the cool breath of *Magh*, when winter air itself hums with a shy murmur of love, a new bond had already taken root. In the chill of that sacred month, two hearts leaned toward one another, poised to script a fresh tale.

For the first time, a wedding procession arrived in the village riding a tractor. The marriage was solemnized twice, once at *Baba Dham* and again at the Narayan Babu's home, as custom demanded. Meanwhile then Kari Devi, squeezed out every coin she could. Brass trinkets were paraded as gold ornaments. A dowry of twenty thousand was taken, separately and shamelessly. *Lakshmi* had arrived, they said, warming every pocket she touched.

Everyone began to love Lajwanti not merely as a daughter but as more than their beloved; all about that warmth! Kari's nose rose higher with every such word. Why would it not? She had been the sole empress of the household until now. Who remains content watching their dominion shrink? And that too Kari. She set to work with her customary feminine stratagems, sowing whispers among gossipers.

"*Kulachhani* she is. A *Pisachin*. Do not be fooled by that innocent face. You know how painful a peacock's strike can be. God knows what she did to Rama. Look how besotted he has become with that red-faced witch."

Another woman chimed in.
"You speak true, Didi. Not just Rama, every man seems bewitched by her.

What sorcery does she practice? When she spoke, even I felt myself melting into her honeyed voice."
Kari sneered.
"Oh, now you are also tuning your voice to her praise? Are you my friend or hers?"
The woman hastily corrected herself.
"No no, I meant, she is a sly fox of a woman. Beware, Didi! Those sugar-dipped words might steal the keys to your rule. Narayan Kaka already sees his departed wife in her. He has crowned her *Lakshmi*. Your reign looks near its end."
Her laughter slid from her sharp eyes to her lips, settling into a sweet yet scheming smile that spread across her face.

Poor Kari already carried doubts like a chronic illness. Now someone had begun to confirm them too. She struggled between jealousy and the formalities of family. She handled firmly:
"You women have only one trade, breaking other homes. You cannot tend your own heart, so you rush to set fire to another's. Shall I complain to your husbands? Get out, all you home-breakers. Who knows where you come crawl in from."
She dragged her words, savoring them: "*hann...nhi too.*"

The family's honor was preserved gracefully by Kari, yet Lajwanti's very presence burned Kari from within like a lacquer house set aflame. Within days, she felt it. Quickly, too quickly.
She now hunted for chances to brand Lajwanti low, uncouth, cursed. Yet every time she tried, others spoke opposite.
"If virtue had a face, it would look like Lajwanti."
Where Kari sought stigma, the world bestowed wonder. Her heart kept getting butchered. Still kept wandering for that one chance.
Which too arrived in a scenic way, a day dreamed, was now.

Narayan Babu had gone to the threshing ground with Babulal. Kari and Bhikhari's little monsters had taken the goats to graze on someone else's melons. The cow was unwell. Kari sat on her cot rolling bidis, while Lajwanti fed fodder to the cow.
"Eat, Lachho, eat! Today the fodder is so nourishing that you will not just stand, you will run into the forest with strength. Eat."
She is stroking Lachho's head lovingly.
Kari shot a barb.
"What miracle have you mixed in it? Tell me too."
"You will see, didi. What can I say for now?"
Kari twisted her mouth into a crooked smile. 'huh!'

Bhikhari returned from his day of loafing.
"Aurh, Kari! how many bidis have you rolled so far?"
Lajwanti immediately drew her veil and slipped into the kitchen.
Kari snapped.
"Why? today you will got to Baitha?"
"ME? To that eunuch? Am I so unmanly? I am not free enough to sit beside him."
"Hmph! As if I expected better."

"Where is Rama?" Bhikhari asked, ignoring her.
"He has gone to 'earn'!" she stressed the word.

"So you think I roam uselessly? was going to *Bidi Godam* you saw that, didn't you? Your eyes wait only for my path. For you I lie like a woman at home. Well, A house needs a man, too! And, what you knows, wherever I sit, money trees sprouts out. I have turned many lives green. What would you know, bending your neck, sniffing bidis all day and every day. You shameless temptress."

Kari muttered,
"The snake is gone, the stick is sound; In every season, his green is found!"
"What did you say?" Bhikhari barked.
Just then the cow collapsed with a thud. Both husband and wife jumped like rat. Lajwanti cried from the kitchen,
"Where mountain has fallen? Bhaiya, please look!"
Kari screeched.
"It has fallen right inside the house, your mountain!"
Peering from behind her veil, Lajwanti screamed,
"hay Ram! Lachho!!!"
She abandoned all propriety, clutched the cow, and started crying madly. In just two or three days, she had found in the cow a companion of years. Who else did she had in her in-laws' home but Lachho? It was she who had turned a mere cow into Lachho - The Goddess Laxmi.

After some time.
Narayan Babu, Kari, Bhikhari all stood in the courtyard. Lajwanti's tears had dried black upon her cheeks. Hair disheveled, she sat like stone, staring at Lachho without a single blink of his lids.
Kari hissed.
"They said a *Lakshmi* has arrived, not a daughter-in-law. See how she devoured the old *Lakshmi*. Witch."
Narayan Babu thundered.

"Slur your mouth, Kari! Not today! swallow your black ominous tongue. Doctor Sahab is there coming. Nothing has happened to my Lachho."

The doctor arrived, examined the cow, and spoke softly with weight in his voice: "Why was no treatment done, Dada?"
"What treatment, Bhaiya?" Narayan Babu asked. "We thought it was seasonal. What is it? Is everything good?"

"You should have treated her. The cow had dry disease. And now it is too late for anything."
Dry disease meant Tuberculosis. Nothing more needed to say. But,
Kari leapt to deny.
"Nothing dry disease. Laajo fed her something. That killed her. Speak plainly what are you a Doctor or bewitched by this cursed woman. Our *Ojha* knows better than you, otherwise."
"It comes slowly." the doctor replied. "You may call your *Ojha* if you wish!"
"Ram Ram!" he folded his hands and left.

"You just can't rest without causing a stir, can you, Kari? Do you have any sense at all of how to speak to educated folks? And what was that rubbish you were spewing? That the Lajo poisoned her? You just wait!"
Saying this, Narayan Babu sat down beside the petrified Lajo. Stroking her forehead gently, he asked, "What did you mix in the fodder, Bitiya? What did you give Lachho?"

"Bitter oil, turmeric, and some carom seeds. mixed in fodder. That is what we give back home. I gave it too, thinking my Lachho would get better. I honestly didn't know, Babuji, that she would leave me like this and go to the Rama..."

Lajwanti teared down into heavy, rhythmic sobs as she spoke. Narayan Babu gestured for Kari to console her, but Kari simply twisted her face in a sneer and turned away. Narayan Babu hesitantly took Lajo into his arms, pulling her close to his heart.

"You didn't killed our Lachho! What are you saying!" he said. "You were only trying to save her and you will be blessed for that, my child. As for who leaves and when; that is all in His hands." As he spoke, his own eyes grew misty with tears.

Here, despite all the twists and turns, the burden of the matter landed squarely in Lajwanti's lap; yet Kari remained convinced that Lajo was the one who had killed Lachho." The cow, whom she neglected all her life, sowed love and compassion after death, anonymously or perhaps stirred even more poison against Lajwanti in her dry heart.

Venting her frustration like a cornered cat scratching at a pole, Kari gradually began making her 'worthy' sons steal Lajwanti's belongings. Kari would wait for the aroma of a meal to fill the kitchen, only to swoop in and lock the pots away in her own room. Whenever Rama gave Lajo some money, Kari's little brats would sniff it out and make it vanish. This cycle continued; Knowing all these mischiefs still, Lajo continued to shower her with love even by sacrificing her own basic needs. She hoped that someday, her elder sister will soften. And will love her, be friend her. But it was like crying before the blind and only losing one's own sight; Kari remained as cold and stubborn as she was.

Narayan Babu spent his entire day in the fields. In his spare time, the villagers had made him a 'thankless' Sarpanch, so he wandered about settling disputes. As evening approached, he would go off in search of his local liquor, staying away from home. When he finally returned late at night, completely dead to the world as if he'd traveled the four corners of the earth, he would simply sprawl out on his cot. Even so, Lajwanti would gather her courage to speak to him, trying to pour out her heart and share her troubles.

If a drunkard could understand the language of pain, wouldn't he have first seen the suffering of his own wife? Shanti Devi had literalized her own end, screaming her lungs out at this drunkard. And as for talking to that Bhikhari, the traditional *Bhabhu-Bhaisur* custom of avoidance stood in the way; and even if it hadn't, what was the use of speaking to that *Bhaisasur*? Who afterall listens to him anyway! Who was left was...

Ramprasad, who would visit only occasionally, satisfying the hunger of his youth before leaving again. One night, Lajwanti finally spoke her mind without filter: "There isn't a grain of food to eat, you don't listen when I speak; (her voice trembled) if a malnourished child is born after *Navami*, don't blame me! What is it to you? You only come here to jerk upon me! Have you ever thought about how my days are spent here? How many times have I asked you to talk to Babuji? But your 'manhood' only exists within this four walls of this room! Did you marry me just to show me these nights? Or is my life meant only to satisfy your lust?"

Ramprasad struck her with a sharp slap! He immediately got off the bed, tightening his loincloth. Sleeping on the floor, he spat, "Bhabhi was right, you are only good to look at. I saw it today, how quickly you dropped respect and started addressing me as *tum*, you ill-mannered woman! Every time I see you, you're spewing nonsense against my mother-like Bhabhi. She has never said a word to me; why on earth does she bother you so much?"

'That's because you place wads of cash in her blouse! Try not giving money to her for once and see, how mother-like she is! You give all your earnings to her as if I am a maid here; I had no idea you were already keeping a *Sautan*, otherwise, I never would have come here!' Lajo continued to vent, weeping for her fate and cursing God. 'My entire childhood was spent fulfilling the duties of the eldest daughter, and now my youth is trapped in the lust of this coward! I don't know if happiness is even written in my life. Where are those virtues my father saw in him?' She thought, sobbing and wailing until dawn broke. At the first sight of light in dawn, Lajwanti, amidst a heated argument with Ramprasad,
she fled to her parental home without biding goodbyes to any of the households. And what so if she didn't, Who then cared for so!?

Clinging to her mother Ahilya's veil, she poured out her grief, cursing her jailed father Kishor and beating herself over her own naivety: 'What a fever of youth I had, that I ended up stuck to this crude man!' Ahilya had seen many marriages; she simply felt that since Lajo was new to the house, she would eventually blend in with time. Her view was that once the knot is tied, whether the husband loves you or sends you to the afterlife, one must uphold the honor of the father's turban! She only performed her duty as a mother, pampering and comforting her; beyond that, she had no power to change anything for her daughter. 'If Kishor Babu were here, he too would be more haunted by society's judgment than his daughter's pain!' (But for now, he.... and Ahilya lost herself in her own thoughts.)

Truly said, he who never felt a wound.. jests at another's pain and scars. How can someone understand a sorrow they have never felt? Everyone had their own grief to cry over!

Slowly but surely, Lajwanti pushed her sorrows down, covering those wounds with layers of forced happiness; and in the midst of this, a daughter was born! A sweet, plump little like a *rasgulla*. She inherited Lajwanti's blushed cheeks, looking like a bright red tomato; whoever saw her wanted to nibble at her, showering her with affection. She was a piece of Lajwanti's heart, giving her a reason to be happy every day!
Since she was born on the day of the Holy *Tulsi-Pujan*, she was unhesitatingly named, 'Tulsi'."
...who would grow up alongside *Samay*.

***

7. The Virtuous Husband!

Time flown, and in its flowing, three years flowed away. Yet this flowing was no gentle breeze; rather, It was suffocating, a kind of thorn lodged in the throat of both families. Neither did Lajwanti hear a word officially from her in laws, nor did the threshold of her marital home sent a letter to the in laws; both remained anything but pale and cold. Ramprasad, too, kept fumbling inside his torn pockets of destiny, but the wretched luck of employment refused to be received.

In all the midst of this, villager gossipers was another trouble-makers, they would often ask Ahilya with feigned innocence, "Lajo's husband is such a fine gentleman, isn't it? Then why does Lajo remain buried here in her parents' s home?"
Ahilya had no answer but to merely press her lips together; these words, bitter as bitter gourd, had made her already flavorless life even more acrid.

On the other side, the self-proclaimed thankless Sarpanch, Narayan Babu, also faced the taunts while dispensing justice. Four men would toss sarcasm his way, "You used to call your daughter-in-law, the great *Lakshmi*, Dada! Why is she invisible? Is something the matter?"

The Sarpanch had no answer for this interrogation. At first, he would laugh it off, saying, "She is newly wed, Bhaiya! let her remain in veil! *Samskara* is also a thing, is it not?"

But what sort of culture or veil imprisons a daughter-in-law for a solid year, especially in a village society where a bride carries cow dung to the barn the very day after her wedding.

So the down payment of excuses could not sustain the debt of truth for so long. It wasn't that the villagers didn't understand; in reality, they were sniffing around, hoping to find some spicy entertainment to flavor their mundane lives. Walls have always had ears, but now they seemed to have sprouted mouths as well. Everywhere, the same whisper echoed:
'He struts like a big cat holding court, while mice throw banquets in his own kitchen! Huh! No clothes on his back, yet he chews betel nut with a knack!'

When it became unbearable, the illiterate Narayan Babu arrived at the abode of Baiju Babu and had him pen a letter to Ramprasad. It read thus:

Chiranjeevi Ramprasad,
Lajwanti's presence at her father's house without cause is dealing a blow to my honor. Does it be fit anyone to stay at their natal home for this long? She holds not a shred of respect for the dignity of her in-laws? You couple had left have become rare sights, like ungrateful kept woman. Now this time, shall enter the house during the Akhari Puja only with the daughter-in-law, or else I warn you!

We shall speak of the rest when we meet.

Your Father,
Narayan Ray.

"What wound was inflicted, that the daughter-in-law hasn't climbed the threshold for three years?" Baiju asked, shaking his chin in astonishment.

"Oh, don't you start now, brother! This girl has fried my brain. Wherever I go, people ask less of me and more of hers! Even my wife was not such a drama queen. I know not why she sits there like a renounced ascetic! Let her gain entry into the nest once, then I shall settle the accounts evenly!"

"Even so Bhaiya! you cared for her deeply. She must have told you something; didn't she?"

"Oh, leave it! If only womankind spoke straight like the wind blows, then all would be well, My naive brother! They are mistresses of their own whims; why would they deem it necessary to inform us? haah! Anyways brother, grant me leave. The panchayat must be waiting, and today I must go to Dhamna as well. Shrikhand Mahto is no less than a stubborn ox; his meeting is today, and the invitation for *Akhari Puja* has also arrived. Let me see if my chair still commands respect in the assembly. You must deposit this letter at the post office without fail. Do not forget. And be aware from your betel-chewing company might drown you in liquor while feeding betel, beware, Son!"

Saying this, he walked away, measuring the road with his black, worn-out leather shoes.

Obeying the letter-laden command of his father, Ramprasad arrived at Lajwanti's house with a heavy heart to fetch her. For the sake of information, let it be known that Lajwanti has three sisters and two brothers, who shall be mentioned in due time. The youngest among them is, Phulki! short, stout, and has bit trouble while spelling 'r' in the sentences. With a slightly depressed nose that is pierced, along with both her ears. Since the child is still raw, instead of jewelry, neem sticks serve as ornaments in her piercings.

She jumped and screamed, "Deeda is here! Deeda is here!" and stood ready with a small pot of water for her brother-in-law.

"What shall I do with this?" Ramprasad, testing the water level of Phulki.
"Eitha dwink it, o wash yo feet!"

"Oh wow, you are quite wise! Who taught you all this?" Ramprasad said as he gained entry in the house.

"Lado Didi has taught me. If anyone comes in this heat, give wota(water) first, ask questions leta (later)!"

Ramprasad cleared his throat and asked, "By the way, where is your 'Lado Didi'?"

Suddenly, carrying a bundle of grass on her head, with salt in her eyes and fire in her heart, Lajwanti fell upon the door like a lightning bolt, exploding with:
"Wherever she is, she is in peace. Two meals she gets, no kicks she meets, nor is she a purchased mistress to any man!"

Ramprasad extended a hand to help lower the bundle of grass from Lajwanti's head, but she jerked his hand away and threw the bundle into the courtyard herself.
"Goodness! You are still flushed with that rage! You haven't forgotten that night's matter yet? Leave it be, Lajo, let it go. A mistake was made. Will you take revenge for a lifetime? Fingers are being pointed at our relationship, the world is laughing at us. Forgive me, spit out the anger!" Ramprasad said, performing a show of holding his ears.

"You thought not of the world's laughter when you raised hands on me! The slap was struck with great precision. Then why now it bothers you? Had you thought a little of me then, had you spoken a few words on my behalf to your world... But why would you do such a thing? What loss was it to you? You had already found an object for lust and luxury. But what befell the poor object, where was your interest in knowing that?"

"What are you doing? Who speaks like this in front of a child?"

"Let her listen! Let her also see and hear what he looks like,
A 'Virtuous Husband!'"

"Why are you shouting, re?" Ahilya entered the courtyard, bringing milk from the shed.
"*Pranam, Matashri!*" Ramprasad immediately touched the world of Ahilya's feet.
"Oh, Jamai Babu! When did you come?"

"Don't ask when he came, ask why he came!" Lajo cut in with satire.
"I came to apologize to Lajwanti, and to take her back."
"You arrived quite too quickly. When did you leave? It took three years to get here; did it not take a bit too long, Jamai Babu?" Lajwanti cast taunt upon taunt.

Ramprasad, displaying the pinnacle of coolness, replied,
"A letter came from my home, and I was thinking about it too, but I was afraid. With what face would I confront Lajwanti? But forced by my family, I have to come."
"You did exactly the right thing, Jamai Babu." Ahilay supported formally.

In the meantime, the middle daughter, Manja, brought tea in scrubbed vessels. The formality of tea, the union of Rama with Tulsi, his eyes filling with tears, the socializing, the re-establishing of his gentility in the society; when all these tasks were accomplished, Ramprasad asked Lajwanti to leave. And that is when the real chaos stood and stirred up.

"I am not going anywhere with this beast! Once I fell for the trap of his garden and broke my own karma. It is my fortune that I have a shelter in my own home at least. My fate is not like Suthia Mausi's; she left her in-laws, and out of fear of society, her own family gave her no roof. The poor woman's life ended by jumping into a well!

I know you will do the same to me! I will die, but I will not live in the house of a two-faced snake like you! Why don't you go to my *Sautan*, your real beloved? what need is there for me? What am I to you? Give the money to her, count the expenses to her. In return, what does she do? I didn't get food to eat, I toiled like an ox all day, while the Queen rolled bidis and earned money. And I had to wash her clothes too? Do you understand anything? I am also a human being! Do I not feel hunger? Do I need not to have money? Do I not wish to rest? What did I not tell you? In return, what did you do? You roam around acting like a virtuous husband, and within the four walls, you show your manhood on your wife! How hard you struck me! I wept all night, but this monster's heart did not melt..."

That silence, rotting, cooking, and boiling for years, now burned with a roar, and upon it, the rain of tears fell with a hiss, cooling it down. Yet, the layers of the wound kept peeling open and open. Neither her tears stopped, nor did she. Ramprasad and Ahilya let her speak, even if they didn't understand every accusation, every complaint, every agony, every insult, every torture! They are letting her speak.

Ramprasad's face turned to ash, like burnt residue, but making an effort, he said, "Forgive me, Lajo. I have no control over my anger, and the first time someone spoke ill of my Bhabhi, I got carried away. I regret that matter. Let it go now. You hit me in return, but end all this now. It has been enough. And yes! I have thought about it. The earnings I send home, I will now give it to you. I will speak to Bhabhi. Your shortage of food and drink will be resolved. And if there are any other complaints, we will talk about them at home! It shall be as you wish!"

Ahilya chimed in, "Agree to it, Bitiya. Do you want to rot in my veil all your life? And a husband's beating is like a blessing, isn't it?

Whose life doesn't have friction? Tell me? Come, stop crying and washing now, and pack your things. I will get Tulsi ready!"

Lajo still couldn't believe it, but the four people who had poisoned Ahilya's morsels with taunts had eventually reached Lajwanti's tongue as well. She agreed with a heavy heart. But wait, what is this? Ahilya took Lajo aside for so long; what did she teach and read to her that Lajwanti's wilted lotus cheeks suddenly flushed with delight? And that too with a completely new wrath and zeal! It seems she is not just returning, but returning to do something, something so astonishing that no one even has an inkling of it!

The rainy season is swelling up. There is a strange audacity in the air; black clouds stand cloaked in dense madness, and with a whistling sound, a black film is coating everything. It feels as though something ominous is about to occur. The herdsman has gathered the cows and buffaloes early today.

The husband and wife had just reached their home when torrential rain began. In between, lightning would strike like an arrow, leaving its imprint on every wall, along with a fear-inducing figure; it seemed as if the eyes of an invisible power peeked for a moment and then vanished back into the darkness. Every member of the household is present, and some conversation is passing between them.

"Now, here your Lakshmi has arrived? Where was she hiding for so many years?" The combative serpent Kari was sitting with hood raised.

"Will you not even let us wash our hands and faces, Bhabhi?" Ramprasad asked in quiet but clear words. By then, Lajo had quickly touched everyone's feet, leaving only Kari aside, and spoke from beneath her veil: "No, no! Let her hiss. She has been sitting frustrated for three years;

only today will the smoldering liver get some air!"

"Whose liver is smoldering, re? And what do you have that I should burn with envy?" Kari, the serpent, sat coiled up.
"That is for you to know. You used to hide the food; you used to have my belongings stolen!"
"Ram Ram! Ram Ram! Lies upon lies! Is this what you learned from your parents' home?"
"If it is a lie, then swear upon your wedded bliss! Speak, will you swear?"

"Shut up, Kari! Let me talk to Lajo!" Narayan Babu, coming to his senses, looked at Lajwanti with gravity. Kari fell silent, but the sharp smile on her twisted mouth and her piercing eyes were pleading to Narayan Babu: Scold the ill-omened one! Shove her face into the stove!

A low voice rose with seriousness and began to rain down upon Lajwanti like a sharp sword:
What do you think of yourself, han? Are you the Queen of this house? Whenever you pleased, you fled to your father's home! No reason, no letter. Are we thriving here on your father's estate? Your father have not married you to us; but he stripped us naked? I have been bearing the sorrow of your bad character for years! Do you even know what the village society has started thinking about my family? Do you know how much blood burns to earn honor and respect? How would you know? You came only as a bad omen! You have eaten my Lachho, You demoness!! You swallowed the peace of my house! What was lacking here? If there was a matter, you should have told me, told your sister, told Bhikhu! Or if nothing else, at least your husband! By running straight to your natal's home, you have cut off my nose. Will you pay for this dishonor, You bastard??

***

8. A watched pot never boils!

The atmosphere remained in a state of chaotic upheaval. The rain continued to lash down with a vengeance, a relentless weeping of the skies. A deafening crack of thunder. Strong enough to rattle the very temples of the skull. Had wrapped the grave assembly in its cold embrace, freezing the room into silence. The scorched and stinging words of the idealist Narayan Babu had rendered everyone, voiceless. Who would dare open their mouth before him? knowing he would yank out their tongue and tie it in knots.

Yet, one side of the story remained unheard. And that side fell upon the stagnant, heavy assembly like a bolt of hot lightning. The winds shifted violently; a sudden, scalding heat replaced the chill. The shock of the lightning made every body tremble, but it was the very next word Lajwanti spoke that shook the foundation of the house to its core.

"Hark now, Narayan Babu!" Lajo said, crumbling his hollow pride between her fingers like dry dust.

"I have long honored the grey of your hair; I have held my tongue at your command. Yet, were I to remain silent this day, life itself would be a hellscape, and the sin of this silence would sit heavy upon my head like a curse! The filth you harbors against me in your heart shall never wash away!"

Lajwanti's voice began to thunder, echoing with the strength of steel, sounding like the blast of a war-conch.
"Today, I too shall speak, and all of you shall listen!"

Every face in the courtyard turned to stone, drained of life. The glass in Kari's hand trembled; Rama's throat became parched, dry as salt. Bhikhu, witnessing this *Jagdamba.* this fierce goddess form of hers; felt himself buried alive in the void.

Lajo raised a finger into the air, her voice cutting through the storm:

"You ask, what shall society say? Society speak, what you preach!
But with what face do you preach to me of society?"

"In a house where bottles of liquor speak louder than a bride's scream,
Where men deem kicking a woman a valorous feat,
Where sisters play the part of cunning witches to keep a false bond!
Than talk of 'Honor' not sound strange to you amidst such rot?"

"And what more? Had you left any duty unfulfilled, You would hear me out! Tell me when were you ever in your senses to hear me? You always left at dawn and returned with liquor filled up to your gullet in the dead of night. Yet, I spoke to you daily, hoping you might listen. But Babuji knows nothing of who laid him upon the cot, who covered him with a sheet! Hah! He would hear me?"

She turned her gaze, sharp as a dagger.
"And this sister... nay, what sister? Cast such a sister into the furnace!
It's better to remain a maiden forever than to suffer with such a sister-in-law. What have this burnt-hearted wretch not done? She soiled vessels for sport, piles of clothes upon clothes for washing, and demanded her feet be pressed! Yet she used to burn with such envy that she has to hide food and steal goods and money. Speak, you black-faced witch! What past life's vengeance do you extract? Why are you hell-bent on poisoning a simple life of mine?"

"And my *Bhaisasur*... my buffalo-headed brother-in-law? What use is speaking to him? Who listens to the poor soul anyway? And indeed, who he allows to speak?"

"And lastly, my *Parmeshwar*, my husband... let us not speak of him. He bear great love for the clan; the wife is but a stranger woman to him. Whether she lives or dies, what is it to him? Provided, of course, no one questions him! Else, the *Parmeshwara's* hands and feet begin to thrash about. A very 'gentle' man indeed! Even more within four walls."

"Shall I speak more, or is this much truth enough for you to digest? Ah, yes! One urgent notice, my dear sister, for you! From this day forth, the coin Rama earns shall fall into the lap of his lawful wife, Lajwanti Devi, and not into your bodice!"

Lajwanti's insolence set Rama ablaze. He trembled with rage, his soul itching to plant a slap, to rain down blows. But Lajwanti stood in such an Avatara that he feared she might strike back. To be beaten by a woman... the world would deem him impotent. They would think he could not bridle his wife's tongue, and if he were kicked in return? That would be a double death for a man's pride! Thus, he swallowed his anger in silence. Everyone was flabbergasted; they had never expected the quiet one to speak so much.

No one had a word left in their mouth. Yes, Kari began to hiss and fuss like a disturbed bush, but Lajo, with full dominion, walked back into her room.

The next morning, the courtyard was not filled with usual peace. It was not silence that filled the space, but the suffocating smoke of insults. Narayan Babu sat on the threshold coughing, as if trying to dislodge the poison of the night stuck in his throat.

Kari washed the dishes, banging them violently, as if Lajo's face was etched upon every metal pot. And Rama sat under the shadow of the thatch, head bowed, wearing a coward's silence, while a fire smoldered within him.

Lajwanti's bold manner of speaking, the truth struck them all like an arrow, and the wound filled with the venom of shallow vengeance. Suddenly, the wooden door frame cracked open, and Lajwanti stepped out. There was a hardness in her steps, like that of an Empress; as if, after suffering a thousand years of imprisonment, she had been liberated today.

Everyone began to hate Lajo, but she gave not a single damn. she went about her work, lost in her own rhythm. She washed not even a rag belonging to another; she cooked only for herself. If something was missing, she went to the shop herself, adorned with grace and *samskara*. It seemed as though an *Apsara* had descended into this nest of a village. Villagers found Lajo delightful; with her speech and behavior, Lajwanti had placed a padlock of relation on everyone's heart. This Lajwanti was no frightened, statue of love; perhaps she was a *Mardani*. A warrior woman who answered a tiny gunpowder with bomb.

Kari burned and withered. For one reason or another, a skirmish would erupt between Kari and Lajo daily, and every day saw the invention of new profanities. Sometimes, hands and feet would fly, and the neighbors would have to intervene.
Now this time, Lajo had made a stubborn vow:
"Let death come if it must, but I shall not flee this battlefield!"

It had been only a few years since she had established the terror of her name, when God began to test Lajo once again. And this trial would be the hardest battle of Lajwanti's life.

This was because, in this fight, she would have to drink pain like glowing embers, washing it down with tears every single day.

The poor soul would fight not with muscle, but with morale. She would endure taunts and satire; she would pray and perform rituals; she would employ using *Saam-Daam-Dand-Bhed,* every trick in the book. Yes, the noise of her victory would surely rise in the end, but that noise would collapse like a castle of air. She would have the joy of winning, but that 'victory' would bring a lifelong, indelible stain!

A character capable of creating many scandals and sagas would be born from this very churning... A child not born of Lajo's womb, But birthed from her circumstances!

***

9. A Cancer in the Bud!

It is the month of *Poosh*, reigning with a tyrant's grip. A cold so biting it rattles the teeth; you can witness the mist swimming through the heavy air like a restless spirit. Bones remain stiff as frozen twigs throughout the day, to say nothing of the icy winds that slice through the skin. In a season where children forget bathing for days on end, a delicate, flower-like bud named Tulsi, rises before the dawn. She ventures to the well, bathes in the freezing water, and offers water to *Suraj Dada* - the Sun God himself. And after all this daily struggles, do you know what she begs from him? A brother.

"In temple bells she asks for a brother. In the mosque's *azaan* she asks for a brother. *Allah* or *Ishwar*, let either listen, but grant just one thing. Give me a brother."

Much the same burns within Tulsi's mother, I mean Lajwanti, shares this desperate fate. She too rises at the break of light, invoking thirty-three crore deities. Her womb practically screams, "O God, keep my womb empty if you must, but if you give, give only a son the birth." For Lajwanti refuses to paste the cursed word "*Nirvansh*" meaning lineageless; upon her forehead by bearing the burden of another daughter.

But why is this happening? What is the root of this misery?
In days gone by. Narayan Babu had three brothers. You already know Narayan Babu and Baiju Babu. The third, actually the middle one, was Dhanpat Ray. A man whose roof lacked even straw. A living joke of a famous proverb. People mocked him without mercy.
"His roof lacks handful of hay, yet the name is Dhanpat Ray."

The issue was simple. Not a single son was born to him. Why? His wife. Charkhi Devi. Loud mouthed like Lajo, though she too was tormented in her in laws' house. But the absence of a son turned her into a cautionary tale. Society carved her into an example. If any woman dared to utter words like rights or life, she was instantly crowned Charkhi Devi and fined with the curse of being lineage-less.

And at present, Lajwanti was trapped in this very snare.
Poor woman had kept decent relations with neighbors. But who dislikes a pinch of mockery? Fun tastes sweet till it bites back. When it turns personal, even pepper burns like acid. Kari had gone door to door whispering barrenness, provoking all tongues. Jabs flew freely.
"Looks like Charkhi Devi will return."
"What fate does a barren woman have? One who argues with elders, how will God let her lineage grow?"

Kari made it impossible for Lajo to even speak properly to anyone. She fought at home too, rubbing salt into Lajo's wounds with taunts of *nirvansh*. Hearing the word daily, the light of hope stopped resting in the cracks of Lajo's mind. She began living in depression, locked in her room all day, chanting God's name, careless of food or drink.

Tulsi was barely four, yet her mother's despair made her mature early enough. She too bore hunger, remembered Lord Shiva with her mother. No crying, no play, no childish cravings. She clung to her mother and became her courage.

Through Lajwanti's dry tears, the days flowed by somehow. Her womb grew heavy, and the time finally arrived. It was the cusp of spring and summer, the occasion of Holi, the month of *Phalgun*. Came with a tragic news. One freezing night, Narayan Babu slept and never saw morning again.

Now the elders of the house were Bhikhari Babu and Kiyari Devi. Now their word ruled without restraint. As it was already been so through Kari. Anyways.

Labor pains began to torment Lajo. But since when the family started caring! Therefore Lajwanti lay in the hospital throughout her pregnancy, night after night, day after day. And in such circumstances, on the day of *Ram Navami*, a boy was born. A complexion lingering between fair and dusky, small eyes, a face lovely yet grumpy. Everything was fine, but... well! Perhaps I am thinking too much.

Now, here you come, you must witness Lajwanti's joy, her euphoria, how the madness of motherly love overflowed to fill her lap.
"May no evil eye touch my son. Thu thu thu...."
"Tulsi Rani, wherever you find space, mark *kala tika* on his cheek."
"My child will slap every face today."

She kissed and cuddled him profusely! She took him to every house to distribute *Baina*, you know sweets; to show off her 'lineage', straightening the twisted faces of her detractors, laughing loudly, and taking twisted digs at her neighbors in return.

The happiness of motherhood, didn't last fair long. Beside where Kari's witch-like eyes happens to live, She performed her black magic, and a terrible boil appeared on the baby's foot. Lajwanti watched as her beloved son dragged himself, falling into her lap. She would call him, make him walk, sometimes even hitting the leg harder. The child cried in pain, but Lajwanti unknown to the illness, hardening her heart, wanted to eradicate this misery. It seemed a minor wound, but when the condition went from bad to worse...
She tried to speak to Rama. For sake of goodness Bhikhari had bought a new Nokia mobile, but Kari deliberately stayed buried in her maternal calls to avoid lending it. Lately Lajo could not endure anymore.

"Even if Rama were here, what could he do? Has he ever done anything for his family? So he would do just today!"

She took her son, herself. And walked to Doctor Ojha. On foot. Misery piled on misery. Lajo's slippers broke. She went barefoot to seek treatment. Dr. Ojha diagnosed a bone disease and advised her to see Dr. Beldar. He did not charge a fee; how could he, when Lajwanti had nothing? That two or three hundred rupees Rama sent, monthly; barely fed a stomach. Should one feed to thrive or raise a child?

But Dr. Beldar was not such a philanthropist. He tore off a bill of five thousand. First money, then treatment! He also added that if treatment was not done immediately, her son would remain lame for life.

Lajwanti, in tattered clothes, with injured feet, ran back home clutching her son. She began to beg Bhikhu and Kari for any kind of assistance. And this was exactly what Kari wanted. She said, "Could have helped you, Money is there, but the passbook is unseen since long."

Lajo understood immediately. Spitting upon her face, she ran back towards the market. Where she was going, she did not know; she just kept running, gasping for air. At one point, she stopped, and the world began to race; the earth began to spin. Exhausted by fatigue, hunger, and thirst, she was so shattered that she collapsed unconscious. But look at a mother's love. She kept the child safe in her arms!

Nearby was the famous sweet shop of two brothers, Mitthu Ram and Tittu Ram. Mitthu saw her and leapt to lift Lajo; Tittu caught the child. Both brought them into the shop. Tittu splashed water from a glass; Lajo came to her senses. She grabbed that very glass and drank the water in great gulps. Mitthu felt pity; he offered *Rasgullas*. The hunger of a hundred lifetimes within Lajwanti attacked the food instantly;

four *Rasgullas* vanished in four seconds. Mitthu offered more. This time, shame overtook Lajo, and she kept the dignity of humanity. But the baby was hungry too. He could not eat grain, but hunger gnawed at him as well. Lajwanti touched the *Rasgulla* to his lips thinking it might be for the son, that he can eat, and what happened next is he latched onto it in such a way that since then, sweets have become his first and favorite food.

Lajo, when conscious enough,
"I have no money but I can wash dirty dishes." she said, choking.
"I cannot make you work. I do not know you. And I did not ask for money though." Mithu understood the pain in her heavy throat.

She folded her hands.
"Why are there no more humans like you on this hell?"
A wide smile stretched across Mithu's puffed cheeks.
"You look troubled. Tell me. I will help if I can."

A ray of hope descended into Lajo's eyes with floods of tears.
"This is my lamp of linage. *Chirag* of my house. Crippled in one leg. He needs treatment now or he will remain disabled forever. Five thousand are needed. My family values jealousy over humanity. My husband is punishment from a past life. I wander like a madwoman. God gave me one son and made him lame. Where do I go? Sometimes I wish to jump off a hill with him. so that I can be escaped from this inhumane world."

"No. please. No need of that. I do not know if you speak truth or just an act. But God made you faint at my doorstep. There must be a reason. I will help you. Right or wrong is God's concern. Since the concern is about his bright future so here I give you five thousand. You need this, so do not refuse. Do hurry, run to the hospital. Need more assistance, please tell me!"

Lajwanti's tears were not stopping anyway, but this divine man had snatched the words from her throat.
"How do I thank you?"
She just kept weeping, hands folded, she wept.
"I will try my best to return this. This debt will remain upon me all my life. A sweet debt."

Saying this, she ran. To the hospital, to that Beldar. She deposited the money, and the treatment was successful. Now the baby had no lame life. Now there was no trouble; a moment of peace came into Lajwanti's lap and veil. Her beloved son was growing faster and notorious where which was concerning but even more than that..

No one But Kari. That burnt-faced wretch. What would she not do? She would lock the kitchen, threaten repeatedly to throw them out of the house! She even beat bud like Tulsi! As a result of malnutrition, and due to a lack of proper food, Lajo with his children dried up like withered wood, to skin and bone. Milk would not form in her body, but the hungry child became irritable. He possessed every trait that Lajo had developed in her bad circumstances. To ensure the child did not become malnourished, once again, without telling anyone, Lajwanti took Tulsi and her son and left for her natal home, her *Naihar!*

Narrator :
And now begins the real story, around which this tale revolving, which you see hanging on every chapters! Now every emotion is about to be double! Every line is a story in itself! The prologue is this fierce. whose introduction is so colossal! Imagine that abyss.

***

10. Kashinath and Kangli-Mangli!

And so, my dear friend, how do you fare? In these restless, suffocating days of struggle, our discourse remained a forgotten debt. As for the life of Lajwanti, it is a path of thorns; what more can one utter? For now, the dust has settled into a semblance of order. A new life has descended upon this earth, only to increase the planet's weary burden. Some years ago, it was not a child but a shard of glass that was born, pricking the peace of all, driving Lajwanti to the precipice of her wits, and holding the entire household hostage to his theatrical whims.

His agile antics and rogue-like comedies kept the neighborhood in a state of perpetual riot. Yet, you shall find yourself a devotee of his villainous charms. Hence hereby, tighten your grip upon your quilt, sit firm, and let us witness what marvels Kashinath creates within the Kishor clan.

Scene I.

"Kashi! Oh, Kashi! Where has the knave vanished again? Can he not stay rooted for a single moment? Tulsi, have you seen Kashi?"

"Nay, Amma!" Tulsi replied, her voice devoid of even a spark of interest. "Who would seek to set eyes upon that wilding? He who exists only to meddle in the affairs of others! He must be, amongst his band of outcasts by the pond, trailing his buffalo."

Scene II.

Kashi and his comrades were busy bathing, though they splashed themselves with more vigor than they did their beasts - buffalos'.

Among brats one of them, Kanhaiya shouted:
"Hehe! Hurray! Kashi! Let us place a wager. Yester-eve, upon Kalua's television, I saw a race of motor-cars. We possess no engines, but we have our buffaloes, do we not? What do you?"
"Aye! Let us see what mettle you art made of!"
Kanhaiya laid the terms: "The wager is this: he who triumphs shall claim Mangli as his own!"
"Such a prize! Now, lad, I shall show you your place! Hurrah! Move, Phaguniya! your master's bride is at stake! you must win, for if you wants to earn that new bell for your neck?"
Phaguniya chewed her cud off then, Bellowed as if saying deal is done. And the race commenced. Kanhaiya led the charge, but Alas! his gaze fell upon Mangli in some distance. His small heart wove a thousand dreams in an instant, and lost in that imaginary world, he sank into the depths of the pond. When the silt settled, Kashi had won the prize.

Kanhaiya muttered, "Today Mangli is thine; tomorrow shall be mine, mark my words!"
"Aye! Tomorrow shall always be thine, but today," Kashi laughed, the sound echoed across the pond, "today is mine!!"

Kanhaiya's heart broke as it did every sun-up, and he chased Kashi with murderous intent. Such was the innocence gifted by their society; but what is that to us? Kashi, spurred by the victory, raced his beast buffalo to the cattle-shed where Naval Kishor was waiting with his cane poised like a scepter of judgment. The old man had been released from his prison, aged and weathered by time.
"you come now? Behold, the sun has climbed to the head! Shall the morning's chores be cut in the noon? And who shall cut the fodder, your grandsire?"

"Aye! you only will cut it, my grandsire! Whenever I attempt the task, I find myself dangling from the handle! Oh, what ails you? My grandsire has grown old, leaning upon a staff. Are you not aged, Grandfather?" Kashi giggled, a sharp, metallic sound.

"you wretched brat! Stand your ground! I took this cane for your very skin! you dare to call me old? Behold, behold for a second!"

Kishor chased Kashi, who led the old man in a merry-go-round across the entire shed. Kashi's tongue was a foul instrument, unloved by the masses, for his deeds mirrored his speech. Kishor called him '*Baanda*' (pronounce: बांड़ा) the fool. And so the days of the Fool passed: every dawn, a new catastrophe.

Scene III.

Mangli was the daughter of Mishri Mandal. Born upon *Mangalvar*, the Tuesday, she was named after the day as, Mangli. no great ceremony graced her naming. Should the sweetness of one's life turn sour, one need only whisper 'Kangli-Mangli,' and she would arrive to orchestrate their ruin. Despite her tender years, she possessed a vocabulary of curses that could carpet a hall.

One day, kashi with Mangli, hand's in hand~
"Amma! I am to be wedded!"
"What madness do you babble now? Cease there for once!"
"Listen, me yaar! Truly, you should find a better hobby than striking me always! Aye come to the point, I go to wed Mangli. I have informed Kanhaiya; the arrangements are complete. If you wish to join, then come! If not!" Kashi blew a kiss toward the horizon, kissing Mangli. "I shall wed without mother or sire. I depart for the temple; say not that I did not summon you!"

In that moment, Ramprasad arrived like a sudden storm and turned the ear-key to Kashi's silence. 'Is this the lesson you have mastered, you base-born wretch!?'

"Oh? You? So suddenly!"
Lajo bowed to touch his feet; the frost between them had thawed. Ramprasad had followed her to her Natal's house, vowing that until he secured a government job, he would not show his face in his own village. Mean time he now use to visit to see Lajo often in his Natal's home.

"Forget ME. Look at this creature; is his tongue a mouth or a sickle? It cuts with every breath! Tell me, you mule, is this what your mother has taught you?"
"Now who are you?" Kashi retorted.
A slap rang out, sharp as a whip.
"Not 'Who' but 'A fire.!' And I am your sire!"
That single blow sufficed to dampen Kashi's loincloth.
"Send him to any private school nearby immediately. If he roams thus, he shall turn into a brute of the fields!"

Lajwanti fretted over Kashi's future too; such a wild, uncurbed spirit surely promised a life of infamy. From this age itself, the lad's heart was entangled in romantic follies! Lajo sought solace in every shrine, every tomb, and every temple. Her prayer was singular: 'Grant Kashi a righteous mind!' Yet, the heavens remained silent, for every miracle required a sacrifice, a rooster, a heap of sweets, a heavy coin. And where the shadow of expense fell, Lajo's devotion felt the sting of chili pepper.

Scene IV.

Lajo grew formidable. She barred Kashi from the cattle and cut the fodder with Kishor herself. The task of carrying midday meal to yards, fell to Tulsi.

Kashi was exiled to a distant private school from which there was no escape. Had he tried for if, he had to meet the 'Jallad' an executioner masquerading as a master, who blinked his eyes rhythmically as he delivered his blows. On Sundays, the respite was denied, for he was sent to Madrasa. to learn the curves of Urdu. There, the master was no teacher but a butcher, who would pluck the hair from one's temples with such cruelty it would peel the very spirit.

What little spirit remained was crushed at night by "Chhi Chhi Mama," Kashi's maternal uncle. Though folks speak of the bond between uncle and nephew, here it was a lie. Lajo surrendered the reins of education to this uncle, and this man was interested in beating more than teaching. For a trifle, he would dangle Kashi over the courtyard well. Should Kashi nod in sleep, a blow would rattle his skull. Once, he struck Kashi with a radish; the vegetable snapped, leaving half in the uncle's hand and half in Kashi's mouth, his lip split and bleeding was another painful scar. Fear ruled. Wherever Chhi Chhi appeared, Kashi's trousers turned wet in terror. Still, the poor lad could not focus. Fear was heavy, but the heart, Sir, rested still with Mangli.

However, the rough edges of his tongue were smoothed. His circle of pals, shifted from Mangli's ragtag band to the scholars. Some of were Gulshan, Bino, and the most cherished, Adil, Kashi's soul-brother from another's mother. As the proverb goes, 'A man is known by the company he keeps,' and Kashi molded his studious friends into rogues like himself. They became a pack of refined rascals, creating tempests within the school, wandering the streets, and sharing the weight of the master's cane. In company, even pain becomes a feast.

Four or five years trickled by like an epoch for Kashi. This was the whole world for him. Unknown that, this was but his mother's home, until one day.

Scene V.

Here Ramprasad arrives, his face is blooming like a flower, laden with sweets and new raiment. Your intuition serves you well: Ramprasad had secured a station! He was now a government clerk in the Block office. Whether of high or low rank, I cannot say, for Ramprasad was a man of few words. Let us see what simmers beneath Kishor's thatched roof.

"Aye! I shall trouble you no longer. I have come to take my Lajo home forever! And this time, let any soul dare to raise a voice against her!"
Kishor laughed, "Hah! What trouble could my own daughter bring,
Rajai Raja?"
"Jamai Raja," Ahilya corrected, clearing her throat.
"Hmph! Jamai Raja! She is your treasure; take her when you will. But save my dignity now. I am the one who holds this village in my debt of freedom, which is why no one speaks to me at my face; yet all smells the change in the wind. You understand, don't you?'

Just then, Kashi arrived from school, he aired his shoes and bag, flying in different directions. He was poised to bolt for the fields when he saw his father's face, and a familiar dampness claimed his trousers. Suddenly, the boy became a portrait of manners. He got to know that suitcases were being corded and bundles tied. "To our own home," they said.

Kashi had lived until now in the illusion that his grandfather's house was his world. A strange mist descended upon his soul. The thrill of a new horizon clashing with the agony of a first parting. To go, or to stay? Where one was exciting another was exiling! He ran to tell his friends, and especially Mangli. When Kashi erupted with the News, was no more Good. Kashi was radiant with excitement, but the others were draped in gloom.

Mangli asked, her voice trembling like a reed:
"So, you will be gone now?"
"Aye! This very day!"
"And you will never return?"
"Nay, nay! I shall return! I must but see my home, dwell there a while, and then I shall fly back to you!"
Mangli lingered on her words, 'Aaaa-ye... then it's fine." A tear shimmered in her eye, even as a smile graced her lips.
The air cleared; friends and foes alike gathered. Kashi met them all, washing away old grievances in the tide of departure.

The hour of exodus arrived. The Scorpio stood at the threshold. Kashi climbed in first, while Mangli's heart sank the deepest. In one pair of eyes sat the spark of adventure; in the other, the heavy blink of a long wait. Both love birds gazes was locked, two mirrors reflecting a shared history. until the distance blurred the image. All that remained was a silhouette etched upon the retina.

Like a tragedy upon the silver screen, Kashi forgot to leave behind a token or take a memento. The Scorpio rolled forward, and the hearts of Lajwanti, Tulsi, and Kashi, remained behind, stretching like shadows in the evening sun, lingering... lingering and lingering...

***

11. Love Triangle!

August 2014

The Scorpio had finally exhaled its passengers at their destination. Every brow hung heavy with the leaden weight of memories, and Kashi, lost in the labyrinth of his own thoughts, had drifted into a deep sleep. Ramprasad attempted to gather the boy in his arms, but Kashi stirred, his eyes snapping open. He descended from the vehicle of his own accord, A whole new world was standing before him, And he was known to none. Though Kashi was born here yet this was the first time his feet had ever truly touched this land in his whole consciousness.

Before him stood a house of cement that looked more like a skeletal ruin than a home. Nearby sat a lonely well, to the East rose mountains draped in mystery, and to the South lay the iron veins of the railway line. The thundering passage of trains became Kashi's solitary wellspring of joy. There was no Kanhaiya here, no Adil, nor the familiar faces of Kangali or Mangli or anything like that. In this barren orchard of loneliness, Kashi knelt in the backyard and sowed a single mango stone. Naming it "Horlicks."
Such was the limit of his world of memory and also his vocabulary was a tiny treasury containing only this milk drink and the sweetness of *Bambaiya Mithai.*

As March gave way to April, the season of Admission is open! yet the family's pockets remained hollowed by the bite of poverty. Ramprasad had found labor, but the hunger of four mouths is a greedy beast that one man's wage can seldom sate. Thus, Kashi was surrendered to the local government school. It was whispered that once the wages flourished, he would be sent to a finer institution.

In their former life, Kishor's wealth had paved the way for private tutors, but here, how could one head bare the weight of four heavy crowns?

That government school gifted Kashi a brother of the soul, a '*langotiya yaar*' named Madho. A cowboy of the same village, Madho possessed a complexion like midnight and a tongue that wagged with the wind of a thousand exaggerations. He was so painfully thin that his ribs appeared as desiccated sticks of wood through his skin. In Madho's company, Kashi's old spirits returned; the days of Kanhaiya were reborn. Kashi would set out for the temple of learning, but the path would often lead him astray into the wild embrace of forests and hills. Only when the sun dipped low would he plunge into the canal to wash away the sins of his truancy before returning home. But the "good" students, those harborers of petty truths, would whisper to Lajo, "Today Kashi did not go to school, Chachi."
And Chachi would inform Chacha. I mean, Ramprasad.

I know not what venom stirred in Ramprasad's veins, whenever he saw Kashi, he beat him without restraint. Kashi responded in kind. He made Ramprasad chase him through the village, then allowed himself to be caught, only to be beaten soundly. Stubborn as he was, he kicked back too. Ramprasad beat him like a merciless man, pinning him against walls, striking until breath itself seemed cornered..

Blood and scratches were common visitors. Still, Kashi spent his days with Madho, he roamed the woods or the markets with Madho, or if nothing then huddled in Madho's hut to watch the magic of the "T.B." (Television). Kashi yearned to watch it until his eyes grew weary.

Back then at his maternal grandmother's house, Kashi used to roam around to get visuals of any glimpse coming out from someone's television, if yes! He quickly used to get in but was quickly be chased

away like a stray dog because he could not sit still; first the floor, then the chair, then the bed, until he was leaping like a dervish. It was a ritual of restlessness. But Madho was different. Whatever Kashi commanded, Madho obeyed; whatever Madho dreamt, Kashi pursued.

The dye of this new companionship was staining Kashi's character. He was becoming a reflection of his surroundings, a shadow of his old self again, worse than before. He forgot his old friends. New ones arrived. If Mangli was not there, then Payaliya was. Just ten steps away from Kashi's house. And for competition, Madho existed, just like Kanhaiya once did.

The seasons turned, and Kashi began to spit filth and curses, even in the presence of Lajo and Rama. Rama would thrash him still, but years of such 'sustenance' had turned Kashi's skin into the thick hide of a buffalo. Neither hand nor foot made an impression on his layer of stubbornness.

Rama believed Lajo had spoiled him. Infact, he had come ruined from her maternal home. He would turn his wrath upon Lajo as well, both mother and son would suffer the lash together. This ignited a fire in Kashi; not for his own pain, but for the sacrilege of a man striking his mother. He would strike back with all his meager strength, but what is the might of a sapling against an axe? Rama saw this defiance as a stain upon his honor and would beat the boy until he hit the dust.

Thus the rhythm of violence continued until one fateful day.
"Rama, cries come from your house far too often. What do you do to Kashi? Do you intent to snuff out the only candle of your lineage completely?" Dhadphad Lal asked calmly.

"All of them are useless specimens. Tulsi is still manageable, but this mother and son have turned my cot upside down. What can I do?

My anger does not stay caged. Kashi's face itself looks like a loafer's. Just seeing it irritates me."

Dhadphad Lal let out a lethal laughter.
"Brother, however he is, he is still a lamp. Think a little. If beating treated people, everybody would have been a collector today. Everyone studies, but not everyone learns. Explain with love. Enroll him in a good school. He is a resilient and determined child. If he find not the right path, he shall surely find fame in infamy, perhaps by stealing away some man's daughter! What then?"

"Hush, man! Speak only of auspicious things!" Rama countered. "Are you a friend or a foe? Do I strike him only to witness such a dark harvest one day?"

"Yet, your blows are the very seeds of his rebellion, Rama. Ponder this well!"
With those words, true to his name, Dhadphad Lal pedaled away noisily, leaving Rama standing in the shadow of his own doubt.

Rama resolved to send Kashi to a private school. Not for the sake of wisdom, but to sever the bond with Madho, a bad company. The two friends were torn asunder, yet their loyalty initially held fast. However, the tides soon shifted. Kashi began to reclaim the "good boy" within him. Still, he would find time to meet Madho. Not for friendship, but for the temptation of television.

Then came the day of the reckoning.
"Do you come to meet me, or my TV?" Madho asked directly, his voice sharp with accusation.
"I come to meet you, my friend." Kashi replied, his spirit shrinking. "why comes this sudden bitterness?"

"Nothing. Just that Payaliya says you stare at her a lot. You find excuses to go to her house." Madho had already woven this lie into his truth; he sought only a confession.

"Nay, brother! These are but phantom tales!" Kashi pleaded. "Where is the time for such follies? My days are consumed by the school, and my evenings by my father's lessons. I steal a way to see you with great difficulty! 'Its she who haunts my doorstep with her petty errands. I speak to her only for your sake; otherwise, I would not even deign to look upon her face!"

"But she says she likes you." Madho cried unwilling, the words tasting like ash. Yet compelled.

"So what is that to me? I can barely manage my own miseries! I yearn to flee my own house. Is my butcher of a father not enough, that you must now speak to me like a stranger? I tell you, stay away from her. She is a witch who seeks to drive a wedge between our souls!"

"So that you can get closer to her?"
Madho twisted the meaning into poison.
"What even are you spitting, Madho? Is our bond so fragile? Fine then! Since she professes a love for me, I shall tell her to cast me aside and offer her heart to you!"
"I have no need of it!"
"Then what is the grievance?"

"I went to her but a moment ago," Madho confessed, his voice trembling. "I sought her company, but she spat upon my presence. She said to me: 'Come not near me, I feel disgusted by you! My heart belongs to Kashi now, not to you! I hover near you only to find a path to him, you blackened creature!' Huh!"

It was not that Madho had always been this way for Payaliya; in Kashi's absence, he and Payaliya had shared a special bond. But Kashi's arrival had wounded Madho's small heart by parting two souls away.

"You were a good friend." Madho continued, his voice rising in a tragic crescendo. "But oh, Kashi! I wish you had never entered in my life! I am not like you, but is that my sin? You too threw more strings than friendship at Payaliya!"
"You are mistaken! I spoke to her only for your honor!" Kashi is trying to clarify himself, but Madho leaped between his words,
"Speak not of honor! Our friendship is a ghost! I desire no such selfish companion. I am okay with my dark skin, for at least I am not a hypocrite like you! Begone from this place! You are an ill omen! Show me not your face, for I feel disgusted by you!"

Kashi was not stung by the word "hypocrite," but the sheer velocity of this very love triangle had hurled him onto the hard pavement of reality. Of all the friends he had known, none had wounded him like this. Madho acted as if nothing had never existed between them.
"Is this truly what he thought of me?" Kashi mused, his mind a cauldron of dark thoughts. "If I am selfish, is he not the same? One hand alone cannot produce a clap! If Payaliya loves him not, what power have I over her heart? For this trifle, he had shattered years of loyalty of mine!
I may not be the perfect friend, but he is no saint either! Have I not earned even a grain of his trust? He used me! What me, He was never worthy of my faith! Huh! The peasant!"

As Kashi walked toward his home, a flood of resentment surged within him. His hatred for Payaliya grew, and the embers of that rage soon scorched his memory of Madho. The very meaning of friendship had changed for him. For the first time, loyalty had left a scar. He wept for Kanhaiya, for Adil, and for Mangli. Once again, he was utterly alone.

He sat beside "Horlicks," pouring out the epic of his sorrow into the abyss of saplings violently. As tears pooled in his eyes, the leaves of the small plant seemed to droop in sympathy. Horlicks, too, felt the dampness of the boy's grief. Lowering his flowers, even Horlicks seemed to be moist and cross.

***

12. Big Brother, Biggest Bandit!

Now if perhaps you remember, Rama's family does not live alone. Kari and Bhikhari also share the household, a joint family stitched together by habit, not harmony. And when two swords live under one roof and never clash, the story sounds hard to swallow. Okay, since everyone has their own rooms, their own pots, so their lentils cook separately. Still, one that veranda is common, which is why war sometimes breaks out. Not that there is ever much of a cause, something worthy enough for open abuse. But Kari's irritation was not a born of today. So why did it suddenly spill over now. Spill it did, and it still does. She burns, broods, boils, and turns to ash from within seeing the blushed cheeks of Lajwanti.

As you know, a jealous soul often tries to prove itself superior, or at the very least, demands equality. You understand my justification; if not, let us cast a glance into the hovel of Bhikhari Rai.

Scene I.

"What are you doing, Karu?" asked Bhikhari, rubbing tobacco in his palm with rhythmic habit.
"Can't you see? I am fastening the blade to this hoe!" she snapped, grinding her teeth.
"And for why, *Malkin*? Are you planning to cut someone's field's Trail., aren't you?" He grinned, revealing a row of yellowed, decaying teeth.

"I shall garden! In the backyard! And you, please go to your Godam. Naught of worth shall ever come from your hands, nor will you suffer me to toil. Don't you know? At the backyard, there mango sapling already rooted. Lajo will surely stake her claim to the very earth!" Kari's spite was beginning to bloom.

"What foolish you mutter! Where then shall Raje go? Shall he find his inheritance entangled in your curly bushes?"

"Is it a need for you to always pull my leg? I care not for your logic, what I know is Lajo very well! That house-breaker surely cast that mango seed with malice in her heart. In any case, You have sent our sons to Surat, you yourself will do nothing; so you begone to your Godam! Take your meal of lentils and rice from the kitchen; there is leftover pottage from yesternight. I have ground no chutney today, so eat your dry bread and be content. I am away!"

"As you command, My Queen," Bhikhari gasped, dusting off his shoulder-towel before heading to the well to invoke the heavens with a ritual bath.

Scene II.

Lajo, seeing the mango sprout, had planted brinjal, chili, tomato, coriander, and maize around it. Almost the entire crop had completed its days. Everything stood ripe at the threshold of harvest. And here Enters Kari, with her monologue:

'Look, look. Bravo, you sly witch. Did I not say she wants to swallow the whole land? Bhikhu might be blind, but I am not. You fly too high, do you not! Now see, you gossip-monger Lajo, how I bring you to your place."

Kari picked up the sickle. With the grace of a marauding elephant, she trampled the boundaries, her heavy feet crushing more than half the vibrant life beneath them.

'On one side, a verdant bride; on the other, a garden died.'

Lajo, hearing the rhythmic thud of destruction, emerged with a *neem*-twig between her teeth, binding her hair. She froze. An electric shock of horror surged through her veins, pinning her like stone. Her months of sweat and blood lay mangled; half-naked, half-bald. The scattered crop staring back at her with sightless, traumatized eyes.

This time, Kari had overstepped the final line. Lajo had endured much before, but this garden was watered with her very blood. She had nurtured it; Her eyes darted; there lay the hoe. She seized it and struck Kari's elbow with a sickening thud.

The sudden blow sent a jarring tremor through Kari's frame, leaving her arm momentarily paralyzed. In a feral reflex, Kari lashed out with the sickle in her left hand, but Lajo dodged. This escape only stoked Kari's fury; she lunged, clawing at Lajo, grabbed her arm, and sank her teeth deep into Lajo's flesh with the strength of a beast out of vengeance.

Death itself seemed to rattle in Lajo's throat. Yet Lajo was no less; She tore at Kari's hair with desperate strength, but what power dwells in a frame so withered by toil? Kari held the flesh, Lajo held the hair. Pain was their common language, but Lajo bore the heavier toll. Kari's venomous teeth tore through the muscle, rending the pulp of her arm. It looked as if a rabid dog had mauled her. The two remained locked in this macabre dance until Rama arrived to pry the serpents apart.

The ruin belonged to Lajo, and the sin to Kari. Yet, surveying the carnage, Rama delivered his justice: a stinging slap across Lajo's face. Which of course was unjust, and but this time the fire would not be doused so easily.

With eyes bloodshot and an arm dripping gore, Lajo shoved Rama with

such ferocity that he stumbled back. She thrust her mangled limb before his eyes. "This hag is a cannibal, your mother like Bhabhi! See how she has feasted upon my flesh, and yet you strike me?
you impotent! you eunuch!"

Before her tirade could even start, Bhikhari arrived. At his sight, Kari dissolved into performative wails. Bhikhu's heart, soft as wax, melted instantly then and there eyeing petty hog Kari.

"You and your witch-wife! There was peace until both arrived. This harbinger of grief has brought only havoc! Oh, my Kari! Let me see where you are hurt."

"She has shattered my very bone, Bhikhu! I will not bide here! your kin seek only to drink my blood! If my own father will not take me, so be it. I shall cast myself from the cliffs of the nearest mountain, but I shall stay in this house no longer!" Kari sobbed, picking bits of Lajo's flesh from between her teeth with her fingernails.

"Peace, my Kari! Oh, the treachery of these two! You will go nowhere. This very day, the walls shall be divided! I shall summon Raje at once. I am weary of beholding these ill-omened faces! Come, Kari, let us seek Bhailu Miyan to tend your hurts. Oh, my poor Kari!"

As much as Bhikhari slaved for Kari's whim, Rama poured scorn upon Lajo. He abandoned her with her tattered flesh and departed for his office. Kashi and Tulsi remained home from school. Tulsi clung to her mother, weeping, but Kashi shed no tear. He had become a man these days; tears were a luxury his heart could no longer afford. Gathering his melancholy, he set about performing his mother's chores. Lajo sat in the silence, staring at her bald orchard, her eyes dry, for the well of her tears had finally run to dust.

Scene III.

Rajeshri arrived at the stroke of nine. During prime time, Kari had well-schooled Bhikhari on his lines, what to say. If women were allowed to speak between men then what's were a need of a puppet like Bhikhari.

The house meeting was set with Two of Yes-men and One of Puppet.
Bhiku, calling to the action: "There are three plots of land, four kattha each. The fourth shall go to Bhuniya. Take what you will, but leave the roadside plot for me. Our father decreed that the eldest should hold the gateway. Let the house also be carved up; the surveyor comes tomorrow. Mark his lines and give your consent."

The elder brother had spoken; the heads bowed in silent submission. And the meeting was over before any debate or discussion. There in through a small hole in the wall, Tulsi watched the entire short story, and later whispered the chronicle to her mother.

When Rama, after the meeting came to his room,
"Why are you so hollow, Rama?" Lajo spat. "If you were merely to nod your head like a toy, then what's the meaning of calling this council?
Why was Raje be called from Delhi? If our voices carry no weight, they might have done their will in shadows by themselves!"

"your tongue wags too much!" Rama roared. "If you were peeping out, why did you not step forward to join in? Have no grace, no honor for how elders to be treated! Don't you Know that an elder brother is a second father? How would you know? You knows only how to tear the hair of the elder's....."

"Does it not move you that she tore the meat from my bone too?"

"Run away or I shall kill you this very end. Shall see your meat in your grave, bastard woman. Always spewing poison. Get the hell out of here."

Scene IV. Narrator :

The surveyor came, the lines were drawn, and from this division rose another tale. Years ago, Baiju Babu's lungs filled with water due to alcohol and intoxication. Narayan Babu pulled him to the grave. In the settlement, fourth hovel fell to his worthless only son, Bhuneshri, known to all as Bhuniya. A true heir to his father's vices, he lived for the bottle and the smoke. Now, Rama and Bhuniya sit upon Lajo's very heart, drowning their senses in spirits and revelry.

The room in which Rama and family was surviving, felled in the lap of Bhikhu, and his greed was so restless that the very day after the division, he stood on Rama's chest. "Vacate this room instantly; As I must set my house in order!" Rama was as meek as a sacrificial lamb, moved his world from one ruin to another. And the land that fell to Rajeshri? It was the very yard where Horlicks, the lone companion of Kashi's solitude, had made his nest. Giving possibilities of a sure clash of clans.

Heaven alone knows what follows up now. Life, which was already a mountain, grows steeper still. The atmosphere thickens with the scent of an approaching storm. The needle of the clock has returned to its starting point for the another lash of loincloths. I mean the conflict of dignity. hah! let us see what the turning gears reveal up next.

***

13. into the abyss of a first love!

One sweeps away moments, as a restless sleeper, kicks at the face when night goes deeper. Madho never saw Kashi again, because Kashi never returned to those lanes after then. The wing called friendship, on which he once brushed kisses off valleys, that very wing was struck down by a petty hunter's sling, Payaliya. Now Kashi looks at friendship, love and all such lofty nouns with a squint of mockery.

The boy who use to run away from home, who lived on constant kicks from kin, suddenly started staying indoors. But the household had larger tangles to untie, so this quiet shift caused no ripple. No one knew which class Kashi studied in, but he had studied enough to grow into oodles of adulthood. And where there is adulthood, there are tales of the heart. To the poor soul, however, these matters seemed a farce, a hollow vanity, until the day a certain "someone" appeared.

Like a living corpse, dead yet breathing, he rode his Humsafar, the bicycle, to school every day, and returned the same way, drained and dull. He remained blissfully unaware that he was being shadowed, Someone had begun circling this gruff bull. Kashi remained unaware of his surroundings. He had already lost at friendship, and at home there was a daily blunder parade, what else was there to say for a lad who has to hear haunted howls and havoc hailing every hour in his hacked hoven .

The clock of Diya was running faster as she cannot bear patience for what she was feeling. Therefore a day Diya finally found her wick. without a hint of hesitation, boldly she raced her steel mare, her bicycle, alongside Kashi's Humsafar, without losing her way.

Without wasting a while, She confessed the secrets of her heart. Unknown of that whom she confessed was an untameable ox, or if not but accepting her proposal was least that was unfortunate to be done in this manner. Kashi halted his cycle and unleashed a lecture so scathing that the wick of Diya's love flickered and died in an instant. Her mare bolted in the opposite direction and disappeared.

The only good in this encounter was that the poison brewing within Kashi for months finally found a vent. As he rode away, the irritation faded, replaced by a strange peace and a lightness of spirit. Like a constipated patient finally relieved by a morning cup of tea. His silence was shattered, and upon the rubble, the foundation of a new life could be laid. Yet, the sting of Madho's old betrayal remained a constant, aching thorn who pricked him occasionally with subtle sting. Above all...

In Kashi's own class sat a peer named Trishna. In her simple nature lay something distinct. Her laughter gifted Kashi a peculiar, rhythmic warmth, like the scent of parched earth meeting the first summer rain. She lacked the vanity of other maidens and could barely manage her own whims, and perhaps it was this very lack of artifice that charmed him. Bitter from past wounds, he had never paid much heed before, but now that he had returned to the land of the living, his gaze fell first upon her. Her small gestures, the way she offered notes unasked, the "theft" of his books, the intentional stumbles in his path, and the way she would slide into the seat beside him at every opportunity.

Kashi was not one for clinging, yet he found, he quite enjoyed her proximity. Previously, he would flee from such things, but now he lingered. Indeed, he began to seek her out for the sake of a shared jest. For the first time in his waking senses, he was falling into the abyss of a first love.

With her innocence and childish grace, Trishna hung her portrait in the window of Kashi's head and heart. Where he began to gaze upon her even in dreams. The domestic ruins of Kashi's home began to sound like music to his ears, and Kari's movements seemed like a rhythmic dance. Everything turned sweet, honeyed, and picturesque. To Kashi, the world appeared matured by love. Despite his many attempts, Trishna refused to share her number. The zenith of their courtship was reached when the two swans began to exchange love letters. Words that could not be uttered in the thick of a crowd were etched into ink. Under the shadow of youth's brief glow, the heat of those letters sustained them for twenty-four hours instead of eight.

Kashi writes:

"I am the Volume, you the Verse therein,
I am the Rhythm, you the Melody's kin.
I am the Twilight, you the Evening Star,
I am the Night, you the Moon from afar.
I am the Tempest, you the Halcyon Sea,
I am the Ember, you the Warmth in me.
I am Defeat, you the Laurel's prize,
I am the Passion, you the Love that sighs.
I am the Blossom, you the Fragrance rare,
I am the Alpha, you the Omega's prayer.
I am the Labor, you the Path I tread,
I am the Morrow, you the Day widespread.
I am the Note, you the Instrument's soul,
I am the Poet, you the Muse, who makes me whole."

And in reply, the parchment would read:
"Bravo! Truly grand! Perhaps you should study as well, lest the final scrolls reveal: 'I am the Scholar promoted, and you are the Dunce detained!'"

Kashi writes:

"Why did you not come to me today? Have you grown so busy lately? And what was so important near that Battery fellow? His voice is so thin even a microphone would need earphones to hear him. How do you tolerate such lads? yes! I know I do not study much, but you are far swifter of wit than him. Anyway. I always say you, even if you stop studying you will still top. Write it down. And you have time for every stray path, but none to come to me. Is it because I spoke loudly yesterday? If yes! forgive me! My temper is a beast, I cannot tether, but I never meant to wound you. Sorry Trishu! I shall be more mindful. And since you did not meet me today, tomorrow you owe me double time. I do not care about any excuses. It's one of the morning. You have given me nothing else, but have certainly stolen my sleep. I go to bed now. Once and over again, I am sorry, Trishu! I shall not be angry again. Please do not drive away from me. Always stay with me.
Yours Kaju."

Trishna replies:

"Battery took my notebook without asking and was not returning it. I thought to tell you, but who knows not your temper? You would have sought a quarrel, so I remained silent! I do not like his voice either. And what you wrote about him, haha! very funny! And yes! I am angry with you! You shout at me all the time. Many times it's not even my fault. One day I shall get fed up with this anger. You always say sorry Trishu, I shall be mindful. But I know well what you are mindful of: your own anger, not me! And today I did come to you, but your friends mattered more. I am of no value to you! Go, I shall not talk to you! Do not write any letters. Huh. I hate you! But.
Yours Trishu."

Life rolled forward on the wheels of these childish whims. Relationships turned from tart to sweet, and love deepened. But since every grand romance seems destined to shatter, how could this pair of swans remain happy for long?

Kashi found immense delight in anything that was transpiring. Such alluring days had not visited him in an age. He had no complaints; his life was flowing like a clear, unhindered stream, until the boat suddenly split into two. Kashi discovered that he was merely an option, a pawn in a game of temptation, a mere source of entertainment. A time pass.

Kashi's final letter:

"I heard something this day regarding you. What strange, delusional tales these people spin! Haha! They know nothing of us. didn't they. Trishna? I felt as if I died for a moment. A fog descended before my eyes. Anubhav claimed that after I departed, he saw you and Madhav together, engaged in... those things. He tried his utmost to convince me. But I know my Trishna is not such a creature. Therefore, I write this letter even before I have shed my uniform. I have faith in you that You are exactly as I see you."

Upon reaching the school, his first act was to deliver the letter. The chaotic noise and the instability of the atmosphere compelled Trishna to read it right there in the classroom. The truth was out; there was no longer any reason for delay or fear.

During the interval, Trishna stood before Kashi.
"What you have heard is true. Regarding Madhav and me. But it is not your fault. He had all but abandoned me, and it was you who held my hand. I shall never forget that, but Madhav is my first love. I am sorry."
(The words were perhaps easy to utter.)

As fate would have it, the final period after the interval was for games. Devdas Kashi spent the remainder of the day with his head upon Anubhav's shoulder. The day dissolved into depression and tears. And these tears were not merely for the thirst of love; they flowed for every tragedy that Kashi, the "man," had suppressed for a lifetime.

The essence was this. Trishna was already involved with someone else. Finding no proper worth or attention there, she used Kashi to incite jealousy, Would that it were a lie!

If only it were not so, then at least Kashi's world of thoughts would not have been so violently shattered and scattered. Later, it was whispered that Trishna liked Kashi, but his anger drove her away. Yet, strangely, he felt no rage toward her. Instead, he sank in his own eyes. He began to curse himself, punish himself. Every trauma triangle, of his past betrayals became vivid and haunting even more.

Love is the best and worst feeling of this world.
He did not slept that entire night. The vigil of depression was kept in the garden of Horlicks. The moonlight filtered through the mango leaves, giving a silver glint to Kashi's tears. Today, Kashi told Horlicks nothing. They simply found solace in each other's shadows. A heavy heart full of thoughts, Kashi sat in abyss, sheltered by Horlicks, staring at the moon in pain... thinking... and thinking... and thinking...

***

14. A Holy Basil of your Heart!

Have you ever sought a tale where every character feels like the protagonist? Where at every turn, one thinks, 'Surely, this is the hero!' It is possible, indeed! If not, then our *Ram-parivaar* shall fulfill your quest. How, you ask? Then watch closely.

Ramprasad. The early days. A rift with his family, cast out of his own home. A harsh, grinding middle age. A household tangled in conflict, locked in constant skirmish with Lajwanti, life itself turning into a battlefield.

Lajwanti. The keeper of the household since childhood. No comfort in her early years, and in youth she lives as though death has already claimed her. Her blood boils, yet the question of womanhood shackles her rage.

Kashi. Born of the world's many vices, a thorn in the sight of his own parents. His character holds the promise of the future, while his present lies buried in the depths of adolescent folly.

And finally, Tulsi. About whom little has ever been openly said. Yet, as a reservoir appears tranquil upon the surface, it roils with hidden currents within.

Tulsi is slightly older than Kashi. Well built, graceful, with a romantic ease about her. A cryptic beauty that spills less from her face and more from her conduct. Beholding her, folk would say that when Lajo first arrived, she was just such a center of allure. She places little faith in vanity or adornment; the Heavens have crafted her with inherent grace.

She spends much of her time with her mother, Lajo, and whenever a moment allows, she tries her hand at typing upon Rama's mobile phone.

Unlike Kashi, She was not sent to a private academy; perhaps Rama found the government school a more fitting choice, and so she studied there. Presently, she is in the twelfth grade, cycling to and fro each day to school. She is not given to much chatter; she speaks only when spoken to, and no trace of envy or malice ever disturbs her rosy cheeks. True, she once tasted the nectar of love; with a bold heart, she had reached out to her beloved, but Alas! the conclusion was exactly what you might already know of what happens to a so called - first love.

However, that particular chapter has long since passed; now, Tulsi has found her own shrine. To put it briefly, the bud of Tulsi's heart once withered and fell, and she never raised her eyes again. Yet, another character in the background had already deemed Tulsi the heroine of his life. Through his jokes and jests, he constantly made her aware of his presence. When this humor transformed into a sense of love, none can say. None, perhaps, save for Time itself, for 'Samay' is the name of that character who deemed Tulsi the rudder of his life's pedestal. With the waters of his devotion and mirth, he kept Tulsi's spirit alive.

The two remain immersed in their digital conversations. Upon the glowing screen of the mobile, their laughter, their tears, their rage, and their unions all transpire before the screen. Such is the intoxication of their passion that a magnetic solitude exists between them every second.

Their life flows like a gentle, cool stream. In the tale of 'The Husband, The Wife, and the Other,' there is no 'other,' save perhaps for Ramprasad, who occasionally suffers from a ghostly suspicion. Often in the night, he would wake with a start, burst into Tulsi's room, and snatch the mobile from her hands.

The first time this occurred, Tulsi and Samay had only just exchanged numbers; their talk was not yet seasoned with spice, and so the 'butcher-hearted' father spared her soul.

But the vigilant Tulsi, and the Heavens who provided Samay with problems, also provided the solution in Kashi. Kashi understands all; he does not reveal the secrets to his stubborn father or his frail mother. His own tale of love remained unfinished, and he does not wish to see his sister meet a similar fate. Thus, before the 'butcher-hearted,' he stands guard like a 'soldier-hearted' sentinel, while the Almighty above writes one breathtaking trial after another. Consequently, the siblings who fought bitterly in childhood now believe in compromise, and Samay believes in drawing himself even closer to Tulsi.

Only a few days remain before the final boards of the twelfth grade, bringing the first omen of their separation. Tulsi shall remain here after the exams, but Samay, turning the wheels of his fate, shall depart for Kota to pursue engineering. Their impending parting grows cruel. The tale had only just begun; the intoxication had only just taken hold. Their youth had only stepped out of childhood; from whence did this sorrow of separation arise?

Restlessness grips them both. If only they could share a few memorable moments, it would add a dash of sweetness to the muddled draught of life. And so, Samay began to weave the tapestry of their final meeting: when, where, how, and for how long they would meet!

But fear was Samay's constant companion; it was his first time, after all! It is only natural. And in this difficult hour, his companion was his most loyal comrade, Pawan Kumar. He arranged all the 'settings' for the meeting. Only one final shot remained, and the picture would be complete: was to persuade Tulsi.

:Samay

Hi!

Tulsi:

Hello!

What r u doing?

Nothing much! Just sitting. u?

Same as u!

Okay, what's ur plans after boards?

What plans?

Graduation from here, simply.

Ah! that I know.

I meant, what about our meeting?

Who knows? Long distance, that is all.

Don't u wish to meet for one last time?

I want to,

very much!

But the family watches closely. You know that.

fear not!. Just tell me, do u want to meet?

Yes. A lot.

Then leave for school as usual tomorrow. Do not go to school. Before the turn, you will see Pawan. follow his bike. I'll meet u near the *Kali Mandir*.

r u planning to marry me?

Hush! don't be Silly!
Listen. From the temple we go to my room. My brother is in Patna for work. I live in the hostel. All boys there. No tension.

This is the last meeting. Do not refuse.
No force. ur choice. Say yes only if u love me.

Now u have started blackmailing too, hn?

When did I ever refuse? I want to meet too.

●●●

hehe! Then sleep now.
let me fix the planning.

Alright. But I am scared!.

Why fear? Have u not heard that song,
jab pyar kiya to darna kya...pyar kiya koi chori nhi kee, pal-pal aahen bharna kya...

Enough. Go now.

Do not panic.
Everything will be fine.

Hope so!

Love u so much.
Bye. Take care.

Love uuu nd misssss uuu sooo muchh.
Bye, cutie. Take care!

The date for youth's first meeting is set, time set, stage set, and the struggle as well! Samay, like a restless pilgrim, bows at the *Kali Mandir*, waiting for Tulsi. It is nearly noon. Today the air lacks its usual romance. A strange, ominous wind drifts by. Fear gnaws at him. His sixth sense keeps twitching his left eye. Yet he is consoling himself. "It is for the first time. That is why I am afraid. All will be well."

And here she comes. Tulsi. In her school uniform, slightly adorned today. Timid yet eager. As she reach: "Am I got too late?" she asks, hiding her nervousness behind a smile.

"No. I was just..." Samay avoids her eyes. "I was Just waiting for so long."

According to the plan, Samay moved ahead, flowing with Pawan, while Tulsi followed about ten paces behind with light footsteps.

The nerves of all were turning pale. The room was the very first in the hostel; anyone could see Tulsi entering a boys hostel, that to in a room, privately. Samay enters the room, whispering to himself with every step, 'This shall be but a conversation... perhaps.' In a few moments, Tulsi reaches the room. 'Come inside! If anyone sees, they may misunderstand,' Samay spoke softly. Pawan signaled Tulsi to enter. Both are now inside. Pawan stands guard outside. 'I shall watch here!' The breath of both comrades remained caught in their throats, yet the mask of manhood refused to slip away from their faces."

Here even after all these settings, every movement, every glimpse, is being captured by someone's eyes. For the first time, a girl had entered a boy's room in the hostel. Someone is keeping a steady, owl-like gaze upon them, like a living surveillance. They are in doubt: who is this girl? And what business is so pressing that the door has been shut?

While inside the room:
Tulsi stood by the mirror, brushing her hair back with her fingers. 'Samay, I know not why, but I feel very strange. Do you not feel it?' 'Shh! Not strange, but true! As though for the first time, I feel something of my own!' saying this, Samay drew closer to Tulsi.

Her breath began to tremble slightly; the air grew warm. Tulsi's fingers turned cold; a bead of warm sweat slowly descended behind her ear, sending a peculiar shiver through her entire body. They had come so close that their racing heartbeats could be heard clearly. Their faltering breaths touched their skin. In that very room, a small yellow bulb added to the warmth of the scene. Its amber glow illuminated Tulsi's cheeks, as though a portrait had come to life. The body felt cold within, while sweat broke out side. Samay traced his finger from the parting of Tulsi's hair down to her ear. 'Had I be known to write a poem, I would have ink the tapestry of my entire life within the depths of your eyes.'

'That, too, was a poem,' Tulsi says, her cheeks turning a deeper crimson with blush.

The distance between them was now but a thin layer of air, which, becoming heated, incited them more. Tulsi's lashes drooped in acceptance; her face bore no fear, but the hue of an innocent consent. A color that could stretch any moment into eternity.

Samay gently placed his hand between her cheek and neck; the touch was so light it seemed not as though he touched her, but as though he touched a feeling. Tulsi drew a soft breath, slow and long, as if gathering courage within. The warmth of one began to graze the other, a shared fever rising between them, and their reflections appeared before them in their closed eyes. A soft smile graced Tulsi's lips. One lip was but a breath's distance from the other; their souls were on the verge of union!

Knock!! knock!! knock!! knock!!!
(It seemed as though a thundering herd of a hundred elephants had begun to storm the door.)

***

15. The Ransom for your Grace!

That afternoon, Samay's room was no less than a secret heaven. Every stir of the outer world, every stray sound, was muffled behind the door, and within lingered only the music of two heartbeats, lost in one another.

Tulsi... her smile possessed that celestial innocence for which Samay would have challenged the entire world. He recalled the moment his finger traced the curves of her face, looking into those eyes of infinite depth which rendered every earthly fear pale and petty. They had crossed far beyond the fragile bridge of words. Each breath in their love held a dangerous delight, the kind that makes every passing second precious.

Then, there came the moment that struck that paradise like a thunderbolt. "What wretch dares thrust his meddling limb through the door of so wondrous a romance?"

It was not merely a voice outside. It was doom knocking. The blood in Samay's heart froze in a single instant. It felt as though his youth had been pierced like a mosquito net riddled with holes. A hundred questions burst inside his mind like a boiling tide, and the heat of that panic trickled out as sweat. But alongside Samay, who was more afraid then him, Tulsi clung to him, trembling, as a leaf clings to its branch in a storm. Her breath caught in her chest. Her fair, romantic face drained of color. The once calm air of the room turned venomous.

"Who could it be, Samay?" Tulsi's faltering voice carried a broken prayer. Let it be no one. Samay gathered his resolve. He knew that cowardice now would be an insult to the love itself.

"It must be Pawan. Why do you fear? Do not be afraid. I shall see."

Words floated on his lips while his palms were soaked. He drew in a breath, as though it were his last, enchanted the holy-name of Ram within, he flung open the door.

In the very next instant, it felt as if the gates of hell had swung wide open.

The entire neighborhood stood before him. There was less anger in their eyes and more hunger for spice and spectacle. Before him loomed a vast, cunning, merciless face called Society. At the center stood that Moustached Man, whose bulging eyes glowed like burning embers, Behind him clustered the idle faces of the alley, men who must have sown wild oats in their youth, yet now wore the soiled cloak of honor with theatrical pride.

"Come out. Quickly. And where is that girl?" the Moustached man barked, his voice cracking like a whip.

Tulsi stepped like a condemned prisoner. Her gaze remained pinned to the dust beneath her feet.
"Who is this girl? And what were you doing inside?" Moustache man demanded, his eyes wide. His voice was a foul decoction of lust masked as purity.

Samay cleared his throat, yet the chords of his voice vibrated with a visible tremor: "It is nothing! She... she is my sister!"

"A Sister?" he mocked. "Let me ask your family which brother meets his sister behind closed doors." His moustache was longer than his honor. "I am a master of mathematics. I know the calculations of loafers like you. Do not try to fool me"

Before he could finish polishing his own virtues, another smoky voice growled from the crowd, "Speak the truth. Who is she? What was she doing in your room? Lie once more and we will grind your nose into the dust. Now Speak!"

Samay, balanced on that delicate bridge between boyhood and manhood, trembling within. But love lent him strength for a fleeting second. A storm rose in his eyes. He glanced at Tulsi. That girl, his life. Let me, burn to ashes, but not a scratch upon her. He gathered the blood in his heart and spoke with a quiet pride: "I shall tell all! But first, let her depart!"

Suddenly, perhaps moved by a flicker, a faint spark of sympathy. "Let the girl go!" someone murmured. And strangely, they all agreed.

Such are the laws of society. A woman is granted a chance to flee, to save, to prove her virtue. A man, however, is born to be a sieve for stones. In older days, even greater mischief then this would be excused as boyish folly. God knows the wind of change have why only changed this rule. These days, the moment society ensnares a pair of doves, it seeks only to cage them in the iron bonds of wedlock.

That was the moment. Tulsi understood. A breach had torn through the fragile boat of her youth. If society's fingers reached her home, it would mean instant marriage. Not to Samay, but to another. Her only treasure in life was this love. If she were not to belong to Samay's courtyard, but be wed elsewhere, it would stain her very existence forever.

Drinking the bitter draught of her own tears, Tulsi let go of Samay's hand. loosening the knot of her own courage, she mounted her bicycle and fled. Her departure was her last silent declaration of love. In such tales, the girl often escapes. The boy is ground to powder. Samay watched. Not even her shadow remained, and a deep, unsettling peace settled upon his face.

His duty was done. He understood her compulsion; but now, the stage has to be shared by him, alone.

"Now speak!" the moustached man demanded eagerly. Was itching with a restless curiosity.

Samay squared his chest, standing not as a sacrificial goat before the altar of the world, but as a lover. He turned his trembling voice into a firm crag of stone and said with grace: "I hold her in my heart! And she holds me in hers! We met as we always do... to share our words and thoughts as we, were Talking.!"

"Only talking?" Suspicion dripped from the question. The man himself entered the room, pawing at the very walls in search of, perhaps hoping to uncover some scandalous spice. He found nothing but the cold embrace of emptiness.

Then came the shrill voice of a one eyed woman whose owl like gaze had been fixed upon the scene from the beginning. "Why ask him? Does a thief confess his theft? Call his family. Now we'll utter the next word to only them and let them be answerable."

As her buffering faded, a whisper rippled through the crowd:
"Look! He arrives!"
And so entered Dayal Babu. Dayal, a man of dark, handsome features and unwed state, whose shimmering eyes were now bowed in shame. He too bore the countenance of a criminal. "Come, brother! See what wondrous flowers your sibling has grown!"

Dayal came near Samay. His voice carried disappointment tangled with affection. "Is this your preparation for the tenth? Can you not keep your youth in your pocket? What shall I answer them now?"

The moustached man fanned the flames again: "Why are you treating him with such a tenderness? He is no babe at the breast! He is another lame. Someone, fetch his father; the matter shall be settled with him now!"

Voices rose. A middle aged man chewing tobacco joined in. "What to expect from the victim and his family. Let us march straight to the girl's house. Such low conduct must be made an example. What message will it be sent among the boys?" background artist howls: "Yes, Yes, Let us March."

Amid this raging tempest, Samay's father, Deendayal Babu, arrived in a frantic state: "Do not commit such ruin, Lala," he pleaded. "Think of my honor. Will you not let me live in society? Do you wish to see my dead face?" His voice was the hollow plea of an aged father's helplessness.

The moustached man hardened his tone: "It is not I who say this, Kaka! People say it. I am but their tongue! Today your son has done this. If this will not be stopped, others will stray for sure. Therefore it is must to be done and for so we have decided. Your son shall marry that girl. Thus the stain upon society shall be cleansed!"

Deendayal Babu folded his hands in submission. His head bowed so low it seemed it might never rise again: "Do not do this, Lala! I shall not be able to show my face in this world! Have mercy upon a poor man! Will you strip me of my very skin?"

When Deendayal's despair was at its zenith, a righteous man among them, Basuki Da, finally broke his silence. He was the most tranquil, the most sagacious soul of the slum.

"You go too far, Lala," he said coolly. "The boy has said they were only talking. Why are you making it a mountain out of a mustard seed?

Why are you smearing soot upon a decent family? A boy and girl speaking is not that too a capital crime. Brothers, we too should spit out our anger. The boy knows his folly, and Deendayal Babu feels the weight of this misfortune. Let society learn a better lesson by not turning error into spectacle."

For a moment, a profound silence reigned. Basuki Da's words bore the cooling balm of humanity. Deendayal Babu seized the chance. "Yes! Yes, Basuki Da. Let the boy complete his tenth first. I will send him away on the very next train. You will never see such a sight again."

And as the flames of society cooled by humanism, the crowd dispersed with bored indifference. Because of that sage soul Basuki Da. Deendayal Babu had his nose in his hand. Samay looked at his father. He knew the price had been paid. The heaven within that room had burned to ash. His future now lay upon the uncertain tracks of a distant train. Yet in his eyes there was a curious gleam. Not of defeat, but of that 'simple talking' for which he had endured an entire neighborhood and preserved the honor of his love. His gaze rose once more toward the room, where Tulsi's fragrance still lingered in the air, and the old melodies began to echo in the background...

jab pyaar kiya to darna kya...
jab pyaar kiya to darna kya?
pyaar kiya koi choree nhi kee...
han! pyaar kiya koi choree nhi kee!
pal-pal aahen bharna kya...
jab pyaar kiya too...

(Slowly, with the fading rhythm, the curtain falls.)

***

16. I shall find thee, O my Bumblebee!

A poetic tale!

Within breaths deep as the swaying sea, along the paths where the wild waves flee. Upon the dewy instruments of the morn, mid cool climes and winds newly born. Within the confines of homeless wall, two caterpillars dwell in silent thrall. They drift through rivers of petaled grace, where fragrance blooms in a flowered embrace. Amidst the mountains and the silver curse, in the melody of a thousand verse.

A hum resounds through the ears of mad, for Love is a syrup that makes a soul glad. Dissolving into the evening air, Within the veil of the body's snare, a rhythmic clinking in every grain, seen in the stars and the soft refrain. She is as fickle as a summer cloud, a quagmire of youth where the proud are bowed. Pure as water, yet a difficult frame, a web of illusion, a seductive game. Her veil is a shadow that pricks the sight, her words are a sting in the dead of night. My fear is a candle that weeps in the gloom, a fading dawn in a closing room.

Darkness stands tall as the sun turns black, while the moon brings the silver radiance always back. The platter of night is a mystic song, where the budding blossoms might belong. In this frolicking garden of emerald hue, a dark wanderer pines for a beauty anew. He lingers all day, a captive of grace, where the saffron scent leaves a lingering trace. The chime of her anklets, a rhythmic beat, yet their meeting is bitter, a whip's cruel heat. He is a solitary soul, simple and true, while she is a lark, a tempest that grew. A dainty parcel of peril and art, Love is her moonbeam, the point of her heart. Yet hatred is timeless, a shadow that stays, the Bumblebee's bondage in a golden haze.

The Bumblebee is but a child in his ways, green in his wit and lost in the maze. The Butterfly is wise, seasoned and cold, her manner romantic, her spirit too bold. With a body of grace and a piercing stare, her youth is a weapon, a silken snare. Her form is restless, her glance a shifting tide, and for her, a thousand suitors have sighed. This Bumblebee is but one in the throng, a tale of love that is ancient and long. For her, it is merely a stroll through the glade, sipping the nectar that the heavens have made; she tastes every bloom, she meets every swain, while he seeks a loyalty she views with disdain.

Each evening she blossoms, a fresh, new delight, yet chooses to linger alone in the night. Where the Butterfly's heart is a tattered silk, the Bumblebee is pure as the morning milk. Yet, vexed by her whims and her wandering eye, he sulks in the shadows, a silent goodbye. Then she woos him back with a tear and a plea, until the morning sets the wanderer free. A new dawn breaks, a new tale is spun, and the Butterfly flies toward the rising sun.

One morn, the Bumblebee woke with a start, a cold premonition clutched at his heart. The Butterfly vanished without a word, the promises of night now faint and unheard. He had yearned to soar by her side today, to join their souls in a lover's play. He searched through the groves till he found her at last, but his heart was shattered, his sky overcast. He saw her entwined with a stranger's grace, and his dreams were erased in that hallowed pace. His eyes refused what the truth had revealed; the mask had fallen, the secret unsealed.

Whose Butterfly was she? To whom did she cling? Whose garden was this? What song did she sing? Suddenly, the farce of love was laid bare, and his laughter turned to a hollow prayer. The golden pollen felt like ash on his tongue; every flower was dust to which he had clung. He followed her shadow, a ghost in the light, dying a thousand deaths in his flight.

The sun that had dawned in the morning sky, now burned on his brow as the hours slipped by. Still, he trailed her through the fading day, until the evening turned the world to grey.

The dusk has settled, the night is nigh, two lonely creatures beneath the sky. The shadows deepened, the hour of breaking drew near, as the chains of illusion grew heavy with fear. The bond began to tighten and gall, for words no longer answered the call. The thirst of their meetings had turned to a drought, and the flame of the spirit was flickering out. No passion remained in the Butterfly's breast, no joy in the kiss, no peace in the rest. He fled in the dark of the moonless night, to a place where no one could witness his flight.

He perched on the thorns, far from the bloom, for the scent of the rose was the scent of the tomb. There was no magic in the fragrance he knew; no sandalwood, no saffron, no honeyed dew. Only the blackened memories remained, like dried-up springs by the sorrow stained. His tears fell like pearls, heavy and slow, for the scales of love were weighted with woe. The Butterfly cared not for his bitter defeat; no worry touched her, no shadow of grief, for she was a nomad, her loyalty brief. Aye, he was a captive of the bond they had sworn, yet she was a wild thing, of conscience shorn. Thus, he drifted into the watery deep, with the darkness of ages his only to keep.

Time marched onward, day after day, and no magic lamp did light up their way. No genie appeared to mend what was torn, for the heart is a plaything, of vanity born. It is a bed of pleasure, a childish spat, a mountain of longing where the soul falls flat. They call this 'Youth', where the lust is entwined, and the eyes of the spirit are rendered blind. Yet, not every love is a hollow facade, not every passion is a masquerade. There are stories where love is not merely for show, where the roots of the spirit are allowed to grow.

But there are also those where the union is flawed, where the longing is missing, and the heart is a fraud. A killer resides in the depths of the pair, a ghost of a bond that was never quite there.

Ofttimes, that killer is the Butterfly's soul, dancing from blossom to blossom's control. One flower can never suffice for her thirst, she wanders the night, by her restlessness cursed. She is a parcel of fraud, a doll made of stone, a trader of feelings who dwells all alone. A vessel of poison, a phantom of greed, she is the demon that makes the heart bleed. No fox, no thief, but a spirit of blight, donning a soft form to steal lime light.

Well, every dog has his day in the sun, even the lion finds his race is run. The clouds may falter and the skies may sway, but the Bumblebee no longer wanders astray. He is simple now, and perhaps a bit wise, with the veil of the world stripped away from his eyes. He dwells in his bliss, a madman of joy, no longer a victim, no longer a toy.

One day, as he wandered with friends by his side, a rustle behind him made the air collide. A tremor of nerves, a shadow so vast, a ghost of the memories he'd buried at last. He felt a faint glimmer, a hint of her grace, as the thought of the Butterfly haunted the space. His world was shaken, the heavens flashed bright, as he soared through the brush in a frantic flight.

Suddenly, his eyes met the foe of his past; the Butterfly stood there, her moment her last. For there loomed a serpent, a titan of gloom, a barbaric beast in the garden of doom. With a body of ebony, savage and grim, it lunged for her life, for every frail limb. The black hiss erupted, a terrifying sound, as the flames of the nightmare rose from the ground. The Bumblebee rose, a streak through the air, diving straight for the fangs in a final despair.

The attack was a whirlwind, a strike in the dark; the serpent's eye shattered, losing its spark. Born into blindness by the sting of the bee, the serpent recoiled, yet would not let be. Its strike missed its mark, its meal was denied, yet the force of the blow cast, the beauty aside.

The Butterfly fell, pathetic wings torn away, she forgot how to fly on that terrible day. A web had been woven mid the flowers' soft bed, where the shadow of cobras lay waiting and spread. Was it the magic of scent that had led her astray, or a trick of the light in the heat of the fray?

She lay on the earth, a corpse that still breathed, while the Bumblebee watched, his heart deeply grieved. She knew in that moment the price she had paid; this was the debt for the life she betrayed. Her soul met with Death in a cold, dark embrace, as the time for her journey arrived in that place. With her final breath, she whispered her plea:

"I shall find thee; O, my Bumblebee, in the life yet to be. For in this wretched world, I lived not for thee. Though my spirit departs on the wings of the wind, In the next life, let our destinies be intertwined."

The chime of the anklet is now but a shriek, the scent of the fields is heavy and weak. Each breath of the Bumblebee is stolen away, as the darkness of Time turns the gold into grey. In the frolicking garden, Death holds the rein, and the syrup of love has returned to pain. The ocean of breath now vomits its fire, and the night is a ruin, a funeral pyre. This is the end of the mystic refrain, the final note of love got disdain.

But the death that I suffer is living even now, and the moon's silver point is a wound on the brow. It is a long game that shall never quite end, for the syrup of love shall forever descend. One bud will blossom, another shall fall; one Butterfly dies, while the next hears the call.

The dousing of one lamp is the start of a flame, and fear is for those who play Love's game. This is the bond that no power can sever; the dance of the two shall continue forever. There is no shore, and there is no home; through the darkness and dawn, Love shall ever roam.

***

17. The Sightless Man's Solo Wish!

The sun descended into the western horizon, bleeding a weary crimson, much like the bloodshot eyes of a peasant who had spent his day breaking his back in the field. A cloud of dust rose toward the sky. To the village people, this is *Godhuli,* which lifts up in the air from the hooves of the cows at every eve. A moment of pure beauty. Whereas, in a crowded place called, city. They name this same dust as pollution. Yet here at village sites, it is being seen as a symbol of 'back to home', as long as your lungs are strong enough to breathe the very soil you walk on.

Scene I.

Bhikhari stood upon the narrow path, leaning on his staff. No yoke rested on his shoulders, yet the burden of responsibilities had bent his neck of its own accord. His gaze lingered on the swaying crops ahead. The harvest was lush, yet he knew well that all this greenness would ultimately breathe its last, inside the moneylender's granary.

"Make haste, Karu! Will you spend the whole night here? You cannot even tie one bundle properly. How will you manage my latrine and needs in old age?"

"Hay Ram! Is this all that remains for me now? My whole youth that ill-fated Lajo devoured, and my old age will gasp in your loincloth's shadow. The entire lineage is stripped of shame, O Lord!"

"What bone now stuck in your throat , you serpent?"

"Don't you know, Rama is building a mansion, And I even heard he will

get a boring well dug too. My heart writhes like a cut worm. I, an old woman, will still draw water from the well, while she who was born after me will flick a switch and watch the water dance! My veil is already started drowning in shame. But why it will bother you? "

Bhikhari sighed and replied, "A poor man's fortune is like a torn pocket, Kari. Put a coin in, it falls out. Put a hand in, it comes out empty. All this greenery will go to the moneylender. Even if I gather every last penny, every copper and cent of my life, it will not suffice to dig a boring for you. At best, a hand pump I can manage for you!"

"Hmph! Hold your tongue and walk, or I shall smash this bundle on your face. Always spilling grand wisdom and then weeping over helplessness!"

Bhikhari's nostrils drooped, his lip hanging heavy with unspoken defeat. Yet, his mind was a whirlpool of schemes. What could he do so his wife might live with youthful ease? So she need not draw water from the well, nor strain her breath at the hand pump. Lost in thought, he walked ten steps ahead of Kari, as men have walked ahead of women since the dawn of time.

Scene II.

Leaving the bare threshing ground open behind, the couple entered the village. Smoke rose from the huts. Not smoke, but the sacrifice of housewives' desires, burning slowly with damp firewood. Every Hori's Dhaniya in the village was blowing their very heart. The fire filled her eyes with tears which the world mistook for maternal devotion. In truth, they were the sting of poverty and penury.

From afar, a conch echoed in the temple. Its voice was so thunderous that it drowned the gossip of the women clustering at the well.

Under the ancient gnarled banyan tree sat a raised platform. Upon which sat Master Ji, spectacled, retired, and self-declared seer of all three times. His sole duty now was to devour the newspapers and view the world through a lens of sharp, slanted irony.

Bhikhu was passing by the courtyard, calling out, "Ram Ram, Master Ji!"

The newspaper lowered. His nose wore the spectacles more than his eyes did. "O, Bhikhu Da! Do not merely offer greetings from a distance. Grant us the favor of your company some day, *Maharaj!*"
Bhikhu's tongue, as always, wished to refuse, yet a thought flickered. A learned soul might suggest a remedy for Kari's affliction. Bhikhu leaped:
"There is nothing for such talk, Dada! I am but your servant. It is your greatness," Bhikhu said, settling upon the cot before the platform. Kari, with the bundle still on her head, vanished into her hut.

Bhikhu inhaled deeply, laying the foundation of his intent:
"Master Ji! this setting sun gives such consolation, does it not? As if it carries away the sins and fatigue of the day, only to rise again with fresh hope."

Master Ji removed his gaze from the paper.
"Bhikhu Bhaiya! that is not hope, that is compulsion. The sun does not rise to gift you hope. It rises so the bank officials may shorten the distance to your door. And that redness of the setting sun you admire, it is no beauty. But the sky's very blood pressure which is rising after witnessing the scams on this planet."

Bhikhu forced a smile. "You lace every word with poison Master Ji. Look now, my cow is about to calve. Lakshmi will enter the house. I am thinking of this time that, I shell sell the milk and install a hand pump in my courtyard."

Master Ji chuckled softly.
"Lakshmi? My friend, Lakshmi no longer rides on owl. She now sits upon government files. And the milk your cow will give, do not call it milk. It will be merely a white liquid that the dairy inspector will taste only to declare, 'It lacks the flavor of honesty. Add a little bribe, then it shall pass.'"

Bhikhu's face dimmed. "But the land is mine. I shall grow gold from the soil and set the pump from that!" said sadly.

"Indeed the land is yours." Master Ji replied, "yet the first right on its crop belongs to the insect called 'the system'. You will grow gold, and they will purchase it at the price of dust. In *Premchand's* era there was only the moneylender. Today's moneylender is digital. He takes your thumbprint and before you even realize, your soul is downloaded."

Bhikhu murmured, "Then life itself feels futile." He had come seeking a solution, but was more burdened now, than when he had arrived.

Master Ji smirked.
You must remain alive, for if you deceased, how will they keep you as a mere digit below the poverty line? If you are gone, in whose name will they draft their grand schemes? Mark the irony: Mukhiya Ji must build his Mansion, and for that your hut must fall so the housing budget may be passed. How could you dream to die, you are sustaining the system."

He snatched the moment. "Speaking of mansions, Rama is building his house. I hear he will dig a boring well. Kari is gnawing at my heart. I know not what to do."

"Did you not say you were installing a hand-pump?"

"I am... but Kari dislikes even the hand pump. She still draws from the well; and though the pump is easier, she cannot bear that Lajo should flick a switch while she herself must strain her lungs at the iron handle."

"A tale of every household, Bhaiya! Truly, a universal curse! Why don't you speak to Rama? He is your devotee. Anyways."

"Nothing new. The thought crossed my mind too! But has a problem, is that: What if his wife, Lajo, forbids it?"

"Then propose a pact of halves! If he will not slide a pipe your way for free, tell him: 'Take half the cost from me and let us share the motor's heart.' He cannot refuse. After all, the weight of his expense must surely be parching his own throat too."

Bhikhu began to ponder. Yes! this could work. Rama would hardly deny. Even if he did, the money meant for the pump could complete a boring. Kari would be happy, and his pocket relieved too.
"Yes… I see wisdom in this. This can work. I shall speak to Rama."

Evening had faded. Moonlight was climbing the sky. The temple bell rang.
"Come," said Bhikhu, "let us attend the Aarti. The mind may find some peace."

Master Ji smiled thinly.
"Certainly go. Even God must be troubled seeing Humans building temples but forgetting to file a tender for humanity. Seek love for your family in the flame of Aarti. While then, I shall search in this newspaper where had the post-mortem of justice today."

Scene III.

The village evening bathed in full moonlight, yet this moonlight did not illuminate, It merely filled the potholes of life with softer darkness, into which common lives fell daily. This midnight silence testified that across cities, towns, and villages, only two kinds of people remained awake, among which: one whose debt had grown, and another whose greed.

The second kind, Bhikhari Rai, had sent a summons to the first kind, Ramprasad. The message was carried by Aghori Rai, Bhikhari's elder son, priest by sentiment, delinquent by nature. Married, his wife's name, Phuleshri Devi; father of a daughter named Bauni, the short-statured. For now, people called her Bauni with affection. what the future holds, might this very name would be her identity, as it happens in villages ofttimes.

Lajo could never understand what manner of man she has. Despite repeated misconduct toward his wife, Rama always sidelined his meal midway and run barefoot at a mere summons from that beggar Sudama-like Bhikhari. Even today, he had left half his plate of rice and rushed. Yet Lajo's tears had grown wise; they no longer fell for such trifles. This was not something as the first summons. When kari's mansion rose, he was called. When Aghori's marriage came, he was called. When Bauni was born, he was called. When the two-wheeler entered the house, he was called.

Every ransom of small and big needs was fulfilled by Rama, a bank that allowed unlimited withdrawals, without interest, without tenure. How could one turn such a treasurer into an enemy with envy? For Rama, these summons were only that last knot in the thread that still tied both families together. Even on the scale of loss, Bhikhu at least called his brother. At least he acknowledge that Rama exist. For Bhikhu it was all a must for Rama to be held, since Bhikhu is the Eldest brother of them. Unknown of that what if one day, When Rama will say, NO.

Brotherhood's fever often rises when the pocket is empty and sleeps away swallowing paracetamol once money is received. The full moon of *Purnamasi*. Descended upon the field ridge like a long-lost guest visiting a poor man's mansion after months. Milky white light gifted even the torn huts a fleeting silver glow. Yet what were the use this moonlight? The full moon does not fill an empty stomach. Infact it helps one to see their wounds more clearly even at midnight. In our land, even the moon has classifications: the fourth-day moon is 'Pious', and the full moon is a 'Pilgrim'.

Furtherer, It seems as if tonight, the moonlight was angry. Even after being full, it hid its head in clouds, unwilling to let its light assist deceit. Bhikhu rubbed his last pinch of tobacco. Kari arranged bedding on the broken cot. Aghori ignored Phuleshri's signals, for he had more zeal for house politics than for marital wrestling. And there come Rama, fluttering like a pigeon with clipped wings, sobbing faintly, having swallowed too many spices of anxiety. He knew well: when work arises, Bhikhari turns sweeter than honey.

Rama, through his sniffles, said "Ram Ram, Bhaiya! How come you remembered me?"

Bhikhari, lifting his vest over his belly, replied smoothly,
"Does one need a reason to remember his brother? I was merely sitting, beholding this shimmering moon and her beauty, thought to call you! See this glittering full moon, how charming she is, isn't she?"

"Ah! True indeed!" Rama sighed. "In this endless running of days, we forget that small joys too feel like heaven. We rarely find time to sit and watch such moonlight in peace, Bhaiya.!"

Bhikhu observed keenly.
"I see how you rush to office early morning, Rama; Return hungry and thirsty, and before sniffing any snacks you then inspect house work and expenses. It would be too fatigue for you, isn't it! Tell me Promotion placed or paused? Heard that you were about to be come, 'Bada Babu!?'" (a Senior Clerk)

Rama laughed bitterly.
"Words on only paper, Bhaiya! The ground reality is that a man of higher caste was seated in the chair I sought. I thought that after seventy-five years of freedom, the walls of caste would have crumbled, but alas! In the name of democracy, we have only the hypocrisy; the people still sleep on the same mats of humiliation. I am where I always was. It is but destiny."

Bhikhu nodded gravely.
"When the shawl slips, what can anyone do? Even the Creator cannot rewrite anyone's destiny."

Aghori, yawning nearby, losing patience. Being rudely straight forward. He cared not for these circular chatter. His tongue finally broke free. "Why are you circling around like crows at dawn? Say it straight! Since so long you ramble nonsense as if morning is arriving. Kaka, Babuji wants to talk about the boring. It is but a matter of sliding one pipe toward our door. That is all it."

Bhikhu looked abashed. "O, this Aghori! He speaks such follies! Ha-ha! The boy is jesting, Rama! Ha-ha!" Bhikhu forced a laugh that sounded like a sob. There is a peculiar shame in begging from those you wish to be at your nose.

Rama pondered: This is the moment! If one pipe can bridge the chasm between our houses, what more could I desire?

"Why call it a jest? It would bring me joy if the water woes of the whole family were ended. How long can you sustain life with that stagnant water of that well? Well done, Aghori, for speaking up. Otherwise, your father is such a bashful soul, a regular *Sharmila Tagore!"*

humph! The business was done. The air that had been caught in Bhikhari and family's throats began to flow again. After some idle talk, Rama departed for his unfinished house. Suddenly, a shadow hidden behind a pillar stirred.

"Lajo! Is that you?"
At the sound, the shadow dissolved into the night's scream, subtly.

***

18. Feast. Folly. Fate.

Scene I.

This morning, Kashi bolted for school in a frantic flair. Heaven knows what the hurry was, but he ignored Lajo's desperate calls and skipped his meal entirely. He pounded the pedals of his cycle with a rhythmic rage, as if he was riding the very nape of time. Why was this sudden haste and for what? On the way, he merged his paths with Anubhav. Both halted at the Stall of "Chatur Chaiwala." where they devoured two samosas each. Money, however, was a ghost they didn't possess; they had long since cultivated the habit of eating on credit.

Working at Chatur Kaka's shop was a wild, carefree lad about Kashi's age. He had a peculiar verbal tic, addressing everyone as his "Son!" His name was Kashi Kumar, a mirror image that reflected the exact opposite of our Kashinath. While Kashinath was a portrait of patience, plumpness, and quiet content, Kashi Kumar was fierce, fretful, and as volatile as a boiled potato.

"Is this a daily charity feast? Just because Kaka stays silent, do you think your treasure chest of debt will keep expanding? Listen well, Son: debt is a luscious poison. It tastes like a honey-dripping jalebi while you eat it, but it turns into bitter gourd when the bill comes due. If you think you'll just feast and flee from school after tenth, think again! I know well your nonsense. My name is Kashi, I serve samosas that are trashy! I'll make you vomit right here and reclaim every penny."

Kashi and Anubhav shared a knowing smirk. They hadn't arrived in a hurry for the food; they had come specifically to meet Kashi Kumar. They wanted to recruit him into their circle. And Why So?

Actually, In their tripod, they had a listener and a speaker, but they lacked a "Bullshitter." Kumar was a grandmaster of gab, a man addicted to the constant clatter of meaningless chatter. Customers visited the shop just to hear his unique brand of village politics. Today, Kashi and Anubhav were not going to school. They had decided to bunk with Kumar, to see where the iron rails of the train would take them. Wherever the engine breathed its last, that's where they would settle down.

Anubhav declared, "I shall settle every debt, but on one condition?"
"Keep your conditions to yourself and hand over my cash!"
Kumar had no appetite for terms.
"What kind of man are you? Don't you ever wish to see the world?" Anubhav fired an arrow of raw emotion.
"I've seen the whole world while setting up carts on the street! I don't need to wander for a new world. Right now, you two need your school more than a trip. Move along, Sons." A stiff hair of pride stood tall on Kumar's experienced chest.

"Forget the school, Kumar. Tell us your story. How did you get trapped in this cage of tea and kettles?" Anubhav sensed that Kumar was slowly being lured into the net.
"What can I say, Bhai? It's a tale of such profound sorrow that you'd fall asleep midway. Noways. I won't tell you." while Kumar feigned disinterest, sitting down with a graceful intrest.

"We won't sleep, bhai! Today it all belongs to you. Let's wander somewhere, and the stories will flow. This daily school feels like a slaughterhouse anyway, where we go only to be sliced and diced." Anubhav's own academic experience was clearly a scarred one.

"Do you want something from me? You're melting like warm syrup. Let me warn you, I will take my debt at any cost! If there's anything else,

speak up." Kumar was no fool.
"We'll pay, we'll pay! Don't fret. Just tell us, will you come?" Anubhav pushed for a final answer.

"And if I don't.. then? And besides, is your friend here a Wallflower?" Kumar tilted his neck and prepared to leave.

"There is a world that exists beyond dirty dishes and evening cigarettes, a world we both want to see with you. Will you come, Kumar?" Kashi's silence finally shattered. And Kumar was instantly dissolved in the warmth of his words, losing his wits as he sat closer to him.
"What is your name, Sir?" Kumar felt a strange, magnetic pull, as if he had known him in another life.

"Kashi! My name is Kashinath."

As he spoke, Kashi smiled. Hearing the name, the other Kashi smiled too. Seeing both Kashi in bloom, Anubhav joined the symphony of grins. Everyone began to laugh. Ha-ha! There wasn't much to laugh about, really. It just felt as though these three, without holding their hands, could no longer pull the bullock-cart of life alone.

"Wait! Let me speak to Kaka. Until then, park your cycles behind the Bael tree... in the cattle shed." Kumar took the soiled dishes to Chatur Kaka.

Kaka was not like those typical shopkeepers who wouldn't let an old worker touch the cash box. He had a special affection for Kumar, partly because Kumar brought in new customers, and partly because he had no children of his own. Permission was granted easily, for Kumar rarely asked for leave. Kaka didn't just let him go; he pressed some cash into his palm. Kumar touched his feet before leaving, and Chatur Kaka patted his back in blessing.

"Let's go, comrades! Where to go? Oh, wait a second! What's your name, lad?" Kumar asked with the speed of a turtle while riding the horse of his curiosity.

"The kick of *Samay* - The Time, and the word of *Anubhav* - The Experience are both fatal. My name is Anubhav." He didn't just introduce himself; he sounded like he was doing a favor.

"Oh, is that so, Son! I'll deal with you properly later. Come on, Kashinath Baba, do you plan to attain *nirvana* right here?"

Scene II.

Kumar joined the trio like a hem meets a veil. They all headed toward the 'Sooty Carriage Rest Stop,' which is to say, the railway station. They had no tickets to worry about and no schedule to follow. Heaven knows which train these three poor pupil of life boarded. "This Kumar will get us killed one day." Anubhav's intuition whispered. "Why does Kashi want to befriend this vagabond?" He harbored a suspicion that this friendship might prove too costly, meanwhile Kashi listening to Kumar's ramblings with profound peace.

Kumar began, "I have four brothers. My parents are alive; I am no orphan. My father simply threw me out of his home!" There was no regret in his voice, only a sturdy, sculptural confidence that if he were still with his family, he would have been a man today.
"But why were you exiled, Kumar? You seem so pure of heart. You couldn't have committed a crime, so why?" Kashi was burning with curiosity.

"It wasn't a crime, brother. I simply ran away with my Jhiliya!" A sparkle of love danced in his eyes.

"Jhiliya??" Kashi suspected he might be...
"I am a married man," Kumar hesitated.
"Pffft!!" Anubhav burst into laughter. "Hey!" Kashi nudged him with his elbow.
"Laugh all you want, Laugh! You're not the first. Everyone laughs!" Kumar's heart sank slightly. He didn't quite liked Anubhav; both had started pulling each other's legs.

"No children, I hope?" Kashi asked with a bashful hesitation.
"I'm not that much of a lustful, brother! I live by starving myself; how would I feed a child?" Kumar showcased his tattered poverty by standing up and pulling out his empty pockets. Forgotten about the money Chatur Kaka had given him. A mini-Cherrapunji of coins rained down! Anubhav lunged for the coins, thinking of the party they would have, just as the train groaned to a halt. He leaped off the freight train. None of them knew where they were. The train hadn't stopped at some shimmering platform; it had halted in the middle of an open, wild field. Kumar and Kashi followed him down. Kumar grabbed Anubhav by the neck and snatched the money back.

"What kind of friend are you? Won't you even spend a bit?" Anubhav tried to play the card of camaraderie.
"I will! but not like this." Kumar jingled the coins against Kashi's wrist. "Here, neither mine nor yours!" The three of them wandered about like confused owls, with no clue of their location or how they would return. As they walked, they encountered a man who looked like a dark gorilla. Kashi asked him, "Kaka! Which village is this?"

The gorilla-man grumbled a single word: "Dattkichwa!"

Hearing this, a kiss of a smile touched their cheeks. The three of them looked at each other and bared their teeth in a grin.

"If the name of the village is so whimsical, imagine how playful the village itself must be." Kumar felt a sudden itch to explore the heart of the settlement. Fighting and bickering, Kumar and Anubhav while Kashi counted the coins. They reached the edge of the village "Seventy rupees!" Kashi announced the limits of their budget.

Scene III.

Right at the entrance sat a small tea shack. Before the shop was even visible, a large wooden board appeared, with handwriting that looked like scrawling insects. It read: "Credit is a 'Magic Trick'. we'll give you, and you'll vanish!"

Kumar let out a thunderous laugh. "Look, you paupers! Beggars like you exist here too. What a brilliant way to insult people! I'll tell Kaka to hang the same board. Haha!"
"Oh, what do you know! The joy of eating on credit is far superior to paying in cash. Isn't that right, Kashi?"

"Hmm?" Kashi let out a sound from his throat. What did he know of the joys of what? He never paid even once; Anubhav was always the one who fed and watered his starve.

The shop was named "Ashleel Chaiwala!" Kumar ordered three teas. The shopkeeper, with tobacco tucked in his cheek, scanned their faces with sunken eyes and gave a slow nod. It was like a human verification process. If only someone had said "I am not a robot," the comedy would have been complete.

Regardless, they saw that under a banyan tree nearby, the politics of the village square were heating up. Seeing this, Kumar entered his

'Gab-Avatar.' The two of them sat down at the back unlike Kumar wiggling his hips to find a spot in front. On a nearby stone platform sat Mukhiya Ji, the village headman. His white tunic held as much brightness as the government funds he had swallowed whole.

Scene IV.

A villager remarked,
"Mukhiya Ji! Your 'Development' has come to the village like an electric pole. The pole stands tall, but the wires are missing."

Immediately, Kumar's restless tongue began to flutter. He jerked, "Mukhiya Ji, where is this 'Development'?" Mukhiya Ji placed a hand on his pocket, smiled, and said, "It's resting inside, don't wake it up! Today, I have come only to distribute this very development!"

The three of friends and all understood the game: it was election season. And as they say, fortune favors the fighter. Kumar's right palm began to itch. A sign of incoming of Goddess Laxmi. "Today, we shall feast like kings!" Kumar thought. He stepped up and began his performance, acting as Mukhiya Ji's greatest gully supporter.

Kumar strained the veins in his neck, addressing the blind assembly. "Bhaiyon! What do you know of the joys of development? So what if there are no wires? Isn't the pole made of real cement? Look at Mukhiya Ji's heart; he has tucked 'Development' safely in his pocket so it doesn't wither in the harsh sun!"

There was such a magic in Kumar's chatter that even the cement pole seemed to smile. He had realized that in this land, the winner is the one who can spin the grandest lie. though the wires of the Mukhiya Ji's development were missing, Kumar's words created such a short-circuit of logic that the people began to hallucinate light even in the darkness.

Mukhiya Ji patted Kumar's back the way a butcher strokes a goat. Kumar set his sharp throat to full volume and shrieked, "Wise-Men! Do not fret over wires. Mukhiya Ji himself is a 'Power House.' The day he presses the button in his pocket, not just your homes, but your very destinies will be illuminated!"

Hearing this, Mukhiya Ji was ecstatic! He reached into his velvet vest and pulled out a crisp thousand-rupee note, tossing it toward Kumar like flowers at a Self-Sacrificed soul. Kumar's itching right hand was finally stilled by the touch of 'Goddess Lakshmi. 'The limited service of seventy rupees had now transformed into an unlimited opportunity of a thousand. Kumar continued to weave poems in praise of a pole that even the street dogs no longer bothered to lift their leg against.

While Kashi and Anubhav scratched their heads in confusion, Kumar knew better. Dishonesty for a thousand was far superior to honesty for seventy. Honesty provides only bread and greens, while dishonesty opens the gates to 'Shahi Paneer.' As the message of wealth arrived, his soul took a dive like a hot samosa in a frying pan! But before the samosa, the tea arrived. They sipped their tea, tucked away from the crowd. The money was theirs; then why to continue the flattery? Kumar sneered, "Yuck! Terrible tea from terrible people! Can anyone ever match the tea-taste as like my shop? Hmph!"

Anubhav gasped, "Wah, bhai!! One should learn how to fleece money from you. What a performance! Incredible!"
Kumar popped his collar. "The name is Kashi and I always stay classy! you got that, Son."

Kumar went to the tea shop, paid the bill, and inquired about a nearby hotel. They dived deeper into the village. The hotel was closer than they expected. Like three famished wolves, they stormed inside.

Scene V.

The Hotel's name was "Pavitra Bhojnalaya." But the layers of soot and grease on the walls told a different story. The three gluttons lunged at a table so hard its legs wobbled. Kumar summoned the waiter as if he owned the entire district. More aura farming, He didn't even touch the menu. Instead:

"Hey, Chhotu! Listen. Bring us the wealthiest paneer in your cauldron."

"Shahi Paneer!" Chhotu whispered with low battery.

"Excellent! Bring it! Along with buttered naan, sweet-and-sour chutney, and yes... cut the onions so thick that the memory of Mukhiya Ji brings tears to our eyes!" The three friends gave a beat and brayed with laughter.

As soon as the boy placed the cauldron on the table, the earthy aroma of spices invaded their nostrils, fanning the flames of their hunger. That wasn't just paneer; it was a milky dream draped in a velvety shroud of saffron gravy. The naan arrived fresh from the scorching tandoor, its dark charred spots looking like craters on the moon. And the dollop of butter melting over it... oh! Their hearts melted too, their tongues yearning to wrap around the feast. When Kumar snapped the 'ear' of the naan, the crunch was like music to his ears. It was tough on the outside but silken within, as if someone had stuffed clouds inside the flour.

The gravy was a golden ocean of oil and spices, in which the cubes of paneer swam without a care. When a morsel was dipped into that nectar, it soaked up half the sea. The moment it entered the mouth, the paneer and naan dissolved like cotton candy. The sting of spices and the sweetness of butter embraced each other so passionately... Mmm! It felt like a sweet-and-spicy raga was being played upon the tongue.

The rings of raw onion on the side, sprinkled with black salt and lemon juice! When the teeth cracked the crisp onion, its sharp juice cut through

the richness of the grease. It was a balance of flavors that doubled the hunger with every bite. And whenever that balance wavered, a dip into the *chutney* restored the soul to its sensory palace.

Their hands were no longer hands; they were pincers of greed. Kumar licked the gravy from his fingertips as if all the wisdom of the world were hidden in that grease. A man's faith and honor might waver at certain points, but no one dares to stand defiant before a bowl of Shahi Paneer.

As the mountain of naan arrived before Anubhav, a predatory glint flashed in his eyes. He didn't even have the patience to wash his hands; his fingers dove straight into the boiling gravy. He wasn't breaking pieces; he was wrapping the entire naan into a paneer-roll, drowning it in the sauce like a thirsty man jumping into a well. When the massive morsel entered his mouth, his cheeks puffed out like a fluffy fellow. He chewed little and swallowed much, as if his throat housed a furnace rather than a digestive tract.

The soft-spoken Kashinath, a deep-diver of the soul, also joined this royal looting. His morality drowned in the gravy alongside his hunger. He was silent, struggling to keep pace as the others tore through naan after naan and he was entangled with the ear of a naan. They were all warriors of the belly, showing their strength in how much they could digest.

As the end of the feast neared, the plates had changed their faces. The mountains of naan were now mere memories. Fingers were stained, bellies were swollen like fried *bhaturas*, and the sensation of butter rose to their throats, making even thirst feel ashamed. When the onion plate lay barren and the butter bowl held only a ghostly white stain, Kumar leaned back in his chair. Letting out a thunderous belch..Burpppp!!.. he said:

"So, Anubhav, my Son! Are you living your high life or not?

You would have been chewing dry bread for seventy rupees, but look now... I've soaked your throat so well that even swear words would slip out smoothly with dignity!" Aaopp!!.. Another belch followed.

Anubhav finished his final bite and collapsed into his chair like a wounded wrestler. His stomach was challenging the very buttons of his shirt. He let out a long, sour burp, a noisy mix of chili and butter. Gasping, he said:
"Yes, brother... today... my heart is finally cold and content! I feel as if I've swallowed the entire village."

Kumar looked at him intently and muttered, "You've swallowed the village. Son, but mark my words...tomorrow morning, a Royal Purge will depart from this very village!"

Scene VI.

When one has stuffed Shahi Paneer up to the very brim of the throat, how can one even think of walking? It was already two o'clock. Fortunately, Anubhav and Kashi usually went to tuition straight from school, so they still had a two-hour lifeline. They moved toward the station. As they walked, a low, violin-like "pee... pee" sounded from behind back of Anubhav. He looked at them, rubbed his belly, and offered a wide, sheepish grin. Then, suddenly, a bass guitar began to rumble in his gut. The Shahi Paneer he had swallowed without chewing was now protesting for their freedom.

The situation turned precarious. He clutched his stomach with both hands, as if trying to physically halt a landslide. An internal emergency was declared. "I can't take it anymore, Kashi! What do I do? Where do I go?" He felt the gates of evacuation could burst at any moment.

If they broke here, the Shahi Paneer would cause a catastrophe in his trousers. Ignoring the search for a proper toilet, Anubhav began a frantic dance of distress.
Anubhav (groaning): "Hey Kumar! Where is *lota*? Where is the *lota*, man?"
Kumar (mocking): "There is no *lota* here... only a bottle I swiped from the hotel! Is there Mukhiya Ji's 'Development' loading??"
Anubhav (screaming): "Not loading, it's 'Unloading'! The volcano is about to erupt!"

He sprinted toward the bushes. Kashi snatched the bottle from Kumar, filled it at a nearby hand-pump, and tossed it behind the shrubs. They couldn't stop laughing, even as they feared for their friend's folly.

From behind the greenery came a long, painful, yet relieved sound: "Oooooohhh...!" It was the sound of internal pressure dissolving into the atmosphere. His 'classy aura' was now turning into 'Gassy flora' and vanishing like the farts of fauna.

As Anubhav emerged, wiping sweat from his brow, face pale and legs trembling, he took only two steps on the path before the cauldron in his gut began to boil again. He leaped back toward the bushes like a langur, as if he were chasing the last fried puri at a langar. Anubhav was no longer a human; he had become a shuttlecock, hit back and forth between his stomach and the field. Each time he returned, his face looked like stale-pale curry. He collapsed on the dirt path, gasping, "Water... water." The moment the water hit his throat, the trumpet of his belly sounded again. "Oh, man!..." he cried and ran once again.

Kumar said to Kashi, "Did he eat Shahi Paneer or a Metro Train? He just won't stop! His year-round luxury has become a two-minute misery!"
Kashi looked at Anubhav; his body now resembled a squeezed lemon. His legs shook, and all the butter had sweated out of him.

Kashi spoke seriously, "No digestive powder can even fix this now. This kabaddi in his stomach won't stop like this. We must take him to a doctor, or this boy will remain only as a 'Memory' (*Anubhav*)." Kumar found the address of a local health center from a nearby shack.

Walking with a jagged gait, the trio moved through the dusty paths. Anubhav had one hand on his belly and the other on Kumar's shoulder, looking like a wounded soldier returning from the front. His mouth only uttered "*Hi Daiyaa... Hi Daiyaa,*" sounding like a scratched tape on an old radio.

Scene VII.

In the main market (which was just a cluster of four shops), there was a store with a large green **'+'** sign. The board read:
'Gupt Medical Store and Primary Health Center.' Below it:
'Dr. Jholachhap - All services in a single syringe!'

All good. But the name "Gupt" (Secret) made them baffled. What's the secret? Why the secret? The place looked more like a grocery store than a clinic. It was a tiny ten-by-ten room where medicines and patients were adjusted on the same bench. On one side hung strips of colorful pills, on the other, packets of biscuits. Hunger and illness were cured under one roof. If neither both worked then just aside the clinic there was a small Hanuman Mandir. where prayer could also work. Where Inside the clinic sat the self-proclaimed doctor, his fingers flying across his phone's screen. Seeing Anubhav in his half-dead state, a glint appeared in his eyes. Since the butcher had found his goat.

Kumar sat Anubhav on the broken bench and said, "Doctor Saab! Look at him. A royal explosion has occurred in his gut. The whole system is shaken. Do something or he'll be straight right here!"

Dr. Jholachhap grabbed Anubhav's pulse as if checking the consistency of sugar syrup. Adjusting his glasses, he asked, "What animal did this glutton eat?"
"I ate Shahi Paneer. Will I be okay, Sir?" Anubhav's trousers were hanging loose along with his hope.

"Yes! Yes! You'll be fine. You just need one 'Royal Injection'!" The doctor teased.

The doctor pulled out a thick syringe. Seeing it, Anubhav's remaining life-force evaporated into gas from his backside. Kumar added to the fun, "Doctor Saab! Apply some butter to the needle. Our friend can't digest anything without butter!"

As the needle pierced him, "*Ooouii.. Maa...*" that escaped Anubhav's lips was the final funeral rite of his stomach's chaos.

Scene VIII.

The bitter gulps of medicine and the sting of that thick needle finally quelled the royal revolution within Anubhav. In place of the explosions, a graveyard silence now echoed with strange sounds. He rose from the bench like an ancient ruin trying to stand upright after repairs.

They set out again on the dusty trail. This much upheaval was quite an adventure for such "experienced" people. Anubhav was no longer walking like a 'primitive beast' but like a 'reformed saint.' Kashi and Kumar walked on either side of him, looking like two veteran thieves taking a novice home after a police treatment . Waiting for the train at the station, they looked like a politician's henchmen after losing an election. The train arrived; they were swept inside by the crowd without even trying. In the clatter of the tracks, Anubhav could hear the mending of his

own intestines. The train spat them out at their village platform at exactly four o'clock. They were back at the same doorstep where they had started, like the three needles of a clock.

It had been a new experience. New, because for the first time, they understood that the geography of the stomach is far more complex than the map of the world. Kumar's thousand-rupee note, Mukhiya Ji's sleeping Development, and Anubhav's journey to the bushes. All had combined to lay the foundation of a friendship thicker than the gravy of Shahi Paneer. The bond was sealed when they all shared each other's phone numbers.

Standing at the station entrance, Kashi reached into his pocket and found that seventy rupees. Those coins was still safe - like the last shred of honesty. He held it out to Kumar, who snatched it instantly.

Kumar smiled and asked, "So, my son, *Paneer*. What will you eat when you get home? Shahi Paneer?"

Anubhav adjusted his loose pants and cast a look of pure terror toward the distant bushes. without a word, he simply nodded and turned toward his house. His silence spoke volumes; if he even heard the word 'Paneer' from this day forth, his stomach would surely begin to rumble.

The three departed. Vanishing in different directions, carrying their bundles of identity and experience. In the dimming evening light, their shadows grew longer - the shadow of a talker, a glutton, and a contented soul.

***

19. Even a golden needle pricks!

It is the month of *Jeth*. Millions of sunrays slipped in from ventilator, like a government inspection officer barging into a house without notice. The morning air carried that scorched scent which only those can smell who do not had to go to offices. For Rama, however, it was just another day of working. Bells were ranging from houses to houses. Devotees drowned in devotion, perhaps to beg forgiveness for last night's sins and to secure divine permission for the next. Nearby, a stray cow stared at another's green trough the way an educated unemployed man eyes his friend's job, with quiet hunger and helpless envy.

Just last week, a new board had been planted at the village entrance. In bold letters it declared, "Clean India, Safe India." Irony laughed softly. Within a week, dust had coated the board so thick that the words looked ashamed of their own hollow glory, darkened as if embarrassed by their own lies. Safety too had aged like wrinkled skin of an old man, creased, cracked, and sagging. To expect safety for women now felt like waiting for crops on barren land. Leave women's safety aside, if it has not come till now, what miracle shall summon it later. Perhaps the campaigns should now rise for those mute animals upon whom we unleash our cruelty and, in doing so, lose the final proof of being human.

By the pond's edge, cranes sat in still meditation. At first glance, they seemed like great sages, yet in truth they resembled those self-proclaimed social workers who only wait for a small scheme to appear so that they can swallow it whole. The sun had begun to reveal its real temperament. The Sun God climbed the sky like an enforcement E.D. raid ascending upon an opposition leader's house.

At the well, women had formed a nest of gathering. The water level was crashing like stock market. The clatter of buckets was less, the whisper of gossip were more. This was the village's own social media, one even Mark Zuckerberg could never block. Here, content doesn't just go viral; if it crosses a line, it even faces a public trial.

"Ram-re-Ram, this month of *Jeth* is a true sinner!" someone sighed.
The government's tap-water scheme had indeed reached the village, but its limited morning and evening service could never quench the endless thirst of the women.

The maize crop was reaching its lush peak. Kari, Bhikhari, Aghori, and Phuleshri lounged along the field ridge, resting in lazy resignation. Kari was kneading *sattu* for the afternoon meal. Apart from this ease lived. Manjan, a wretched orphan boy, Bhikhari's nephew by loose thread of relation. He received two meals a day and four beatings to balance them. A free servant, a bonded labourer without chains under Bhikhari's shadow.

They are talking among themselves.
Sprinkling water over *sattu*, Kari voiced her worry, "What if Rama refuses to give water to us? Every day that husband and wife are at each other's throats. That Lajo is a haughty one. If she poisons Rama's ears against us, then?"
Bhikhari twirled his moustache and scoffed, "How will she poison his ears? I am his elder brother. At a single signal from me, he will kick aside a hundred Lajos' and drag them by their ear. The boring machine is coming tomorrow. Just watch how Rama gives us water. And if he throws too many tantrums, I Shall simply yell, 'Let half the tank cost be in my name and let the matter be settled.' Besides... since when does Rama have the gall to ask me for money?"

Even in poverty, Bhikhari carried a strange arrogance.

What a delightful irony. The pleasure of being an elder brother tasted sweeter than bread to him. First he thought of paying half, now he schemed to digest even that too. Slowly, Bhikhari had begun to treat Rama's pocket as his ancestral property.

Kari sighed coldly and muttered, "May God make your words true. My heart trembles otherwise. Let only tonight pass without Lajo creating a quarrel. I will happily bear all her old wounds if peace stays."

This was not the language of grace but the dialect of greed. Who knew whether after the water tank was set, the quarrels would cease, or whether an ocean of sudden affection would bloom in Kari's heart for Lajo.

The man and wife cooked their *litti* and *chokha*, for when it comes to straightening one's own owl, a man can sell not just his honesty but his entire own lineage along.

Mean time, Chhota Babu Ramprasad was in the condition of a gambler who, after losing everything, stakes even his shirt. The moment he began building a house on loan, it felt as though he had placed a grinding stone upon his own chest. First he hired nearby masons and labourers on contract, then shifted to daily wages. Money was limited water, and the house an endless blind well. He kept pouring money, yet the house merely was licking its foundation. A year had passed, and the end of work still looked like a distant mirage.

With due time doubt crept in. Were these masons and labourers deliberately lazy, merely stretching days? If the house finished early, would their livelihood not suffer? Rama gathered information everywhere, but nowhere did he find cheaper and faster labour. Finally, what has always happened in villages happened again. He called his two brothers-in-law. Both were professional masons.

Both came with their labour, reluctantly fulfilling relations but truly loyal to the evening liquor that they tore through Ramprasad's pocket daily. Every night they had to watch Rama and Lajo's quarrels, yet for a drunkard, even hell becomes a feast if the cup is filled.

Among them, the middle brother-in-law Brajmohan possessed some sense. The younger one, Jhumru, was dull-witted, a complete nonsense. Less work, more secret drinking, and expertly deceiving Ramprasad became his true profession.

From the moment Lajo learned that Rama intended to give water to her enemies, she began a daily dance of fury. She was like one possessed. Her tongue kept crying with curses while her body labored like an ox at the mill, yoked at all hours. She was the last to sleep and the first to rise, cooking for those wretches, scrubbing bricks, sifting sand, searching for tasks like a common laborer to speed the work along. Even when everyone else stopped, her toil continued: the nightly feast, the liquor, the snacks, everything was arranged by Lajo, single-handedly. And what she get in return, her nighttime wages were delivered in kicks. She pleaded and protested against giving away the water to her enemies, again she was paid for this too only with more violence. Her body seemed to have forgotten the meaning of pain, fatigue, or despair.
Sometimes, When she cried to Rama, "Find someone else who can do as much as I do!" Rama would retort, "I could bring a hired whore and she would do more than you!"

A salaried labourer cannot be abused, for he may leave. But a wife can be beaten and humiliated at will, for she is chained within the sacred bond, a free servant draped in the cloth of sanctity.

The poor woman became shameless in the struggle for her own rights, but Rama remained as stubborn as a mountain.

Amidst this, you might recall Phulki, that lisping girl. Lajo's youngest sister. At present, She was the wisest and the most modern of them all. To keep her veiled within four walls was a feat beyond any man's strength. Once a stuttering girl, she now silenced the most eloquent of critics. Married she was, but she was not built to be entombed in the ancient walls of her in-laws' home. She earned her own way and lived in a rented house. When Jhumru struck her, she did not swallow her pride like Lajo; she returned one blow with four. One evening, she told Lajo plainly: "When self-respect has died in this house, why live like a corpse? Take your children, pack your things, and catch the first morning train to me. We both sisters shall earn with pride and live with grace!"

Lajo followed. Spending the night in the company of Kashi and Tulsi's faces. How much money would it take to secure the future of her two grown children? Here, the drunkard was at least a government employee; even in death, he would leave behind a pension. She decided she would not take her children. She spent the night loving them with her eyes full of tears. At the first light of dawn, she began her restless packing. Tulsi woke and began to prepare, but Lajo stopped her, binding her with an oath; the girl had to stay. Only Lajo would leave.

From the outside, it seemed Rama did not care, but only the inner Rama knew the truth of his heart. Jhumru was swaying in search of his morning liquor. Brajmohan repeatedly pleading to Rama to stop Lajo, to use force if necessary; in this village society, a separation between husband and wife is a lifelong stain. A time would come when no one would even offer them water. How would old age pass? After twenty-five years of marriage, where would Rama find a new bride? He insisted that Rama give in to Lajo's demands. Nearby Lajo's crumpled sari revealed the unrest of her heart like a trembling flag of war.

Along time, there a room was less a chamber and more a brick grave

where Lajo had buried a piece of her own heart alive. The walls had no window, no vent; there was only a heavy wooden door behind which a mother had imprisoned her son. Kashi pounded the door from within, like a bird beating its chest against the bars of a cage. Tulsi begged with a choked voice to go along, but if love alone could secure a future, there would be no need for desperate oaths.

Standing at the door, Lajo told the weeping Kashi to take care of himself. Kashi's rage then intensified. He beat the door as if only one of them would survive the day. From behind the wood, he threatened Ramprasad with venomous curses: if his mother left the house today, he would burn Rama alive the moment the door broke. And if he could not burn him, he would set himself on fire. He would not spend a lifetime with such a spineless father.

Rama stood like a statue, listening. How could his children think such things? He believed Lajo was merely an illiterate shrew who knew only how to spit poison, but when his educated children began to think the same, he realized that perhaps he was the one in the wrong.

His family was shattering before his eyes: his wife was leaving, his son was thirsting for his father's blood, and he could see the naked hatred in his daughter's eyes. He realized then that Lajo was not just a wife; she was the soul of the house. Without their mother, his children would become strays. His liquor might slide down his throat now, but when death finally will caught in that same throat, there would be no one to look after him. He had been joining these pipes to keep the family together, yet if no one remained in his own new house to drink the water, what was the point of such a job or such a home?

In truth, having never spoken with love since the day of their wedding, he did not know how to become soft-spoken now.

Hence, he made Brajmohan the mediator, but Brajmohan refused, advising Rama to speak for himself. Hesitantly, Rama finally spoke the words: "The water will not be shared." Brajmohan then lectured Lajo on the ways and conducts of society. With broken hope, Lajo asked, "Why Rama, that your silence only breaks when everything is about to shatter?"

When the families civil clash, shettle down; The boring truck halts at Rama's mansion. And the case study begins.. It was nearly ten in the morning, but the faces of the people looked as twelve of midnight. Every heart raced like a locomotive. The boring had reached a hundred feet deep, yet not a single drop of water had emerged. A fear gripped them all that a minor error might lead to a total disaster. To imagine the water not coming was an ill omen. In her desperation, Lajo had even promised a sacrificial goat to Mother Ganga. Until the water struck, Kari sat huddled on the doorstep like a coiled serpent. Today, she had performed a miracle; whenever a tool was missing for the boring, she produced it from her own hidden breast. Ancestral shovels, axes, pickaxes, and who knows what else. On the day of the family partition, she had claimed that everything had been sold.

"Narayan Babu sold everything long ago," she said. But today, suddenly, everything had been 'bought back.' Everyone knew, what's actually the case was. At last, the boring was complete, and Mother Ganga revealed herself a hundred and fifty feet below the earth. A wave of water hit the ground, and a wave of joy hit their faces. Kari was nearly leaping as she congratulated Rama. Lajo's trembling heart found peace; her eyes filled as she thanked the Goddess of Thirst. She was merely waiting now for the moment Rama would refuse the water to his brother, for the moment a metaphorical slap would land on those greedy faces. Evening fell, and Rama spoke not a word of the pipes to Bhikhari.

The very next day, the boring was plastered over, as if Rama had placed a

permanent seal on his decision. He had still mentioned no pipes to Bhikhu. Finally, impatient Bhikhari asked Rama, "Are you forgetting something?" Rama replied simply, "No."
"Come, let us divide the cost and the water half-and-half," Bhikhari pressed.
"Ask Lajo!" was all Rama said.
That was the very moment, The look on the faces of Bhikhari and Kari was a sight to behold. It was as if someone had padlocked the gates of a free soup kitchen just as they were about to enter. They lacked the means to commission their own boring, and in all their lives, they had never seen a well a hundred and fifty feet deep.

It is for days like these that a government job is a blessing! For the Bhikhu and his wife, Kari the night was poisonous and stony. In their house, it was not the stove that burned, but the very envy. But upon Lajo's scorched heart, for the first time, a cool stream of the Ganges was flowing. While Rama had once tried to bring love between the families, the venom only deepened deep now.

After then What, see the Big Boss, Lajo would run the motor in a way of showing off, flexing flashily, whenever Kari went for drawing water from the well. watching Lajo, Kari would slam her bucket at the well in bitter resentment. This first taste of success breathed immense life into Lajo. She began to immerse herself in her work with a new fervor, unaware that through this excessive labor, a grave illness was beginning to tighten its grip upon her.

Between the blooming of the maize and the fraying of relationships, the arrival of water was not just the quenching of thirst; it was the laying of a sharp and treacherous chessboard for a family war. After months of bone-breaking labor and heavy struggle, the house finally stood complete.

It was a house where, if one were to even lightly scratch the surface, the lime and cement would come crumbling down. Rama had to take a second loan, yet the house remained shallow and frail.

This was because he listened to everyone's advice and tested everyone's wisdom. Walls were raised and then razed; features were broken and rebuilt. In the end, what remained was a house that was a sight to behold. Yes. There is no satire here. Looking at the house simply stirred a strange sense of pity, for because, at just the right a side there stood Bhikhari's ruin. It looked as if heaven and hell were joined in a singular, awkward union. Like silk stitched to sackcloth, like a gold coin clutched in a soot-stained hand. and so on, and so forth.

***

20. She is upset... yet, it suits her so!

'Though miles stretch between us, in my solitude, you remain; you are that perfect story for which words feel too plain.'

Kashi's vagabond heart has stumbled thrice already, yet since when do heartbeats heed reason? Like a restless squirrel, it simply hops from branch to branch, seeking nothing but a moment's amusement. In the last poetic tale, Chapter Sixteen, that wandering bumblebee was none other than Kashi himself, and that butterfly was his third blooming garden, plucked away by its rightful gardener. And when a garden is that lively and lovely, can the gardener truly be blamed for taking a flower? Why is it like that, the one you long for never longs for you, and the one who longs for you never stirs your longing? Amid such tangled questions and silent sighs, Kashi too now floats in the same ache.

Looking at his love triangles and romantic geometry thus far, Kashi's arithmetic of affection concludes one thing only: the famed 'sweets of love' was never meant for his tongue. Else how could that third garden, after showing such insane loyalty, suddenly departed? It seemed Kashi would rather face a noose than enter the carnival of love again. For just as a tiny dewdrop clings to a jasmine vine, shimmering like a pearl in the mellow sunlight, gifting a pure and pleasing beauty, yet the very moment you try to hold it, it slips without a sound, so too is attraction for Kashi. From afar, it enchants; up close, it escapes. And yet, these theories look graceful only in books. In real life, the boat named heart rocks with the current and insists on drifting, whether the river be sacred Ganga or a murky drain.

Still, tightening the knot of his inner ache. Now, He, Kashi makes a stern vow: He will not love again. Although that seems bit rude, but who knows what Comes, what may. Let us see what this Himalayan like decision within his humble heart brings: whether a thunderous roar or a hollow silence.

While Kashi, tangled in deep questions, merely passes his days, on the same stage there exists a bird who is quietly distributing her heart. To describe her is to read a dusky, melodic poem. The carving of her face feels as though destiny sculpted it in leisure, like a fine Ajanta masterpiece, so intricate and emotive that the eyes refuse to turn away, as if the full moon were peeking through a veil of clouds. Her lotus eyes were not merely eyes but fathomless lakes of a new moon night, where one glance may drown the very sense of self like a boat trapped in a whirlpool.

Those light curls dancing upon her forehead resemble silky labyrinth threads, crafted solely to entangle logic and steal composure of the beholder. She was the mistress of a slender frame, delicate as a rose stalk, yet her charm is sharp as a naked sword drawn from its sheath, beautiful and perilous alike. With a voice like a koel's soft call and the playful quickness of a parrot, when she began to speak, she possessed the listener like a draught of fine wine. It was as if a ceaseless river of words had burst forth. Just as a parrot has the habit of continuous chatter and a love for green chilies, 'Preksha' possessed an obsession for spicy food and an intoxicating addiction to conversation. When she spoke, one lost track of time and self; her words were as zesty as those chilies, leaving the listener craving for of one more bite.

In short, Preksha is a dusky riddle, one that is more delightful to remain tangled in, than to be solved. And perhaps that is what love truly mean: where you do not try to understand it but to live it.

Preksha does not care what films have played in the background of Kashi's past. She does not care whether he is reserved or expressive, principled or carefree, intense or pretentious, a dream-cook of castles in air or a humble simmerer of lentils. Somehow, unknowingly, she has fallen into her first love, sudden and sincere, the kind that blooms in a single breath. In the flower of her heart, a tiny anklet chimes all day in one-sided rhythm. though sadly, they are not in the same class. Thus, the school recess was the only window of time to wash her eyes with the sight of him. The second recess at school is a glorious time; it is when every pigeon passes by the door of his mate. But when love is one-sided, the difficulties mount, as they did for Preksha.

Every day during recess, Kashi washes his lifeless face with water, and that very moment becomes the one in which Preksha washes her eager eyes with the sight of him. Just for a fleeting second. Then he passes like a gust of air beside her, brushing past her without a single glance. They say Kashi walks like a robot, unaware of right or left. Yet, as said before, Preksha does not care. She waits all day for recess and spends the entire night studying Kashi's Instagram profile, with such devotion that if there existed a degree beyond a PhD, she would pursue it with ease, provided that degree were Kashi himself. She does nothing but little, merely making him aware of her presence like a gentle tide: liking stories, liking notes, expressing opinions on things he posts.

When inclination grew from little to large, when presence came from near to nearer, their small, restrained exchanges turned into a chain of unrestrained talks. The moment Kashi replied to her messages, she would instantly appear online.
Kashi would ask, "Do you stay online all day?"
Preksha replied, "When am I ever offline?"
Kashi: "And studies?"
Preksha: "They some how gets done!"

This time, Kashi has not forgotten his decision. He does not wish to return to his old state, no matter whether Preksha resembles those girls or not. He never showed any eagerness to talk to her, though he never let her feel it so. Whenever Preksha thought he was finally hers, Kashi would subtly distance himself, avoiding conversations. He had understood the feeling of her love and wished to crush the tale before it even have Began. He feared the same fate that had always found him; he feared the shattering of the heart before it had even joined. He brought this fear to life one night like a living nightmare. The conversation went on for hours, and before Kashi could even hear her heart's confession, he said, "If you choose friendship, we shall walk together forever; if you choose love, we shall part very soon." Preksha objected; there was no logic in the idea that love leads to parting. When the instrument and the voice are in harmony, how can the music be discordant?

She replied in turn, "If this bond ever breaks, you will be the one to leave first." Kashi protested inwardly. He had never left any bond. In truth, he was the one people always left. He was entirely certain he would never be the first to walk away. Yet he made a prophecy, "A time will come when neither you will block me nor I you, yet we will not be speaking to one another." To Preksha, everything seemed simple. She was ready to fight any circumstance, as long as that circumstance was not Kashi himself.

In this story of love, there was no romantic triangle or square but only a seed of 'fear' that kept rooting deeper and deeper into Kashi's heart. At every time he kept thinking: where is Preksha and where am I? At times he believed she might never understand his inner tides. And the third whisper remained constant: "What if she too leaves me?" One night, after many words, After a few exchanges, he wrote a long, exhaustive farewell letter and sent it. At the end of that letter, he writes,
"After losing you, I look for someone just like you."
In return, he received only a brief message:

"May you surely find someone better than me, but may you never find anyone like me."

And from that very edge, Kashi's prophecy came true. Both were free to speak, yet neither was saying a word. Kashi stood stubborn on his principles, She made every effort: writing poems in her notes and stories, sharing her photographs, trying through both vulnerability and beauty to convince Kashi that his decision was unjust. This silent effort stretched their wings for nearly two months. Finally, Kashi messaged her again under a pretext. At that time, Kashi was surrounded by people who were all "love-birds," while he alone remained buried in books like a monk. Solitude began to bite him. He needed a companion who would also listen to him. "When everyone else is talking, why have I taken this vow of silence? When we part, we part, but why should I ruin today for the sake of tomorrow?" With this thought, he reached out to Preksha a second time. Kashi, who had only ever been a listener, now needed someone to listen to him.

But Preksha was famous for her talkativeness. During their talks, She would repeat same thing fifty times. Kashi would listen with great appetite and interest, but the moment Kashi began to say something, suddenly her mother would arrive, or her uncle, or her sister, or a monkey, or birds, or even a distant thief would magically appear in her awareness. And when he said nothing, silence began to trouble her. Like a child who complains about everything. Her liveliness and his stillness kept colliding again and again.

For Kashi, she slowly became like a bone stuck in his throat. He had invited trouble by returning. He could neither say, "Listen to me too," nor could he say, "Be quiet." Thus the bond merely appeared two-sided while turning one-sided again. Had Kashi been an AI, perhaps he could have listened all day. Alas, he was a human, and humans have mouths too.

How long can the bullock cart of love be dragged on one wheel alone? Therefore, One Sunday he decided, if this time I am not heard, then I shall not return at any cost. Fear of heartbreak or fear of being abandoned, whatever it may be. When Kashi extended his hand again, he was no hunter chasing selfish gain. He was a traveller dying of thirst in a desert, fully aware that the water ahead might be a mirage, yet wishing to attempt one last sip before collapsing. Seeking Preksha was not his strength. It was his greatest weakness.

With Kashi's sensitive temperament, exactly what he feared came to pass. Preksha did not know what Kashi had resolved; she was simply who she was. And so, it happened: Preksha did not listen to Kashi. And that was what all needed: Kashi hung up the phone. She offered excuses, claiming she was indeed listening, for she did not know what true listening meant. And as that saying goes: "Test the gold with patience and thrice, but test a man only once with wise." Once more, and forever, the two became islands. The prophecy remained in effect. No one took the initiative to speak. Both were fighting an internal war, yet neither would bridge the gap. Be it resentment or attraction, be it mercy or a grievance, be it the sacred or the mundane, damn it all, but no one was either willing to speak it first.

'In the pride of love, neither you won nor I lost;
I lost you, and for you I was lost.'

This time, no one left and no one gained; it was only the 'fear' of being left that spoiled the entire endeavor. Kashi did not know if he was right or wrong. He simply believed that living life with someone who neither listens nor understands is a nightmare, worse than the worst. It may be possible that in the time to come, Preksha might become exactly what Kashi wanted, or perhaps something he could never wish. The future is unknown, but now, she has started to remain quiet. She has started to

listen to others, listening so much that she started listening to anyone, in the hope that if Kashi returns a third time, he finds her exactly as he wished.

Whenever Kashi grew restless to be heard by Preksha, he ended up hurting himself the most. He would fall in his own eyes. He wanted to embrace Preksha, to listen to her heart's content, but the screams of his past failures were so loud in his mind that he could not hear Preksha's soft voice. He was a prisoner of a cage of his own making; he had the key, but he had grown terrified of the open air now.

Its known that months or years, will pass, Kashi will hardly forget a story of such tangy, tempered and textured love. But one thing is certain: because of his fear, he will never be able to love anyone again. He did not break the bond because he lacked love; he broke it because he knew he was an empty well that would swallow Preksha's boundless energy and words. He set Preksha free from himself so she could 'chirp' with someone who could give her what Kashi no longer possessed:

'a living heart.'

***

In the crimson hush of evening's glow, Kashi sat on the lowest step of Horlicks, writing something really slow:

She is upset…yet, it suits her so.
When dusk descends and my tears blends
With the echoes of your distant call,
Perhaps somewhere, on some lonely evening,
You too sit and weep, remembering it all.
What more can I say? To meet you now feels wrong,
Maybe another soul in your heart now belong.
She is upset… yet, it suits her so.

Was it the sorrow of you, or the fear of your loss?
Of being yours, or becoming you at a cost?
Let it be now. What's done is done,
It was my fear that made me run.
Sometimes I wonder, had you been the same,
Would you have been my angel in name?
Strang you makes my heart both dry and glow,
She is upset… yet, it suits her so.

I do not ask how you are. Nor I wish to hear,
Why should I, when your memory draws me near?
In having you, my heart aches and dies,
In longing for you, it restlessly flies.
Better. Perhaps. Had we never met at all,
Yet the heart still sighs at your silent call.
You are my poison, yet my only cure I know,
She is upset… yet, it suits her so.

21. Deep within the depths, the seeker finds the pearl!

All at once, the wind changed its will. The scorching breath that had been burning backs for an entire month suddenly stilled, as if tired of its own tyranny. From the western corner, where till now only dust had wandered like a homeless soul, a dark mass of clouds began to gather, draped in a dreadful silence that strangely roared.

In the blink of an eye, that dark mass of cloud spread overran the sky like a marching army. The sun rolled helplessly within the folds of clouds, as though defeated in a celestial wrestle. And then came that scent, the very fragrance, a farmer's nose waits for all year long, the sacred smell was the earthen musk of the first drop that kisses the thirsty soil. It is not merely a smell. It is the perfume of a new life.

And the second intent, where firs had soft tapping sounds, now turned to fat drops, which began falling upon the dust. Wherever a drop touched, a tiny fountain of dust rose, danced briefly, and dissolved into the very cosmos. The earth, cracked from thirst, lay split open in places like the wrinkled skin of an old soul stripped bare by time. The dry intestines of the land seemed eager to drink the nectar of rain and quench a thirst of centuries. The earthy aroma rising from the soil felt like a deep burp of satisfaction after ages of deprivation. And then, as the saying goes, the heavens broke their dam. The skies gave way, and the rain began to pour in a rhythmic, roaring rush.

A lively stir rippled through the village. Children, who had been rotting inside homes turned into summer prisons, ran out naked and freshly reborn, splashing, jumping, and laughing in wild delight.

Their laughter rivaled the whispering rhythm of the rain. Dust washed away from the leaves of trees. The *koel* upon the mango tree began to sing. Dogs, who had been panting with their tongues out, now wagged their tails and joined the flowing streams with curious excitement. Cattle, once restless from thirst, now seemed to attain a holy ablution under the rain's blessing. The rain grew fiercer. Streams began to gallop from the thatched roofs. Rivers, rivulets, ponds, and puddles were reborn, their waves rose like revived spirits.

By the next quarter of the day, in that damp afternoon, the world as far as the eye could see was a shimmering mirror. The village lay soaked, looking like the celestial river Ganges had descended to earth. The sky had burst open as though settling accounts of years in a single day.
"When the fields had already turned to ash, what worth were the clouds even if they arrived?"

While children were living their childhood in the downpour, Manjan was sent to cut the embankment so that water could enter the fields and breathe life into the crops. Loss was never a habit of Kari. Even if Manjan wore his ribs thin in the task, it was considered no real loss.

While time grew older, the rain's fury turned even more ferocious. As if rain alone was not enough to stir storms in life, hailstones too began to fall, crackling sharply thud-thud-thud-thud. The gusts of wind and the blows of hail striking the wooden doors created a groan, like a sorrowful spirit begging to be let inside for a roof.

Raindrops hitting the solid roof sounded like drums in a wild orchestra. The second quarter of the day already felt like dead midnight. For the homeless and helpless, it was calamity. For those with concrete houses, it was the pinnacle of natural beauty.

To sit by a window with a steaming cup of ginger tea while the rain lashes outside is to feel time itself stand still. One gulps the tea, tucks into a blanket, and sprawls across the bed; surely even their dreams would be arriving soft and tender. In the ground floor room, Bada Babu, Ramprasad, slept alone. At his beside, a dim old lamp flickered beside his pillow. The concrete house built last year was the debt of his entire lifetime, a monument of his honesty. While the room at the roof, along with Kashi and Tulsi, the ailing Lajwanti slept in it, a drugged and a deep sleep.

Ramprasad tossed and turned. drowned in the depths of his thoughts. Sleep refused to embrace him. Outside, the rain roared, but within his ears echoed the cries of bygone era, the struggles that such rains once dragged into life like unwelcome guests. He turned again. Yes, there was relief that his children were safe upstairs, the roof stronger, no fear of leaks. Only gentle sprays entered through window's corners, sweet and harmless. Gone were those nights when mud walls collapsed overnight or thatched roofs wept endlessly, forcing buckets to stand guard. Those days were gone, Bada Babu had at the very least, managed to outrun that kind of poverty.

Yet, even within strong walls, a fear haunted Rama. A fear that could turn the living into lifeless in a blink. A fear that denied him even the chance for penance. A thin film of tears clouded his eyes, he feared losing Lajwanti. Behind his lids, a montage of the past played out. He remembered everything that would have been impossible without Lajo's silent struggle. Even after nearly twenty seven years of marriage, she remained the same tireless, ascetic, homemaker. In return she received only harsh and violent disdain, yet somehow the bond endured. She lived a jagged, decaying life through sheer self reliance. But for how long? How long can an ox tied to the mill grind alone without support?

How long would selfless, loveless Lajo remain a symbol of divinity? Was this lingering, chronic fever - *Miyadi bukhar* the very Mother Earth come to pull Lajo away from Rama into her final embrace?

Rama wrapped the blanket and sighed deeply, staring at the falling rain as if it were not water but the flowing river of time itself. "Will I be left alone then? Will Lajo leave us all and go? Were these painful days all that were written in her destiny? How do I tell her? How do I say, 'Forgive me'? I do not want to be alone. What will be felt on children? What of that stubborn bull of a son? What about my flower like Tulsi? How can she leave me like this? Does she think she alone has the right to all noble deeds? Does she alone own the right to swallow every sorrow?"

"No. She must get well! I will make her well! You made me the vessel of her pain, didn't You, Hey Raam? Now see how I keep her from every ache! I will give her only happiness, You shall see. You shall see."

Bound by the chains of sharp agony and regret, forty five year old Ramprasad, a man firm and unyielding in principles, suddenly melted like stone turned wax and began to weep. What right had he to apply balm after dealing the wound? What right had he to share his grief with a body already on its deathbed? Who was he to decide who stays and who goes? Even if his shameful tears flowed, could they ever hope to reflect even a fraction of the ocean of tears Lajo had shed? Even if his heart felt the weight of his sins, would Lajo's worn, calloused hands ever find it in them to forgive him? So what if his heart stung? So what if his chest tightened? How could Lajo's wounds, her bruises, her tortures, and her mental agonies simply dissolve into the puddle of Rama's belated regret?

Tortured by these rare, decades old memories, Ramprasad fell asleep with two thin trails of tears escaping the corners of his eyes.

Those tears were not like the monsoon rain; but were like the moisture that seeps from the cracks of a parched, sun-baked barren land. The earth does not scream; it simply cracks in silence. Rama's heart cracked the same way tonight. At his bedside, the green lamp drank the last of its oil and surrendered by sleeping to the dark.

Outside, the season was still seasoning. It is known that, Rain is the perhaps, nature of nature itself, reopening buried wounds and making them fresh and difficult. Like a lover who stays awake all night remembering his beloved, hiding tears within raindrops. Like a distant boatman battling waves in hope of meeting his fisherwoman some day. Like moonlight that knows it has no light of its own yet spends a lifetime reflecting the moon. It is how a river, knowing she has no union with the shore and that her destiny is the mouth of the sea, still flows, washing the feet of the banks as she passes. This rainy season is no mere a season. It is the charioteer of love. The charioteer of love.

In a tormented heart, what sleep, what peace? After an hour of fitful rest, Ramprasad rose and stood by the window with trembling steps. The darkness outside was so thick that one could not see their own hand. Only in the flash of lightning was the village revealed for a heartbeat: drowned fields, shivering trees, and somewhere far off, the collapsing wall of a poor man's shack. Ramprasad's mind was like a bubble, sinking and surfacing on the water. He thought, "This concrete house can save me from the wrath of the rain, but how can it save me from the regret I feel now for Lajo?"

Just then came a cough sound from upstairs. Perhaps Lajo had awakened. Ramprasad inhaled deeply and prayed silently that the rain would cease now. He could no longer bear these suppressed, crushed wounds. He picked up the copper pot beneath his plank, drank two sips of water, and went toward the toilet beside the kitchen.

at the far end, to the right, reached after climbing a small step. A pair of rubber slippers rested behind the partition. And behind the slipper placed there, coiled like a chessboard pattern of dark spots upon olive green, with two black streaks beneath its eyes like smeared kohl, sat a snub-nosed serpent! Round snout, bulging eyes. Enough space under the main door for ten such snakes to slip in. It must be said: since childhood, Rama's greatest fear had been snakes.

Dazed and depressed, Rama had no idea who sat behind the slippers he just stepped into! Minutes later, when he finished and stepped out, his eyes fell upon the snake. In that instant, His entire body shuddered. All his depression turned into sweat and slipped off him. All his flowery thoughts burned into a bitter ash. At that moment, Lajo came down to make tea for Rama, calling out as she moved toward the latrine.

"Don't come here, Lajo! Don't come this way! Here is a snake! Call Bhikhu Bhaiya, quickly!"

The fact, in the entire clan, only two men were brave enough to exorcise the ghost of a venomous snake. The first was the late Dhanpat Rai. The second was the living Bhikhari Rai.

A door had been placed near the kitchen that opened directly into Bhikhu's hell; an emergency gate for both families. Lajo threw it open for the first time. There stood Phuleshri, bailing water from the alley. "Ay! Phulwa, send Bhikhu Bhaiya quickly! He is trapped in the bathroom, there's a snake here! It might bite him! Go, fast!"

Sensing the gravity of the moment, Phuleshri ran to the front room, the guard chamber of Kari and Bhikhari. The moment Bhikhu heard his younger brother was in danger, he very well knew Rama's lifelong terror

of snakes. He grabbed his sharp spear without wasting a breath and rushed.

"Will you save the man who killed us for water?" The words belonged to Kari. She sat by the embers, her eyes filled with a low, hateful fire, now crossing even the thin line of humanity. Let him die if he must, but he must fulfill my spite first. she thought,

"What has he ever done for you that you would save his life?"

"Sit. Let your silence be the stone that seals his tomb." The command of *Queen Kaikeyi* - Kari was obeyed.

Bhikhu sat back, paralyzed, as if he had just strangled his own brother with his bare hands.

"Bhaiya! Bhaiya!"

Lajo, drenched in rain, screamed madly at Bhikhu's door. Been a while but no answer came up. She understood in that very intent. Why was she knocking at a door of them who were never truly theirs? She ran farther and reached Pankaj Bhaiya, a man who respected Lajo. Sitting nearby, sipping tea, was Musho Nauaa, Barber by profession, Rama's protector in action. He carried a birth born enmity toward snakes, for he had lost his own mother to a snake bite. Since then, he killed snakes freely, without fee, without fear. Both men grabbed staves and spear and rushed to the scene. Musho did not waste a blink. without a second thought, Musho in the first heartbeat aimed for the small, elusive target. The stave swung. In the next heartbeat, the snake's kohl-rimmed eyes burst out; Musho crushed its mouth to pulp.

Breath returned to Rama's chest. Once again, Lajo's quiet magic prevailed, and Rama became even more of a devoted to her. After exchanging a few words, Musho and Pankaj returned home.

Lajo spoke softly yet voice trembling,

"You were always there for them, and today, when you needed them, they bolted the door. Why won't you see? They can never be ours. If something had happened to you... where would a fool like me have run carrying you?"

Saying this, she clutched her veil and began to weep. Her words pricked Rama's heart like thorns. Her moist eyes made him tremble. His own eyes welled up. He wiped Lajo's tears and said,
"Stay here. I'll just be back."
"Where are you going?" Lajo asked, uncertain.
"To demand the account of my goodness."
In one of Rama's eyes, there was a tender love for Lajo; in the other, dark pull of disgust burning hatred for Bhikhu.

Rama stepped out. Lajo rushed to wake Kashi and Tulsi. In case of a clash, What is a clash without comrades? The entire tale was told in brief, and rage like Rudra's fire began to run in their veins. Today, not defeat but death would be served to the wicked. All advanced toward that living hell.

Rama, his eyes burning with the heat of his inner turmoil, vented his agony.
"Are you a brother or a 'scoundrel'? Does such a brother even exist? Has hatred grown so much that you wouldn't save your own blood? Tell me, what did I lack? Whenever you called, I came. Today, when I needed you, you hid in your woman's lap?"
"Watch your tongue, Rama! Don't forget I am your elder brother," Bhikhu blustered.
"I didn't forget! That's why I called for you! But you. There is a limit even to being a scoundrel! I didn't expect this from you!" Rama lashed out. Just then, Aghori jumped into the fray.

"Watch who you're talking to and whose door you're standing at, Kaka. Don't make me do something that makes Kaki..."
"Stay in your pants, Aghori! I am talking to your father, not you. Unless, of course, you've become your father's father, then speak..." Rama's words sealed that gay's throat. But what shield is there against I you are shameless?
"How dare you call my father a scoundrel?" Aghori burst his seams. Stepped out of his pants. Bhikhu found his excuse to strike back, "Yes! Tell me, how did you call me a scoundrel?"

"How can I not? You are my brother; you should have forgotten a woman's grudge and done your duty. You know how much I fear snakes, yet you didn't come; if this isn't scoundrelry, what is?" Rama was shaken, for whom she had so far illtreated his own family, seeing how Bhikhu spoke with such cold detachment.
"I don't know about all that! How did you curse me? Who are you to curse me?" Bhikhu remained stubborn.

"What are you saying? I am your brother! I have every right to scold you! Does your pride matter more than my blood?" This time, Rama was falling apart.
"Yes!" Bhikhu replied without hesitation.
"Am I nothing to you?" Rama's final blow of patience.
"Nothing!" Bhikhu snapped. When doom befalls a man, wisdom dies first. Bhikhu did not know what he was about to lose.

"Fine! Then it is for the best, Bhikhari! Now you will see what Rama is made of." His nose was cold from the rain, but his voice was iron. "Come, Lajo! Let's go. There is nothing left to say; it has all been washed away in this rain. I have ended the very relationship. Let's go inside and have a fine tea. Come, Kashi! Tulsi, come, my child. Let's go."

The first glimpse of 'what Rama is made of' happened that very moment. For ten years Rama had been giving Bhikhu electricity free of cost. He cut the wire. The ruin truly began to feel like hell in that drenched darkness. Bhikhari could not even light his ganja in the pitch black night, the craving for which made his mind spin even further. Worse still, the gas cylinder emptied that very day. Gas was always arranged by Rama. That he was betrayed. Now How would the stove burn? How would the food be cooked? Darkness was already a another piercing thing

Behind the house, on Rajeshri's land, Aghori's wife, Phuleshri, was making a futile attempt to blow fire into a sodden stove with damp wood. Smoke filled her eyes with tears, while the household burned within with irritation. She sobbed softly, and the waves of unrest rippled through every heart.

Somehow the night passed with dry *sattu*. As if that was least enough, Aghori now ran circling to gas agencies and electricity offices. Such effort was unbearable, Hence Bhikhu suddenly looked like an old man. Aghori became the new master of the house, and with power, his vices became unmasked. He began returning late at night, drunk to the brim on local liquor. Everything of their household was traumatized in a week.

Lajo would watch the theater of their misery from her balcony, sipping tea, laughing and gloating. Seeing this, Bhikhu grew even more deranged. He began searching for a way, any way, to hurt Lajo and wound Rama. The opportunity came swiftly. He called Rajeshri and proposed, "Give me the backyard land, and in turn keep the roadside land of mine."
For Rajeshri, it was pure profit. "Everything is yours, Bhaiya. As you say."

The very next day, Bhikhari stayed home with his family. Rama left for office as usual, and Kashi for school. Around noon, like a thief, a woodcutter arrived. His name was Kedar Jadav.

Short in stature, stiff moustache, and a habit of spitting at every sentence. his face was the kind you'd want to spit on him, but I digress. The sound of the saw reached Lajo's ears. Confused, she climbed to the terrace and saw the limbs of 'Horlicks' being severed. She ran down with Tulsi. Bhikhu and his family blocked her path. Despite Lajo's desperate struggles, one by one, the raw branches of Horlicks, heavy with clusters of mangoes, were hacked away. It felt as though the stomach of a living infant had been ripped open, its veins and arteries torn out while it still breathed.

At last, after everything was stripped, the saw bit into the trunk. The merciless blade felled the heart of the tree in moments. Horlicks died, but the life fled from Lajo's body. She screamed and threw herself onto the fallen trunk. Her third and tallest child was dying before her eyes. The Horlicks was sawn by Kashi but was nurtured by Lajo day and night to let him thrive. Kari and Bhikhu felt a supreme, monstrous satisfaction, as if this unholy act had given their lives meaning. "Clear away these fruits and wood quickly; I want to build a new house here!" As he left, Bhikhu spat venom on Lajo's wound. Tulsi just stood there, holding her mother, staring at the trunk. They had grown up together, and today, he had left her, uprooted. Both mother and daughter began collecting the bones of Horlicks, preserving memories piece by piece.

They say a fruit-bearing tree should never be cut; they only just say, no one follows it. Two hours later, Kashi came home on his cycle. Every day, he would look for the leafy branches of his brother Horlicks, but today, he saw only the empty sky. He collapsed right there. He ran to the backyard. What did he see? The scattered bones, veins, and limbs of Horlicks everywhere. Clusters of raw and ripe mangoes lay strewn about; the whole garden seemed to have died in mourning. Nearby, the guava tree, the papaya trees, and the greens were all trampled; their fruit rotted, smelling of death was what all around in the air.

Kashi looked at Lajo with desolate eyes. Lajo, holding the 'bones' in her hands, looked back at him with helpless despair. He dragged himself toward her. "What is this, Ma?"

"It's all over, Kashi. Your brother is gone. My son is gone. Those scoundrels killed your Horlicks! They killed my son!" Lajo was sick and weak; she had no strength left but to weep. But cold Kashi was still Hot-blooded. He went straight for his staff. And shouted "You scoundrel Bhikhari! Come out! Or I shall stone your house to the ground!" "Why are you barking, you dwarf? It's my land, my will! Go cry with your mother and gather the wood! Get out of my face!" Aghori extinguished the fire before it could even blaze.

What was remained now? When the land is no longer yours, how can the flower belong to you? The entire Rama family was filled with despair. Collecting the remains of Horlicks. What does it feel like when you find your own kin dead and gather their torn limbs, head, and torso? Every broken piece you lift shatters a piece of your own soul too. Every dead fragment you collect kills you to your throat. The weight of thick branches makes your very existence stagger. It pierces you, it refines you in fire like molten cage of grief. Why are you even alive, if you could not save your own? When you lift the trunk, you feel how shallow your own heart is. When you touch the white sap of the tree, smell it, its fragrance has a perfume distilled from its very soul. Then you understand the agony of a consciousness that dies silently under cruelty.

In the future of the dead, there remains only a deep well of memories, where the seeker sinks and surfaces repeatedly. At night, Rama returned home and called Raje. It was confirmed. The land had been exchanged. This time, he had nothing in his hands except the duty to support his grief stricken family.

.

While the family sat together in mourning, there Kashi sat apart from them on the terrace, on a raised cemented chair covering iron pillar rods. In the screaming silence of night, he stared fixedly at a tiny, innocent mango sapling: The offspring of Horlicks. A delicate, tender thing with only two leaves. In his grieving heart, he had given that infant a home in a small tin box. Tonight was that same moonlight that makes wounds visible, but the garden was a ruin. Through the heart-wrenching pain, Kashi watched the moon. From the corners of his eyes, a gentle rain of tears began to fall.

Deep in his heart, on some distant horizon, a rainbow must be scattering its seven colors. The place where he had cherished dreams of growing up with Horlicks. How could he accept that the one who lived through his darkest days had left without a final farewell? How could he console himself? How could he believe that Horlicks' presence was now just a breeze, keeping his loneliness accompanied?

In constant glance and grief, Above him, the sky continued its relentless downpour. The croaking of frogs and the chirping of crickets making the silence even more terrifying. In Kashi's hand was a damp white notebook and a pen. With shivering, frozen hands, he wrote upon it:

"Aam Zindagi."

(The curtain falls.)

***



Gratitude.

In the quiet solitude of my writing journey, my sister, Aastha Kumari, was my first reader and my clearest mirror. She embraced the courage of my pen without measure. She did not merely refine my words, but stood by me as a guide, a hope, and a quiet admirer at every pages. With honesty and without hesitation, she revealed my flaws, saw my strengths, and gently held my dreams. In truth, this novel is not only mine, but also the fruit of her unwavering faith.

I am equally grateful to my elderly village friends, whose stories lent a rustic warmth to these pages, their words flowing like ink into my pen. And to my Mother, whose griefs and lived wisdom shaped my understanding of her divinity; in listening to her, I often forgot I was writing, sometimes even losing myself in tears.

To every soul who unknowingly added a word of joy or sorrow to these pages: thank you. I offer my heartfelt thanks to all of them. without the support of these people, the conception of this novel would have remained nothing more than an imagined vision.

Above all, I thank you, dear reader, who, in today's fast-paced life, chose to read about Aam Zindagi. And, in doing so, became a priceless part of mine. It is you who have kept literature alive behind the pages. I am deeply grateful. You are the heartbeat of literature.

Fare the Well!.

